

CITY: PG 3

CM Rekha Gupta flags off 300 new EV buses to boost public transport



NATION: PG 5

Congress fires salvo over LPG crisis



FILM: PG 14

'Taking things step by step'



Rupee crashes to all-time low of 93.53/dollar

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: The Indian rupee tumbled to a record closing low against the US dollar on Friday, as persistent foreign fund outflows and elevated crude oil prices weighed heavily on sentiment amid ongoing geopolitical tensions.

The local currency dropped 64 paise to settle at 93.53 per dollar, after opening at 92.92 in the interbank foreign exchange market. It breached the 93 level for the first time during the session and extended losses throughout the day. The previous record low of 92.89 was recorded on Wednesday, when the rupee had declined 49 paise. Forex markets were closed on Thursday for Gudhi Padwa.

Traders said rising crude oil prices and a broader shift toward risk aversion have intensified pressure on the rupee. "Surging energy costs and geopolitical uncertainty

Continued on P4

WAR TOLL RISES: OVER 1,300 DEAD IN IRAN; 15 IN ISRAEL

Iran hits Kuwaiti oil refinery as Israel renews attacks on Tehran



Iranians attend the funeral procession of Iran's intelligence minister Esmail Khatib in Tehran Emirates

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: A Kuwaiti oil refinery came under Iranian drone attack early Friday, and sirens in Israel warned of incoming fire, while explosions boomed over Tehran from Israeli strikes as the country marked the Persian New Year.

The war that has rocked the global economy neared the end of its third week, with Iran showing no signs of letting up on its attacks on Gulf region energy structures. Kuwait said two waves of drone strikes at its Mina Al-Ahmadi oil refinery sparked a fire and crews were working to control the blaze.

The refinery, which can process some 730,000 barrels of oil per day, was already damaged Thursday in another Iranian attack. It is one of three oil refineries in Kuwait, a tiny, oil-rich nation on the Persian Gulf.

Iran stepped up its attacks on energy sites in Gulf Arab states after Israel on Wednesday bombed Iran's massive South Pars offshore natural gas field in the Persian Gulf.

Loud explosions could also be heard in Jerusalem after the Israeli

- HIGHLIGHTS**
- » New Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei vows enemies will lose "security" amid escalating conflict
 - » Iran's Revolutionary Guard says Tehran still building missiles, war will go on
 - » Indian national killed in Saudi Arabia due to 'recent events of March 18'
 - » 'Fits Netanyahu's status as war criminal': Iran on Israeli PM's 'praise' for Genghis Khan
 - » ISRAELI MILITARY SAYS STRIKING IRANIAN REGION ON CASPIAN SEA

'COWARDS': Trump slams allies for refusing support against Iran

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump lashed out at America's allies, branding them "cowards" for failing to respond to his call for military support against Iran to secure the Strait of Hormuz.

"COWARDS, and we will REMEMBER!" he wrote on his Truth Social platform.

Trump said allied nations were complaining about surging oil prices while refusing to assist in keeping the crucial shipping route open. He has been urging partners to help

Continued on P4

Sri Lanka refused US request to land warplanes

Requests were made on March 4 and March 8

MPOST BUREAU

COLOMBO: Sri Lanka has declined requests from the United States to allow two military aircraft to land at Mattala International Airport earlier this month, with President Anura Kumara Dissanayake telling Parliament the move reflects Colombo's determination to stay neutral amid rising tensions linked to the Middle East conflict and broader Indian Ocean security concerns.

The president said the US sought clearance on March 4 and March 8 for two warplanes operating out of Djibouti, a strategic hub between the Red Sea and Gulf of Aden. Both requests were turned down. According to Dissanayake, the aircraft were equipped with eight anti-ship missiles. "We want to maintain our neutrality despite many pressures. We won't give in. The Middle East war

- HIGHLIGHTS**
- » Aircraft originated from US base in Djibouti
 - » Warplanes reportedly carried eight anti-ship missiles
 - » Colombo rejected both requests citing neutrality concerns

poses challenges, but we will do everything possible to remain neutral," he said, adding, "They wanted to bring in two warplanes armed with eight anti-ship missiles from a base in Djibouti to the Mattala International Airport and we said no."

His remarks came a day after talks with US Special Envoy for South and Central Asia Sergio Gor, where both sides discussed maritime security, port protection,

Continued on P4

Flipkart Group CFO Sriram Venkataraman steps down

Nishant Verman rejoins as SVP

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Flipkart on Friday announced that Group Chief Financial Officer Sriram Venkataraman will step down from his position. The company said he will stay on "for a period of time" to support continuity and ensure a smooth transition.

During the interim, Ravi Iyer, CFO of Flipkart, will take charge of the broader finance organisation, according to a company statement.

The Walmart-backed e-commerce firm also confirmed the return of Nishant Verman as Senior Vice President for Corporate Development and Partnerships. Verman rejoins after founding Bazaar, a cross-border exports platform. He has earlier worked with Microsoft's Corporate Development team and Morgan Stanley in tech investment banking.

Continued on P4

PM Modi speaks to King of Bahrain; condemns attacks on energy infra

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday held a telephone conversation with King Hamad Bin Isa Al Khalifa, during which both leaders reviewed the evolving situation in West Asia and raised concerns over recent attacks targeting civilian and energy infrastructure.

In a post on X, Modi described the interaction as "fruitful" and said he extended Eid al-Fitr greetings to the king and the people of Bahrain. He noted that the two leaders "discussed the current situation in the West Asian region" and condemned attacks on key

The prime minister also stressed the need to maintain freedom of navigation and ensure that shipping routes remain open and secure

infrastructure, pointing to their impact on global supplies of food, fuel and fertilisers.

The prime minister also stressed the need to maintain freedom of navigation and ensure that

shipping routes remain open and secure amid ongoing tensions.

Modi thanked the Bahraini monarch for his continued support toward the Indian community living in the Gulf nation.

This marks the second conversation between the two leaders since the escalation of conflict following strikes by the United States and Israel on Iran on February 28, which prompted retaliatory actions by Tehran against several Gulf countries.

Since the crisis began, Modi has also spoken with leaders from Saudi Arabia, Jordan, the United Arab Emirates, France, Malaysia, Israel and Iran.

'WITHOUT FORMAL ANNOUNCEMENT...'

Transfers of officials ahead of polls 'declared President's Rule': Mamata

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: Trinamool Congress (TMC) chairperson Mamata Banerjee on Friday launched a scathing attack on the BJP-led Centre and the Election Commission of India (ECI) over the frequent transfer of administrative and police officials ahead of the Assembly elections, terming it "declared President's Rule" imposed without formal announcement.

"This is not undecleared. The manner in which the poll body is functioning in Bengal at the behest of the BJP — this is declared President's Rule. It is shameful that elections are being conducted like this. Why

is there so much fear?" Banerjee said at a Press conference at her Kalighat residence while releasing the party's manifesto.

Calling the situation a "shame for democracy", she alleged a deep-rooted conspiracy to influence the poll process.

"They have understood Bengalis cannot be suppressed. Even today, Bengal is being targeted for its language, identity and intellect. The state's global intellectual presence makes it a target of jealous forces," she said.

Accusing the poll body of acting as a "mouthpiece" of the BJP, Banerjee said: "Every time the observers ask, we give it. This time the elections are in

Continued on P4

CJI Surya Kant recuses from hearing on EC appointments law

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Friday stepped aside from hearing petitions that question the validity of a 2023 law altering the process for appointing election commissioners, citing a potential conflict of interest.

"I will be accused of conflict of interest. There is a conflict of interest," he said at the outset while sitting with Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi. He added that the case should be heard by a bench where no judge is in line to become the chief justice.

The petitions challenge provisions of the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment,

Continued on P4

Action icon Chuck Norris passes away at 86

NEW YORK: Chuck Norris, the martial arts champion turned Hollywood action icon known for his roles in "Walker, Texas Ranger" and a string of hit films, has died at the age of 86. His family said he passed away on Thursday in a "sudden" manner.

In a statement shared on social media, his family said he was "surrounded by his family and was at peace", adding that further details would remain private.

Born Carlos Ray Norris on March 10, 1940, in Ryan, Oklahoma, he rose from a modest upbringing to become one of the most recognisable figures in martial arts and entertainment. After

Continued on P4

RAIN AND SNOW DISRUPT NORMAL LIFE

Western disturbance chills North India

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: A widespread spell of unseasonal rain, thunderstorms and snowfall swept across large parts of India on Friday, dragging temperatures well below normal, improving air quality in some regions, and raising concerns over crop damage, even as forecasters signalled that conditions over North India may gradually stabilise in the coming days.

Rain lashed several northern states on Friday, including Punjab, Haryana and Delhi, while thunderstorms and gusty winds swept across Uttar Pradesh. The weather system, which began influencing the region from Thursday evening, led to a marked fall in temperatures, in some cases pushing daytime readings 10 to 12 degrees Celsius below seasonal averages.



A man covers himself with a plastic sheet amid rain, in Dehradun, Friday

In Delhi, the impact was particularly striking. The national capital recorded its coldest March day in six years, with the maximum temperature at Safdarjung

settling at 21.7 degrees Celsius, 9.6 degrees below normal. The city also experienced a sharp improvement in air quality, with the Air Quality Index dropping to 93, placing it in the 'satisfactory' category for the first time in around five months. Rainfall of about 7 mm was recorded during the day

Continued on P4

Govt blocks 300 illegal betting sites, apps in fresh crackdown

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government has blocked 300 websites and applications linked to illegal gambling and betting in a fresh enforcement drive, according to official sources on Friday. The action targets a wide range of platforms, including online sports betting services, casino-style offerings such as slots and roulette, live dealer games, and betting exchanges that operate as peer-to-peer marketplaces.

Authorities have also acted against satta and matka networks, along with real-money card and casino gaming applications, as part of the ongoing effort to curb unlawful online money gaming. "A total of around 300 such

The move adds to a broader campaign that has seen approximately 8,400 platforms blocked so far

websites and applications have been blocked in the latest crackdown," a source said.

The move adds to a broader campaign that has seen approximately 8,400 platforms blocked so far. Of these, nearly 4,900 were taken down following the enactment of the Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act, 2025, the source added.

Continued on P4

India-China border trade via Lipulekh Pass to resume after six years

MPOST BUREAU

PITHORAGARH: Border trade between India and China through the Lipulekh Pass in Uttarakhand's Pithoragarh district is expected to restart this year, ending a six-year suspension.

District Magistrate Ashish Bhatgai said preparations are underway following directions from the Union government. The trading window, usually held between June and September, is being planned after the Ministry of External Affairs issued a No Objection Certificate.

Bhatgai said Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri has written to Uttarakhand Chief Secretary Anand Bardhan, seeking the revival of trade through the high-altitude route. The com-

munication noted that clearances have also been granted by the Ministry of Home Affairs and the Ministry of Commerce and Industry.

The state government has been asked to coordinate with relevant departments to ensure that the 2026 trading season proceeds smoothly. Officials said contact details of local authorities will be shared with Chinese counterparts to strengthen coordination on both sides of the border.

Instructions have been issued to agencies responsible for issuing trade passes, along with designated banks handling currency exchange, the Customs Department and the Dharchula administration. Authorities are working on a detailed plan covering transit camps,

Continued on P4

HEAVY SECURITY IN DWARKA

Delhi on high alert ahead of Eid

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: With Eid-ul-Fitr a day away, security has been stepped up across South-west Delhi's Dwarka district, as the Uttam Nagar area remains tense after the March 4 killing.

Police said more than 100 pickets have been set up, with personnel deployed on rooftops and at key junctions to maintain a close watch on movement in sensitive pockets.

Security has been tightened around the Uttam Nagar East metro station following directions from the Delhi High Court after apprehensions of unrest during the festival.

"We have made detailed deployment plans and are ready to respond swiftly to any situation," an officer said. The HC order was passed on a PIL filed by a civil rights group, the Association for Protection of Civil Rights, which approached the high court to prevent "imminent communal violence" on Eid in Uttam Nagar.

A civil society group comprising eminent Muslims wrote to Union Home Minister Amit



A child at a sweet shop near Jama Masjid ahead of the Eid Al-Fitr

Shah on Thursday over "open threats" to the Muslim community in Uttam Nagar, and urged him to pass special instructions to the police to take strict action.

Meanwhile, force has been mounted in Hastsal village, where the killing took place, and nearby areas, with joint deployment of Delhi Police and central armed forces.

On March 4, the day of Holi, Tarun, 26, was killed in a clash between two neighbouring families in Uttam Nagar's JJ

CLOSER LOOK

» A civil society group comprising eminent Muslims wrote to Union Home Minister Shah over "open threats" to the Muslim community in Uttam Nagar, and urged him to pass special instructions to the police to take strict action

» Monitoring of social media has also been intensified to track and curb the spread of inflammatory content

Colony. The altercation, police said, was triggered after a water balloon thrown by a girl from one family accidentally hit a woman from the other.

The incident led to protests by some groups, and two vehicles linked to the accused were set on fire. The police have so far apprehended 14 people, including two minors, in connection with the case.

The police said security focus has been sharpened around mosques, Eidgahs and other places of congrega-

tion where large crowds are expected. Area domination exercises, including foot patrols and vehicle checks, are being carried out regularly.

Monitoring of social media has also been intensified to track and curb the spread of inflammatory content, the police said, adding that several objectionable posts have already been flagged and acted upon.

"Delhi Police has put in place comprehensive security arrangements to ensure that Eid is celebrated in a safe, peaceful and harmonious environment across the city," the city force said on X.

The police said that any attempt to disturb public peace and communal harmony will attract legal action.

"Let us celebrate responsibly and contribute to maintaining peace and unity," the statement added.

Areas with mixed populations have been categorised as sensitive and are under constant watch. Apart from ground deployment, police teams have been positioned at elevated points in select locations to enhance surveillance.

Police presence notwithstanding, unease persists among locals.

Pradeep Shukla, president of the Uttam Nagar RWA, said the visible security presence has brought a sense of control, but anxiety remains.

"There is heavy barricading, and movement has reduced. It feels unusually quiet. People are still worried, but we are hoping things remain peaceful," he said.

One dead, one injured in high-tension line accident in Kapashera

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 45-year-old mason died and another labourer was injured after coming into contact with a high-tension power line during construction work in southwest Delhi's Kapashera area on Friday afternoon.

Police said they were alerted to the incident through a PCR call received at Kapashera Police Station. The call was logged around 2:30 pm, following which a team rushed to the spot. By the time they arrived, both injured men had already been taken to a nearby hospital by ambulance.

Preliminary inquiry revealed that the workers were engaged in construction at a residential building when the accident occurred. Jhulan (32), who was on the first floor, had picked up a bamboo pole to hand it to Rajkumar, also known as Ramchandra, working on the second floor. During the process, the bamboo accidentally touched an overhead high-tension line, sending a



Workers were engaged in construction at a residential building when the accident occurred

strong electric current through it. Both men suffered severe electric shock injuries and fell from their respective positions. Rajkumar fell to the first floor, while Jhulan fell to the second floor, police said. They were rushed to hospital, where Rajkumar later succumbed to his injuries. His body has been sent for post-mortem examination.

Police have registered a case under relevant sections of law, and further investigation is under way.

Fire breaks out in 5-storey guest house; four rescued

GURUGRAM: A fire broke out at a five-storey guest house in Sector 28 on Friday afternoon, triggering panic among residents. Four people, including three women, were rescued by police, firefighters, Haryana State Disaster Response Force (HSDRF) personnel and locals. The blaze, which reportedly originated from an electrical panel on the ground floor, is suspected to have been caused by a short circuit.

Heavy smoke quickly spread through the building, making access from the front difficult. Rescue teams used side railings, ropes and the rear staircase to reach the upper floors and evacuate those trapped. Fire engines and HSDRF teams brought the blaze under control within about an hour, preventing it from spreading further.

Officials said the building was fully occupied at the time, but prompt and coordinated action helped avert a major tragedy. Several items on the ground floor were damaged.

MP0ST

Police nabs man for firing at Narela businesswoman

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police Crime Branch has arrested a 23-year-old man for an alleged attempt to murder a businesswoman in Narela. The accused, identified as Anish alias Ishwar Dayal, had been absconding since March 7 after allegedly opening fire to terrorise the victim and force her to shut her business.

Acting on specific intelligence inputs, a Crime Branch team from RK Puram apprehended him during a targeted operation on March 18. He has been booked

under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Arms Act.

The case dates back to March 6, when the woman, who runs a water plant, reported that two men arrived on a motorcycle. One of them, identified as Anish, allegedly threatened her with a pistol and fired at a wall near the premises to instil fear. The duo warned her to shut down the business before fleeing.

Police had earlier arrested co-accused Piyush. During interrogation, Anish allegedly said the attack was linked to prior enmity.

SHO, sub-inspector suspended in Noida over missing legal provisions in rape case

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: Two police personnel posted at Phase III police station — the station house officer (SHO) and a sub-inspector — have been suspended for allegedly omitting crucial legal provisions in a rape case, officials said. Police on Friday said the accused, identified as Vikas Kumar alias Mohd Rameez, a native of Chhatarpur, has been arrested.

The case was registered on March 17 on the complaint of a 24-year-old woman from Madhya Pradesh employed with a private firm in Noida. She alleged that a 26-year-old

The lapse came under scrutiny after protests by right-wing groups outside the police station

man, whom she met through social media two years ago, entered into a live-in relationship with her while concealing his religious identity and raped her on the promise of marriage.

In her complaint, the woman further alleged that when she pressed for marriage, the accused coerced her to convert her religion and later extorted money before fleeing.

Initially, the FIR was registered under Sections 69 (sexual intercourse by deceitful means), 351 (criminal intimidation) and 308 (extortion) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS).

The lapse came under scrutiny after protests by right-wing groups outside the police station, prompting a review by senior officers, who found that relevant provisions had not been invoked.

Police Commissioner Laxmi Singh has sought an explanation from Deputy Commissioner of Police (Central Noida) Shakti Mohan Awasthi, while a preliminary inquiry has been initiated against

Assistant Commissioner of Police Umesh Yadav.

The suspended officers — SHO Punit Kumar and sub-inspector Preeti Gupta — failed to include provisions of the Uttar Pradesh Prohibition of Unlawful Conversion of Religion Act and the SC/ST Act in the FIR, despite allegations of forced religious conversion and caste-based remarks.

Additional DCP Rajendra Kumar Gautam said the accused had been absconding and two teams were formed to trace him. The probe into the procedural lapse has been assigned to an officer of assistant DCP rank.

News at a glance

TATA POWER-DDL LOK ADALAT ON MARCH 22

NEW DELHI: Tata Power Delhi Distribution Ltd will hold a National Lok Adalat on March 22 in Rohini to settle electricity theft cases and issues related to disconnected connections. The initiative, organised with the Delhi State Legal Services Authority, will run from 10 am to 4 pm. Consumers can register via helpline 19124 or email. Participants must carry ID and relevant bills. The move aims to encourage settlements and reduce pending disputes.

PALM EXPO EXPANDS TO DELHI

NEW DELHI: Informa Markets India will launch PALM Expo Delhi to boost North India's professional audio-visual and lighting industry. The event will be held from January 7 to 9, 2027, at Bharat Mandapam, with 70–100 exhibitors and up to 7,000 participants expected. Following its Mumbai success, the expo targets a region contributing 40–45 per cent of India's AV market, driven by digital infrastructure growth, corporate expansion and rising demand for advanced communication technologies.

Court directs state to undertake Tahir Hussain's surgery within fifteen days

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court on Friday declined interim bail to former AAP councillor Tahir Hussain in a case related to the 2020 Delhi riots, but directed authorities to ensure that his surgery is conducted within 15 days. Additional Sessions Judge Parveen Singh was hearing Hussain's plea seeking interim bail for a month on medical grounds.

In an order, the court said, "Considering these facts and circumstances, the application at hand is disposed of on following terms that the surgery of the applicant, as required, shall be conducted within 15 days from today, unless some medical complications result



in delay in the surgery."

Hussain, who is in judicial custody since April 6, 2020, had sought bail from March 20 to April 20 in connection with a case related to the 2020 riots in northeast Delhi.

He had sought interim bail citing an inguinal hernia requiring surgical intervention and post-operative care.

"The applicant (Hussain)

While the procedure required is elective, the accused cannot be denied timely treatment

shall be provided all post-operative care in hospital and in jail as per the recommendations of the doctor," the judge said.

He said while the procedure required is elective in nature, the accused cannot be denied timely treatment. "Surgery of the applicant is an elective surgery which the accused/applicant can choose as and when he requires. Accused is being

managed through conservative treatment and no complications have been reflected," the court said. Hussain's counsel submitted that delays in hospital visits and medical tests due to an overburdened system had hampered timely treatment and that he should be allowed to undergo surgery at a hospital and with a doctor of his choice.

The court declined interim bail to former AAP councillor Tahir Hussain but directed that his hernia surgery be conducted within 15 days. The prosecution opposed the plea, stating his condition was stable and not life-threatening, and that the surgery was elective.

PII

Hotel chef held for RK Puram burglary: Cops

NEW DELHI: A 22-year-old chef working night shifts at a five-star hotel has been arrested for allegedly burgling a house in southwest Delhi's RK Puram using a master key, police said. Cash and jewellery worth Rs 2.69 lakh, along with a master key and two scooters, were recovered from the accused, identified as Nilesh alias Nikesh.

Police said CCTV footage showed him entering and leaving the house, helping track his movement. During interrogation, he allegedly confessed to the crime and revealed he used gaps in his work schedule to carry out the theft. Further investigation is underway. MP0ST

Man shot dead by bikers inside Bawana shop; three injured

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 30-year-old man was shot dead and three others, including his father and an eight-year-old boy, were injured after three assailants opened fire inside a shop attached to their house in outer North Delhi's Bawana on Thursday evening, police said. Officials suspect gang rivalry behind the attack.

Police said two PCR calls were received around 5:26 pm reporting the incident in Harewali village. Callers informed them that three men on a motorcycle had fired at their family member, Ravi Bhardwaj, and that he was being taken to a hospital in Pooth Khurd. A police team, along with senior officers, rushed to the spot and the hospital.

According to Deputy Commissioner of Police (Outer North) Hareshwar Swami, preliminary enquiry revealed



that the attackers arrived on a motorcycle and opened fire, specifically targeting Ravi. He was taken to MV Hospital, where he was declared dead. His body has been preserved at the BSA Hospital mortuary.

Three others injured in the firing include Ravi's father Anil Bhardwaj (55), neighbour Raj Kumar (46), and an eight-year-old relative. Empty cartridges were recovered from the scene.

Police have registered a case under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Arms Act. Special teams are analysing CCTV footage and tracking the accused, who are suspected to have fled towards Haryana.

BOARD CLEARS INFRA PROJECTS

Property rates in Yamuna e-way region to rise 3.58% from April 1

DIPIKA KIROLA

GREATER NOIDA: In a significant development for the NCR real estate market, the Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority (YEIDA) has approved a 3.58 per cent increase in property prices across its jurisdiction. The decision was taken at the authority's 89th board meeting, with revised rates set to come into effect from April 1, 2026.

The hike comes just ahead of the inauguration of the Noida International Airport, scheduled for March 28. Officials believe the commencement of flight operations will significantly boost demand for land and real estate in the Yamuna Expressway region, which has already been witnessing heightened investor interest.



The revised rates will apply across all categories, including residential plots, commercial spaces and industrial land. For prospective buyers, this translates into higher acquisition costs, particularly for those planning fresh investments. However, developers and market experts view the increase as a sign of strong future appreciation, driven by infrastructure growth.

During the meeting, chaired by Chairman Alok Kumar, who is also the Additional Chief Secretary for MSME, Infrastructure and

A traffic park-cum-training centre will be developed with support from the Honda India

Industrial Development, YEIDA also cleared several proposals aimed at strengthening the region's infrastructure.

"A traffic park-cum-training centre will be developed with support from the Honda India Foundation under its CSR initiative.

"The authority will provide land free of cost, while ownership will remain with YEIDA. Additionally, partial modifications in the bid documents for the Heritage City project have been approved to facilitate further progress," said RK Singh, Chief

Executive Officer, YEIDA.

With key projects such as the airport and improved expressway connectivity, the Yamuna Authority area is rapidly emerging as a major investment hub in NCR. Officials said the price revision reflects rising land demand, growing investor confidence and expectations of economic growth following the airport's launch.

Experts believe property prices may continue to rise as commercial activity increases and more infrastructure projects take shape in the coming months.

AIIMS to study link between lung cancer, pollution

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: AIIMS-Delhi is studying links between exposure to air pollution, particularly fine particulate matter (PM2.5), and the risk of lung cancer under its AIRCARE study, led by Dr Abhishek Shankar. The study will analyse 1,615 lung cancer patients and an equal number of controls from families across Delhi-NCR.

Researchers will use cohort and case-control methods to examine long-term exposure across demographics and socio-economic groups. The study will also explore whether pollution triggers a population-specific genetic signature that may lead to cancer.

Dr Shankar said rising cases among non-smokers, especially women and young adults, are a concern. The findings aim to help develop risk-based screening models and inform policy to address the growing health burden.



INCOME TAX ACT, 2025
applicable from
1st April 2026
Improved Clarity & Ease in Reading

CBC 15401/13/0017/2526



INCOME TAX ACT
2025
Powering the mission of Viksit Bharat
Simple Law, Empowered Bharat

Towards Viksit Bharat
Through Simplified Taxation Law

"Today the goal of the country is Viksit Bharat, Sashakt Bharat! We cannot stop until this dream of a developed India is fulfilled."
- Shri Narendra Modi, Prime Minister



EV push: Rs 24 crore subsidy to 12,877 buyers

CM Rekha Gupta flags off 300 new EV buses to boost public transport

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major push towards clean and future-ready urban transport, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday unveiled a series of transformative mobility initiatives, including the rollout of 300 new electric buses, launch of an inter-state e-bus service, and disbursement of over Rs 24 crore in EV subsidies, marking a significant leap in the Capital's transition to sustainable transport.

The Chief Minister flagged off the new zero-emission buses from the Indraprastha Bus Depot, taking Delhi's total fleet strength beyond 6,100 buses. Equipped with CCTV cameras, panic buttons, real-time tracking and accessibility features for persons with disabilities, the buses are part of the government's larger target of scaling up to 14,000 buses by 2028-29, including 5,000 electric buses in the near term.

Addressing the gathering, Gupta said, "Our goal is clean, safe, and future-ready transportation for Delhi," adding that green mobility will reduce pollution while improving daily



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta flags off 300 electric buses at the Indraprastha Bus Depot, on Friday

commuting. Highlighting financial reforms, she said, "We are clearing the financial liabilities of previous governments; DTC is moving towards financial stability," noting that systemic gaps and inefficiencies are being addressed through transparency and better resource management.

In a boost to regional connectivity, the government also launched a new inter-state electric bus service between Nanaksar in Delhi and Ghazi-

abad, covering a 21-km route via Bhajanpura, Loni Road, the UP border, Pasonda, Hindon Airport and Mohan Nagar. The service will initially run three buses on a pilot basis, completing 12 daily trips between 7:15 am and 10:10 pm, with fares capped at Rs 53.

The Chief Minister also laid the foundation stone for a modern, multi-storey office of the Delhi Transport Corporation, spread across 1,800 square metres. The facility will feature

advanced infrastructure, including a conference hall, workstations, energy-efficient design and fire safety systems, while a temporary office will ensure uninterrupted operations during construction.

Further strengthening the EV ecosystem, the government relaunched the EV incentive portal and disbursed over Rs 24.04 crore to 12,877 beneficiaries through Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT). Gupta noted that subsidy delays under the

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Travel from Nanaksar to Ghaziabad set to become easier as new e-bus service launches
- » We are clearing the financial liabilities of previous governments; DTC is moving towards financial stability: CM
- » CM also laid the foundation stone for a modern, multi-storey office of the Delhi Transport Corporation, spread across 1,800 square metres

previous regime have been resolved through a transparent system ensuring timely payments.

Transport Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh said, "Under the guidance of the Prime Minister and the leadership of the Chief Minister, development projects are taking shape on the ground," adding that the initiatives mark significant progress in making Delhi's transport system modern, efficient and environmentally sustainable.

CM holds pre-budget meet with Kinnar community



OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a significant step towards inclusive governance, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday held a direct dialogue with members of the Kinnar community as part of pre-budget consultations, assuring that their concerns and aspirations will shape the upcoming Delhi Budget 2026.

The interaction, held at the Delhi Secretariat, saw community representatives sharing their experiences and raising key issues related to employment, healthcare, housing, sanitation and access to basic civic facilities. The Chief Minister engaged closely with participants and reiterated that the government is committed to ensuring that every section of society is heard. "The government will ensure the Kinnar community's participation in building a Viksit Delhi," she said.

Members of the commu-

The govt will ensure the Kinnar community's participation in building a Viksit Delhi

nity welcomed the government's decision to provide free travel in DTC buses through the 'Saheli Pink Card', stating that it would ease daily commuting and contribute to their economic empowerment.

During the discussion, representatives stressed the need for creating safe and dignified employment opportunities, expanding access to sensitive and inclusive healthcare, and introducing skill development and job-oriented training programmes. They also highlighted the importance of improving housing, sanitation and other basic ame-

nities, along with expanding social security coverage.

Simplifying processes related to identity and documentation was another key demand raised during the interaction. Participants said that addressing these challenges would help members of the Kinnar community integrate into the mainstream with dignity and independence.

Responding to the suggestions, Gupta said the Kinnar community is an integral part of society and ensuring their dignity, safety and empowerment remains a priority. Emphasising the importance of participatory governance, she said that incorporating public feedback into policymaking is essential for effective administration.

She further expressed confidence that the inputs received during the consultation would be reflected in the upcoming budget, helping create a roadmap for a more inclusive, balanced and developed Delhi.



Jal Board relaxes NOC norm; 25% IFC enough

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major relief for homeowners and developers, the Delhi Jal Board has introduced a key reform allowing provisional No Objection Certificates (NOCs) with just 25 per cent payment of Infrastructure Charges (IFC), a move expected to revive stalled construction projects across the Capital.

Announced under the leadership of Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, the decision aims to ease the financial burden caused by steep IFC rates that had slowed down building approvals and redevelopment in recent years.

Under the new provision, applicants can secure a provisional NOC at the building plan approval stage by paying only 25 per cent of the IFC. The remaining amount will be adjusted later based on final rates at the time of sanctioning the water connection. The reform addresses long-standing concerns over the shift from occupancy-based to floor-area-based IFC calculations, which had increased charges by up to 5-10 times

in several cases. Explaining the rationale, Singh said, "We were receiving repeated complaints that high IFC was stopping people from building their homes. This was neither fair to citizens nor efficient for the system. We decided to fix it with a practical and humane approach." He added, "With just 25 per cent payment, construction can begin. The remaining amount will be fairly adjusted later."

Highlighting the broader vision, he said, "Our goal is not to maximize revenue, but to create a fair and balanced system."

The reform is expected to provide immediate relief to stalled projects, reduce upfront costs, and accelerate construction activity. Properties up to 200 square metres will remain exempt from IFC, while larger plots may see liabilities reduced by 50-70 per cent.

Officials believe the move will boost economic activity, generate employment, and strengthen trust in governance by simplifying procedures and promoting ease of doing business in Delhi.

Speaker Gupta gives 15 laptops to DoE

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a move aimed at strengthening digital education and optimising public resources, Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta on Friday handed over the first batch of 15 laptops to the Directorate of Education for use in government schools across the Capital.

The initiative, led by the Speaker, focuses on repurposing functional laptops previously used by the Delhi Legislative Assembly Secretariat. These devices, now being redistributed in phases, are expected to provide students with hands-



on exposure to digital tools and enhance classroom learning.

Speaking on the occasion, Gupta emphasised the importance of utilising public assets effectively. "Public assets must serve their highest purpose, this phased rollout ensures work-

ing laptops reach students in government schools," he said, adding that the effort reflects a commitment to nation-building through education.

The distribution follows the implementation of the National eVidhan Application (NeVA) in

the Assembly Secretariat since the Monsoon Session of 2025, which led to the procurement of new systems. As part of the transition, older laptops in good working condition are now being redirected for educational use. Officials said that around 50-60 laptops will be handed over to the education department in subsequent phases, with priority given to students who lack access to digital resources.

In addition, laptops procured in 2019 and still operational have also been approved for donation, highlighting a resource-efficient approach to governance.

Sood inaugurates pool at govt school

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Education and Sports Minister Ashish Sood on Friday inaugurated a swimming pool at a Sarvodaya Bal Vidyalaya School, in Saraswati Vihar.

The facility has been constructed at a cost of Rs 2.60 crore and is aimed at strengthening access to sports infrastructure for students in the area, according to a statement.

Describing the development as more than just the addition of a swimming facility, Sood said it would open up new opportunities for students from nearby localities and help promote sports alongside academics.

The minister said the project was initiated in 2018 but remained incomplete for several years before being finished in 2026. The six-lane pool is expected to benefit a large number of students from surrounding areas.

He said the government is working to improve basic infrastructure in schools so that students can compete at higher levels, including national and international platforms.

Delays in the project had affected potential opportunities for students, Sood said, adding that the project's timely completion could have enabled earlier access to training and skill development in swimming.

Delhi govt is focusing on developing sports facilities and providing support to young athletes

— Min Ashish Sood

Highlighting broader efforts, he said the Delhi government is focusing on developing sports facilities and providing support to young athletes.

Financial assistance of up to Rs 5 lakh is being provided to students preparing for state and national-level competitions, covering expenses such as coaching, training and travel.

The minister further said that the government is working towards ensuring that all schools become "NIPUN certified", with a focus on improving foundational learning outcomes.

Special initiatives are also being undertaken to support students who require additional academic assistance, he mentioned.

Sood added that strengthening both education and sports infrastructure remains a priority to ensure holistic development of students in the capital.



Prime Minister Narendra Modi meets Delhi L-G Taranjit Singh Sandhu

AQI TO STAY 'MODERATE' TILL MARCH 23

Rain resets Delhi: Coldest March day in 6 yrs, AQI 'satisfactory' after 5 mths

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: After days of persistent rain and gusty winds, the national capital witnessed a sharp dip in temperatures along with a spell of clean air, recording its coldest March day in six years and the cleanest air in about five months, with the AQI falling in the 'satisfactory' category on Friday.

With the maximum temperature settling at 21.7 degrees Celsius at Safdarjung, 9.6 degrees below normal, Delhi logged its coldest March day

since March 8, 2020, when the mercury had dropped to 21.2 degrees Celsius.

After the rain, air quality also improved markedly, with the Air Quality Index (AQI) recorded at 93, placing it in the 'satisfactory' category. This marks the first such day in about five months (161 days), with the last time the city recorded 'satisfactory' air quality on October 9, 2025, when the AQI stood at 99.

According to CPCB standards, an AQI of 0-50 is considered 'good'; 51-100 'satisfactory';

101-200 'moderate'; 201-300 'poor'; 301-400 'very poor'; and 401-500 'severe'. Across the city, maximum temperatures remained well below normal levels. Palam recorded a maximum temperature of 21.2 degrees Celsius, 10.4 degrees below normal.

Lodhi Road recorded 21.0 degrees Celsius, 9.0 degrees below normal, Ridge 21.1 degrees Celsius, 10.7 degrees below normal, and Ayanagar 21.5 degrees Celsius, 10.5 degrees below normal. On the minimum temperature front,

Safdarjung recorded 16 degrees Celsius, 0.5 degrees below normal. Palam logged 14.7 degrees Celsius, 1.7 degrees below normal. Lodhi Road recorded 15.8 degrees Celsius, 0.8 degrees above normal, Ridge recorded 15.1 degrees Celsius, 2.6 degrees below normal, and Ayanagar reported 16 degrees Celsius, 0.2 degrees below normal.

The city recorded 7 mm of rainfall during the day, taking the average rainfall for the month so far to 16.2 mm till date, making it the wettest March in three years since 2023,

when the average rainfall stood at 50.4 mm. After 8.30 am on Friday, rainfall was recorded at Safdarjung at 1.4 mm, Palam at 1.4 mm, Lodhi Road at 1.2 mm, Ridge at 1.0 mm and Ayanagar at 0.8 mm.

Among other stations, Mayur Vihar recorded 2.5 mm, while Pusa and Janakpuri recorded 1.0 mm each.

Between 11.30 am and 2.30 pm, Safdarjung and Lodhi Road recorded no rainfall, while Palam recorded 0.2 mm, Ridge 0.2 mm and Ayanagar 0.2 mm. Among other stations, Najaf-

garh and Janakpuri recorded 0.5 mm each. Between 2.30 pm and 5.30 pm, no station recorded any rainfall.

From 8.30 am on Thursday to 8.30 am on Friday, the national capital recorded cumulative rainfall of 6.6 mm at Safdarjung, 5.4 mm at Palam, 6.3 mm at Lodhi Road, 7.4 mm at Ridge and 5.6 mm at Ayanagar.

The air quality is likely to be in the 'moderate' category from Saturday to March 23, according to the Air Quality Early Warning System.



Visitors make their way through the Kartavya Path amid rainfall

'SINCE FEB 28, AROUND 3 LAKH PASSENGERS RETURNED'

West Asia conflict: Six Indians lost their lives in ‘various incidents’:MEA

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Amid the escalating West Asia conflict, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) on Friday said six Indian nationals have lost their lives while one remains missing in “various incidents”.

At an inter-ministerial briefing here, Additional Secretary (Gulf), MEA, Aseem R Mahajan, also said, “Late yesterday night, we received information regarding the tragic demise of an Indian

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Mahajan also told reporters in Delhi that ‘six Indian nationals have lost their lives and one is missing in various incidents’
- » Energy and other civilian infrastructure in the Gulf region have also come under attack during this conflict that has stretched into three weeks, with no end to it in sight

national, during an attack in Riyadh on March 18.” He, however, did not elaborate upon the circumstances of this death. On Friday, the Indian

Embassy in Riyadh also said that an Indian national was killed in Saudi Arabia due to the “recent events of March 18”. In a social media post, the Indian Mission

expressed its “deepest condolences on the tragic demise of an Indian national in Riyadh due to recent events on March 18”.

A day earlier, the Indian embassy said alerts were received by residents in Riyadh and some other regions on Wednesday. “The Indian community is advised to remain calm and composed,” the embassy said.

Mahajan also told reporters in Delhi that “six Indian nationals have lost their lives and one is missing in various incidents”.

“Our missions in Saudi Arabia, Oman, Iraq, and the UAE are in regular touch with the concerned authorities regarding the missing Indian national and for the early repatriation of mortal remains of the deceased Indian nationals to India,” he said.

Less than a week ago, the MEA official had told reporters in an inter-ministerial briefing on the West Asia situation that five Indian nationals had lost their lives while one is missing in “various incidents”.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Friday refused to entertain a plea seeking removal of a remark against its verdicts from NCERT’s old class 8 Social Science textbook, saying that people have a right to criticise them.

The Centre, meanwhile, informed a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi that it had constituted an expert committee comprising two former apex court judges and an ex-attorney general to review the NCERT book with a chapter on corruption in the judiciary.



Solicitor General Tushar Mehta told the bench that the committee comprises senior advocate and former Attorney General KK Venugopal, former top court judge Justice Indu Malhotra, and former Supreme Court judge and current National Judicial Academy director Justice Aniruddha Bose, along with a vice chancellor.

“We have formed the committee to draft the chapter. Mr KK Venugopal will be a member of the committee. Justice Indu Malhotra will also be a part. We have also requested Justice Aniruddha Bose from the National Judicial Academy to be there,” Mehta said.

The top court was hearing a petition by former NCERT member Pankaj Pushkar against a passage in an older class 8 textbook that read, “recent judgments tend to view the slum dweller as an encroacher in the city”.

The court refused to entertain the petition, observing that the judiciary should not be oversensitive about healthy criticism.

From Page 1

Iran hits

Khamenei hasn’t been seen since he succeeded his father, the 86-year-old Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who was killed in an Israeli airstrike on the first day of the war.

His remarks came in a statement issued on his behalf and sent to President Masoud Pezeshkian after Israel killed Intelligence Minister Esmail Khatib earlier this week.

Heavy explosions shook Dubai as air defences intercepted early incoming fire over the city, where people were observing Eid al-Fitr, the end of the holy Muslim fasting month of Ramadan, and mosques made the day’s first call to prayers.

Bahrain’s Interior Ministry said a fire broke out after shrapnel from an intercepted projectile landed on a warehouse, and Saudi Arabia reported shooting down multiple drones targeting its oil-rich Eastern Province.

The renewed attacks came after an intense day that saw Iran hit energy infrastructure around the region and launch more than a dozen missile salvos at Israel following the attack on South Pars.

South Pars, the Iranian part of the world’s largest gas field, is located offshore in the Persian Gulf and owned jointly with Qatar. With some 80% of power generated in Iran coming from natural gas, the attack posed a direct threat to the country’s electricity supplies.

Late Thursday, Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said the country would hold off on any further attacks on the gas field at the request of U.S. President Donald Trump after the Iranian response sent oil prices skyrocketing.

The Israeli prime minister also claimed Iran’s capability to produce ballistic missiles had been taken out, but the paramilitary Revolutionary Guard insisted Friday that they were still in production.

“We are producing missiles even during war conditions, which is amazing, and there is no particular problem in stockpiling,” spokesman Gen. Ali Mohammad Naeini was quoted as saying in Iran’s stat-run IRAN newspaper.

He added defiantly that Iran had no intention of seeking a quick end to the war. “These people expect the war to continue until the enemy is completely exhausted,” he said. “This war must end when the shadow of war is lifted from the country.”

Iran’s stranglehold on shipping through the Strait of Hormuz, a strategic waterway through which a fifth of the world’s oil and other critical goods are transported, has caused rising concerns of a global energy crisis.

Brent crude oil, the international standard, which spiked to more than \$119 a barrel during Iran’s attacks Thursday, was around \$107 in morning trading on Friday, up more than 47% since Israel and the United States attacked Iran on Feb. 28 to start the conflict.

In Israel, sirens sounded early Friday warning of attacks on Jerusalem and on the north of the country, sending people again scrambling to shelters. There were no immediate reports of casualties.

Meanwhile, the US military is said to be deploying three more warships and roughly 2,500 more marines to the Middle East. One US official confirmed Friday that the USS Boxer and two other amphibious assault ships, along with roughly 11th Marine Expeditionary Unit, have deployed from their home port of San Diego and are bound for the Middle East.

On Friday, Israel broadened

its attacks to Syria, saying it hit infrastructure there in response to attacks on the minority Druze population in southern Sweida province. Syria’s state-run SANA news agency did not immediately acknowledge the attack.

More than 1,300 people in Iran have been killed during the war. Israeli strikes against the Hezbollah militant group in Lebanon have displaced more than 1 million people, according to the Lebanese government, which says more than 1,000 people have been killed. Israel says it has killed more than 500 Hezbollah militants.

In Israel, 15 people have been killed by Iranian missile fire. Four people were also killed in the occupied West Bank by an Iranian missile strike. At least 13 U.S. military members have been killed.

The UAE said it disrupted what it called “a terrorist network funded and operated by Lebanon’s Hezbollah and Iran.” It arrested five men accused of laundering money, alleging they were “operating within the country under a fictitious commercial cover” that sought to carry out schemes that would threaten the country’s financial stability.

A report from Riyadh, quoting the Indian Embassy, said that an Indian national was killed in Saudi Arabia due to the “recent events of March 18”.

In a social media post, the Indian mission expressed its “deepest condolences on the tragic demise of an Indian national in Riyadh due to recent events on March 18th”. The circumstances regarding the Indian national’s death are not clear.

Meanwhile, Iran’s Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi on Friday criticised Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu over remarks comparing Jesus Christ and Genghis Khan, calling them disrespectful. Writing on X, Araghchi questioned Netanyahu’s reliance on Christian support in the United States while allegedly showing disdain for Jesus. The controversy began after Netanyahu, citing historian Will Durant, said moral strength alone cannot ensure survival. The comments sparked widespread backlash online, with users calling them offensive and anti-Christian. Netanyahu later clarified he did not intend to insult Jesus, stating the quote highlighted the need for strength alongside morality. Critics, however, continued to question his remarks.

Israeli forces have, for the first time, struck Iranian naval targets in the Caspian Sea, destroying vessels and a shipyard used for repairs and construction. The military described this as a ‘systematic strike on all levels’ of Iran’s naval capacity in the area, part of ‘Operation Roaring Lion’. The US simultaneously targeted Iranian vessels in the Strait of Hormuz and over 90 sites on Kharg Island, underscoring a coordinated push to degrade Iran’s maritime and oil infrastructure.

‘COWARDS’

protect the waterway, a key artery for global oil flows, arguing that easing the bottleneck would stabilise exports. Expressing frustration, the Republican leader said the United States was not receiving backing “despite the fact that we helped” NATO “so much” and added that preventing Iran from acquiring a nuclear weapon was in the shared interest of all allies.

AGENCIES

Rupee crashes

are raising concerns about inflation and a widening trade deficit,” a forex dealer said. The ongoing Iran conflict, now in its third week, has disrupted energy supply routes, particu-

larly through the Strait of Hormuz, contributing to global price volatility.

The dollar index rose 0.37 per cent to 99.60, reflecting the strength of the US currency, while Brent crude futures were marginally lower at USD 108.62 per barrel.

Domestic equities recovered from Thursday’s sharp losses but gave up most intraday gains. The BSE Sensex closed 325.72 points, or 0.44 per cent higher, at 74,532.96, after rising over 1,000 points earlier in the day. The NSE Nifty gained 112.35 points, or 0.49 per cent, to end at 23,114.50.

Foreign institutional investors sold equities worth Rs 5,518.39 crore on Friday, adding to outflows seen a day earlier. Meanwhile, India’s forex reserves fell by USD 7.052 billion to USD 709.759 billion for the week ended March 13, according to the Reserve Bank of India.

Sri Lanka refused

trade cooperation and the vision of a free and open Indo-Pacific. Despite these engagements, Sri Lanka signalled it would resist any move that could draw it into military alignments.

The decision follows a deadly maritime incident off the southern coast near Galle on March 4, when a US submarine torpedoed the Iranian frigate IRIS Dena, killing 84 sailors. Thirty-two survivors were rescued by the Sri Lankan Navy. The vessel had been returning from a naval exercise in India.

Days later, another Iranian ship, IRINS Bushehr, carrying 219 crew members, sought entry into Colombo port. Authorities redirected it to Trincomalee, while 204 sailors were accommodated at a naval facility near Colombo with temporary visas.

The developments have sparked debate within Sri Lanka over maritime conduct and the risks smaller nations face amid major power rivalries, alongside concerns about economic fallout affecting fuel supplies, remittances and tourism.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

CFO Sriram

Founded in 2007, Flipkart Group includes Myntra, Flipkart Wholesale, Cleartrip, and super. money.

CJI Surya Kant

Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023, which removed the CJI from the selection panel. Advocate Prashant Bhushan, appearing for a petitioner, backed the recusal and suggested listing the matter before a bench without any prospective CJI.

Accepting the suggestion, the court directed that the case be heard on April 7 by a newly constituted bench.

The law, passed in December 2023, replaced an earlier arrangement set by a Constitution bench in March 2023 that included the prime minister, the Leader of Opposition and the CJI in the selection committee. Petitioners argue the change weakens institutional independence. The Centre has defended the law, stating that independence does not depend on a judicial member’s presence.

Chuck Norris

moving to California at age 12, he joined the US Air Force in 1958. It was during a deployment to Korea that he began training in

disciplines such as judo and Tang Soo Do, an experience he later credited with shaping his athletic ability.

Norris went on to become a six-time undefeated World Professional Middleweight Karate champion and founded Chun Kuk Do, along with the United Fighting Arts Federation, which has issued more than 3,300 black belts. Black Belt magazine recognised him with a 10th-degree black belt.

He entered films in 1968 with a minor role in “The Wrecking Crew” and gained wider attention after his fight scene with Bruce Lee in 1972’s “Return of the Dragon.” Over the years, he appeared in more than 20 films, including “Missing in Action” and “The Delta Force.”

His most enduring role came in 1993 with “Walker, Texas Ranger,” which ran for nine seasons. “You try to portray the proper meaning... fighting injustice with justice,” he said in a 1996 interview.

Beyond acting, Norris became an internet phenomenon through “Chuck Norris Facts,” later embracing the humour in a book that also supported his children’s charity work. He is survived by five children.

AGENCIES

Govt holds retail fuel

while in Chennai, rates increased from Rs 92.54 to Rs 113.38 per litre, a hike of Rs 20.84.

The revisions come against the backdrop of a surge in international oil prices, which touched USD 119 per barrel on Thursday amid escalating tensions linked to the Iran conflict, before easing to around USD 108 per barrel.

Despite the global pressure, retail prices of standard fuels have not been revised. In Delhi, normal petrol continues to be priced at Rs 94.77 per litre, while diesel remains at Rs 87.67 per litre. Regular petrol, typically rated at 91-92 octane, is widely used for everyday vehicles, whereas premium variants with higher octane levels of 95-98 are meant for high-performance engines.

Addressing the changes, Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, said there had been no increase in prices affecting the general public. “Some increase is reported in the premium category, which hardly makes up for 2-4 per cent of the entire petrol sold in the country,” she said, adding, “There is no increase in price for the common man.”

She also reiterated that fuel pricing is determined by oil marketing companies following deregulation of petrol and diesel in 2010 and 2014, respectively. “It is decided by oil marketing companies. Government does not regulate petrol and diesel prices,” Sharma said.

Officials indicated that while global oil markets are being closely monitored, there is no immediate plan to revise retail fuel prices. Oil companies are expected to absorb current cost pressures for now. “Our priority is to make energy available to all consumers. Till now we have not increased the prices,” Sharma added.

In a statement on social media platform X, Indian Oil Corporation said it had kept regular fuel prices stable despite rising international costs. “A limited revision applies only to premium petrol XP-95, with minimal impact on overall consumption,” the company noted.

Retail fuel prices have remained unchanged since April 2022, with state-run retailers such as Indian Oil Corporation, Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd balancing losses dur-

ing high crude phases with gains when prices soften.

India imports about 88 per cent of its crude oil and nearly half of its natural gas, much of it routed through the Strait of Hormuz. Recent geopolitical developments, including US and Israeli strikes on Iranian facilities, have raised concerns over shipping disruptions, with insurers reportedly withdrawing coverage and tanker movement slowing.

Oil prices had earlier surged to USD 119 per barrel in June 2022 following Russia’s invasion of Ukraine. While companies recorded modest profits that year, they reported a record Rs 81,000 crore profit in FY24, helping offset earlier margin pressures. In the current financial year, the three state-run firms posted a combined profit of Rs 23,743 crore in the December quarter alone.

Mamata

this state. Do people from other states know Bengal? They don’t know the people here, the culture, harmony, booths or subdivisions. They don’t know the festivals here. Who will see all this? If anything happens after this, the BJP government will be responsible.”

She further alleged that the BJP was desperate to capture power in the state and was using all possible means, with the Election Commission acting as a “primary facilitator”. The “arbitrary removal” of state officials, she claimed, was aimed at influencing the elections by enabling the entry of black money, smuggling of arms and drugs through border areas, and engineering riots.

Banerjee also alleged that a “dangerous blueprint” was being prepared to alter Bengal’s geographical structure by excluding North Bengal and merging parts of neighbouring Bihar to form a new state.

Raising concerns over future electoral processes, she said delimitation, NRC and census-related exercises could be used to remove names of genuine voters from electoral rolls to benefit the ruling party at the Centre.

Criticising privatisation, Banerjee claimed that major public sector entities such as Air India and the Life Insurance Corporation of India were being sold against national interest, while those involved in bank frauds had fled the country.

Calling for unity among Hindus, Buddhists, Sikhs and Jains, she urged voters to reject the BJP’s “politics of fear and inducement” and unite to defend democracy and protect Bengal’s identity, culture and language by supporting the Trinamool Congress in the upcoming Assembly polls.

Govt blocks

The Centre has stated its intent to build a safe and accountable online gaming environment while encouraging legitimate sectors such as e-sports and social gaming. The 2025 law seeks to support innovation in these areas while banning online money games in all forms. The prohibition covers games of chance, games of skill, and any hybrid formats involving real-money stakes.

The legislation also outlaws the promotion, advertisement, and facilitation of such activities, including financial transactions routed through banks or payment systems. It grants authorities the power to block access to unlawful platforms under the Information Technology Act, 2000, and lays down strict penalties for violations.

Under the law, offering or facilitating online money games can lead to imprisonment of up to three years or a fine of up to Rs

1 crore, or both. Repeat offenders face harsher consequences, including a minimum jail term of three years that may extend to five years, along with fines ranging from Rs 1 crore to Rs 2 crore.

Advertising such platforms is also punishable, with penalties of up to two years in prison or fines up to Rs 50 lakh, or both, with stricter provisions for subsequent offences.

The Act further provides for the establishment of a national Online Gaming Authority of India. This body will classify and register permissible games, determine whether a game involves monetary stakes, issue regulatory guidelines, and handle user grievances. It also introduces a transparent registration framework and safeguards aimed at preventing harm linked to prohibited online gaming activities.

India-China

communication systems, banking arrangements, security and medical support for traders.

Border trade through Lipulekh had resumed in 1992 but was halted in 2019 due to the Covid-19 pandemic.

Jeevan Singh Ronkali, president of the Simant Vyapar Sangathan, welcomed the move, saying traders would now be able to recover goods left in warehouses in Tibet’s Taklaktok.

North India

across various stations, contributing to what has become the wettest March in three years so far.

Neighbouring regions of Punjab and Haryana also witnessed persistent rainfall for a second consecutive day, dragging temperatures down significantly. Chandigarh recorded a maximum of 18.8 degrees Celsius, about 10 degrees below normal. Similar trends were observed across cities such as Ambala, Hisar, Ludhiana and Patiala, where maximum temperatures remained well below seasonal norms.

Uttar Pradesh experienced widespread thunderstorm activity accompanied by lightning and strong winds, offering respite from earlier heat but bringing hazardous conditions. According to Atul Kumar Singh, a senior scientist at the Regional Meteorological Centre in Lucknow, “the impact of the weather system will continue across eastern Uttar Pradesh, central regions and Bundelkhand on Saturday, with strong winds and thunderstorms expected in most parts of the state.” The Met department issued an orange alert for hailstorms in about 27 districts, including Meerut, Agra, Mathura and Kanpur Dehat. Wind speeds during thunderstorms are expected to range between 40 and 60 kilometres per hour. Rainfall was recorded in most districts, with Hamirpur receiving the highest at 40 mm, followed by Bareilly, Shahjahanpur and Aligarh with 24 mm each.

Lucknow recorded 18 mm of rainfall, with its maximum temperature plunging to 23.5 degrees Celsius, nearly 10 degrees below normal. Western districts such as Muzaffarnagar and Meerut saw even sharper drops, with daytime temperatures dipping to 17.8 degrees and 18.4 degrees Celsius respectively. Overall, temperatures across the state are expected to fall by 5 to 7 degrees Celsius over a two-day period.

While the plains dealt with rain and storms, hill states experienced intense winter-like conditions. In Uttarakhand, heavy snowfall blanketed high-altitude pilgrimage sites, including Badrinath, Kedarnath, Gangotri and Yamunotri. Kedarnath recorded

up to four feet of snow by Friday evening, while Badrinath received around two feet.

The snowfall, described as among the heaviest in March in recent years, led to a sharp drop in temperatures across the state. Dehradun recorded a maximum of 17.4 degrees Celsius, about 11 degrees below normal. Authorities issued an orange alert for several districts, warning of heavy rain, snowfall, hailstorms and gusty winds of up to 50 kilometres per hour.

Similar conditions prevailed in Himachal Pradesh, where higher reaches such as Manali, Rohtang Pass and the Atal Tunnel were buried under 90 to 120 cm of snow. Continuous snowfall in Lahaul and Spiti cut off several areas, while landslides blocked key routes including the Bhuntar Manikaran road, leaving vehicles stranded. Manali recorded the highest rainfall in the state at 87 mm, with several other towns also receiving heavy precipitation.

Meteorological officials have warned of continued wet conditions in Himachal Pradesh until March 25, with thunderstorms and gusty winds expected in some districts early next week.

Further east, parts of West Bengal are bracing for thunderstorms, lightning and hailstorms accompanied by gusty winds reaching up to 60 to 70 kilometres per hour. Heavy to very heavy rainfall is likely in northern districts such as Jalpaiguri and Alipurdura, while southern districts including Purulia and Bankura may experience thundersqualls.

In the Northeast, Arunachal Pradesh is expected to see multiple days of thunderstorm activity with lightning and heavy rain across several districts through early next week, indicating the widespread influence of unstable atmospheric conditions.

The weather system has also affected central and western India. Rajasthan recorded light to moderate rainfall, with Nokha in Bikaner receiving 25 mm over 24 hours. Temperatures across the state remained 2 to 8 degrees below normal, although conditions are expected to turn largely dry over the next four to five days.

At the national level, the impact of unseasonal rain and hailstorms has raised concerns for agriculture. Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan said that standing rabi crops, including wheat, have been affected in several states. “Not only did it rain, but many areas also experienced hailstorms, resulting in damage to the crops,” he said, adding that officials have been directed to coordinate with state governments to assess losses and ensure proper processing of insurance claims.

The India Meteorological Department has also warned of two additional western disturbances in the coming days, prompting advisories for farmers and authorities to remain alert.

Despite the widespread activity, forecasts suggest that rainfall over North India will begin to ease gradually. While isolated weather events may persist in hill regions, the plains are expected to see a reduction in precipitation. However, dense-to-moderate fog is likely to continue in parts of Punjab and adjoining areas, potentially affecting visibility during early morning and late night hours. Meteorologists say temperatures will follow a mixed trend, with minimum temperatures remaining relatively low in several cities, bringing a chill to mornings and nights, while increasing cloud cover across the northwestern plains may influence daytime conditions.

As the current system weakens, a transition phase is expected, marked by fluctuating temperatures, lingering cloudiness and patchy fog, keeping weather conditions unsettled even as the intensity of rainfall declines.

ASKS BJP HOW IT WILL FACE VOTERS

Congress fires salvo over LPG crisis, dares BJP on voter test

OUR CORRESPONDENT

BENGALURU: Attacking the Narendra Modi-led government in the centre over the LPG cylinder crisis in the country, Congress General Secretary Randeep Singh Surjewala on Friday asked the BJP, how will it go to the voters in poll-bound states.

Claiming that the country was facing a “huge crisis”, he attacked the centre over the depreciation of the Indian rupee to Rs 93 against the US dollar, terming it “worrisome” for both the economy and employment.

Surjewala, who is also the party in charge of Karnataka, said that during the tenure of Manmohan Singh as PM, Modi had said that the “prestige of the prime minister falls when the value of the rupee declines”. Then the value of the Indian Rupee against the USD was at Rs 54



Karnataka Deputy CM DK Shivakumar and Congress leader Randeep Surjewala during a meeting for the Assembly by-elections, in Bengaluru, on Friday

PFI

for a dollar. Speaking to reporters here, he alleged that despite the current situation, the government and the BJP remained “on mute mode”,

Highlights

» Claiming that the country was facing a “huge crisis”, he attacked the centre over the depreciation of the Indian rupee to Rs 93 against the US dollar, terming it “worrisome” for both the economy and employment

» The Congress leader alleged that people were buying gas cylinders in black at Rs 1,300. He further alleged that the Centre had raised the price of domestic gas twice and commercial gas thrice

while ordinary households, small dhabas, restaurants and eateries were facing a severe crisis with a shortage of both commercial and domestic gas.

“Today, the Indian rupee has fallen to 93 rupees to a dollar, but the BJP, Prime Minister Modi and their government remain on a mute mode. Ordinary households, small dhabas and restaurants, and small eateries feel the crisis today. No commercial gas is available, no domestic gas is available,” he claimed.

The Congress leader alleged that people were buying gas cylinders in black at Rs 1,300.

“At this price, we will have to employ a security guard to protect every cylinder in India,” he said sarcastically and alleged that the BJP is not taking responsibility for the situation.

He further alleged that the Centre had raised the price of domestic gas twice and commercial gas thrice.

“Tomorrow you will again

raise the price of petrol and diesel. What should the ordinary Indian do? Does the BJP have any answer? Do they even have a right to go and seek votes?” he asked.

While Assam, Tamil Nadu, Kerala, West Bengal and Puducherry are facing Assembly polls, two seats in Karnataka -- Davangere South and Bagalkot -- will go for by-elections.

Speaking to reporters here, Surjewala demanded answers from BJP leaders and JD(S) leader H D Kumaraswamy.

“We demand from Kumaraswamy why he is keeping mum? Why are they quiet? Price of commercial gas goes up three times, the price of domestic gas goes up two times, the price of premium petrol and diesel goes up, and the price of petrol and diesel is about to go up,” he said.

Rahul pitches UDF, says Kerala wants change as polls loom

‘For me, Keralam is home and its Keralam are family’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: People of Kerala are ready for change, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi said on Friday, as he pitched for a UDF government in the state.

“Team UDF is Team Kerala,” he said in a post on X.

“Each candidate reflects the voice, the aspirations and the trust of the people of Kerala. This is a collective of experienced leaders and young change-makers - a strong team of men and women who understand the intricacies of the constituencies they represent,” Gandhi said in his post.

“For me, Keralam is home and the people of Keralam are family. I owe a great debt to the people for everything they have taught me and for the love and warmth they have embraced me with - I will always be your partner,” the former Wayanad MP said.

“The message from Kerala



Rahul Gandhi said that ‘team UDF is team Kerala’

PFI

His message came a day after Congress released its list of 92 candidates

in Kerala.

Gandhi’s message came a day after the Congress released its list of 92 candidates for the April 9 assembly election in the state.

Determined to take on the ruling Left Democratic Front (LDF), the Congress on Thursday banked on its state leadership to see it through, deciding against fielding any of its MPs.

The party braved internal pressures by banking on its Kerala leadership rather than sending parliamentarians to fight the polls. The Congress is contesting 92 seats, leaving others for its allies in the UDF and some independents.

The Congress has been out of power in the southern state for a decade.

PM Modi greets Thai PM on re-election

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday congratulated Anutin Charnvirakul on his re-election as the prime minister of Thailand and said he was looking forward to working closely with him to further deepen the multifaceted strategic partnership between the two nations.

Charnvirakul won a vote in parliament on Thursday to remain in office.

“Heartiest congratulations to Mr. Anutin Charnvirakul on his election as Prime Minister of the Kingdom of Thailand. I look forward to working closely with him. Together, we will further deepen the multifaceted

India-Thailand Strategic Partnership,” Modi said in a post on X.

The PM said India-Thailand ties are rooted in shared civilisational heritage, close cultural connect and vibrant people-to-people ties.

“India and Thailand remain united in our shared aspirations for peace, progress and prosperity for our peoples,” Modi said.

Charnvirakul, the leader of the Bhum Jai Thai Party, garnered 293 votes, exceeding the required majority of 498 members who attended the session in the House of Representatives.

He is expected to take office in a few days.

MPOST

Modi should openly come out against West Asia conflict: Owaisi



Asaduddin Owaisi criticised government’s foreign policies

FILE

more weight in what you say. The prime minister was speaking to different leaders (of other countries). You openly say that this war is wrong,” he said.

If Modi does not have love for Iran, Qatar and other West Asian nations, he should oppose the ongoing conflict at least for the sake of one crore Indians who work there and send 50 per cent of India’s foreign exchange, he claimed.

He charged that the BJP-RSS does not have concern for the Indians working in the West Asia region, but the organisations have become the “beloved” of Trump and Netanyahu.

If the host countries send the Indians back, post-conflict, due to pressure on their economies, will Modi take care of their livelihood, he asked.

The Hyderabad MP said India’s Strategic Petroleum Reserve (SPR) is adequate for only 9.50 days, whereas international bodies suggest that the reserves should last 90 days. Describing Pakistan as a “younger brother of Israel”, he said the two countries would never let their neighbours live peacefully, finding fault with Pakistan for carrying out attacks on Afghanistan.

AGENCIES

Alliance locked: Congress, Rajior Dal; 11 seats to state party

Cong has announced complete list of 87 seats, along with a woman hopeful

GUWAHATI: After days of negotiation and uncertainty, the Congress and Rajior Dal finalised seat-sharing arrangements for the Assam assembly polls, and decided that the national party will leave 11 constituencies for the other one, and there will be a friendly contest in two. In a late-night development on Thursday at Jorhat, leaders of the two parties, headed by state Congress president Gaurav Gogoi and Rajior Dal chief Akhil Gogoi, signed the agreement.

Akhil Gogoi will contest from Sivasagar, a seat he won in the last polls while still in prison on sedition charges for allegedly instigating violence during the Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) protests.

The Congress had given the Margherita seat to the Rajior Dal. Earlier, the national party had given it to Prateek Bordoloi, who decided not to contest on a Congress ticket after his father defected to the BJP earlier this week.

The other seats to be contested by Rajior Dal are Dalgaoon, Dhing, Sissiborgaon, Digboi, Bokakhat, Manas, Tezpur and Kaliabor, while friendly contests will take place between the two parties in Goalpara (East) and Gauripur.

The party has nominated a woman candidate, Gyanashree Bora, from the Mariani constituency.

The opposition alliance now comprises six parties -- Con-

Himanta files nomination from Jalikbari

GUWAHATI: Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma filed nomination papers on Friday, seeking re-election from the Jalukbari constituency for the sixth term in a row. Sarma was accompanied by his wife Riniki Bhuyan Sarma, son Nandil Biswa Sarma, BJP’s Gauhati Lok Sabha MP Bijuli Kalita Medhi and Guwahati Mayor Mrigen Sarania. Before reaching the Kamrup (Metropolitan) District Election office to file the nomination, the CM, atop an open vehicle, led a large procession from the Veterinary Field at Khanapara to the election office at Hengrabari, a distance of about 5.6 kms. The BJP leader got off the vehicle at Last Gate in Dispur, walked for a few minutes, and then entered another vehicle to reach the office of the district commissioner cum district electoral officer.

AGENCIES

gress, Rajior Dal, Assam Jatiya Parishad (AJP), CPI(M), All Party Hill Leaders Conference (APHLC) and the CPI(ML). The Congress has announced its complete list of 87 seats, the AJP in 10 seats while the CPI(M) and APHLC will contest in two seats each.

MPOST

Ramados’ PMK, Sasikala’s outfit team up for TN polls

VILLUPURAM: PMK, led by its founder S Ramados, and AIPTMMK, a new outfit helmed by the confidante of late chief minister J Jayalithaa, VK Sasikala, on Friday entered into a pact to jointly fight the Assembly polls in Tamil Nadu and Puducherry.

Announcing the decision at a crowded press conference at Thailapuram near here, Ramados said: “This is a victorious alliance, this combine will win big.” Further, the octogenarian leader said that the Pattali Makkal Katchi--All India Puratchi Thalaivar Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam alliance will make a big impact in Tamil Nadu and that there need not be any doubt about it.

“Today itself, the signing of this pact would have made several persons tremble,” he claimed. To a question, Ramados said the alliance would field candidates “in all the 234 Assembly constituencies” and welcomed like-minded parties to the alliance.

AGENCIES

Nitish launches projects worth over Rs 1K crore

GAYAJI/ AURANGABAD: Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar on Friday launched development projects worth around Rs 1,422 crore in Gayaji and Aurangabad districts during his ‘Samridhi Yatra’.

He also reviewed ongoing schemes and projects in both districts, according to an official statement.

According to a statement by the Chief Minister’s Office, “Kumar launched 673 development schemes worth Rs 744 crore in Gayaji district. These include the inauguration of 553 schemes costing Rs 367 crore and foundation stones for 140 schemes worth Rs 377 crore.”

Kumar also reviewed development works in the district, including construction of bridges over Badki and Majhiawan rivers in Bankey Bazar



Nitish Kumar during the Samridhi Yatra, in Aurangabad, on Friday

PFI

block, block-cum-zonal office and residential buildings, the Bada Bandh check dam irrigation project, widening and strengthening of the Imamganj-Pakri (Jharkhand border) road via Kothi and Salaiya, etc.

He handed over a symbolic cheque of Rs 609 crore to 13,334 women associated with Jeevika self-help groups.

Later, in Aurangabad, he launched 262 projects worth around Rs 678 crore, including the inauguration of 142 projects costing Rs 123 crore and foundation laying for 120 projects worth Rs 555 crore.

The CM visited ward No. 3 of Barun Nagar Panchayat in the district, where he inspected the progress of drinking

‘Lock up’ party office: DMK jabs Palaniswami for Delhi alliance talks

CHENNAI: The ruling DMK on Friday took a swipe at AIADMK chief Edappadi K Palaniswami for holding seat-sharing talks in Delhi with the BJP, indicating it was unprecedented as the opposition party was leading the NDA in Tamil Nadu.

In a sarcastic tone, DMK leader and state minister KN Nehru asked the AIADMK to lock its headquarters here, wondering how the Tamil Nadu-based party leading the coalition could have the seat-sharing talks in the national capital.

Similar to investigating agencies sending summons, Union Home Minister Amit Shah has invited Palaniswami for seat-sharing talks, Nehru

DMK leader KN Nehru wondered how Palaniswami could have the seat-sharing talks in the national capital

alleged about Palaniswami’s meeting with the BJP leader.

Meanwhile, TN BJP unit Chief Nainar Nagenthiran hit back at the DMK over seat-sharing saying, “What is wrong in that?”

In a statement, Nehru. The DMK principal secretary said, “if AIADMK is leading the NDA in Tamil Nadu, then seat-sharing talks should

have taken place at its headquarters in Chennai. But, Palaniswami is holding talks at Amit Shah’s residence.”

“Not even once have seat-sharing talks been held at the office of the party that is supposed to lead the alliance. Neither have the discussions happened at the Chennai residence of Palaniswami.”

Nehru questioned whether the meeting could not be held at the AIADMK headquarters at Royapettah built by its late founder M G Ramachandran.

In a swipe at Palaniswami, he said: “You may lock the party headquarters in Avvai Shanmugham Salai in Royapettah until the elections are over.”

MPOST

HYDERABAD: Alleging that Prime Minister Narendra Modi became close to his Israeli counterpart Benjamin Netanyahu and US President Donald Trump in contrast to India’s neutral stance vis-à-vis West Asia in the past, AIMIM president Asaduddin Owaisi on Friday said Modi should openly affirm that the ongoing military conflict is wrong.

Addressing a gathering at the Makkah Masjid here, he said India has maintained friendly ties with all countries in West Asia, though it treated the cause of Palestinians as its own.

“What did Modi do? Modi became close to Trump and Netanyahu. Now, how can you stop war? If you are neutral, maybe there would have been

Railways sweeten deal, hike loco pilots’ allowance by 25%, cheers over 2 lakh staff

Move ends two-year wait for over two lakh running staff after protests and repeated union demands

NEW DELHI: Meeting a long-standing demand of over two lakh train operations staff, the Railway Board on Friday announced a 25 per cent increase in the kilometrage allowance for loco running staff with retrospective effect from January 1, 2024.

The announcement comes after over two years of persistent representations and protests by various railway employee unions and federations.

An official order issued on Friday said that following a 50 per cent increase in dearness allowance (DA) effective from January 1, 2024, the Board decided to increase the kilometrage allowance for various categories of loco running staff from the same date.

The order noted that the matter was examined in consultation with the Finance Department of the Railway Board and referred to the Ministry of Finance (Department of Expenditure) for concurrence after persistent demand by recognised federations,



Revision has been aligned with DA hike and pay commission norms

FILE

including the AIRF and NFIR. The decision has brought cheers among over two lakh employees engaged in train operations who had staged protests in support of the hike.

Unlike other railway employees who receive a Travelling Allowance (TA), loco running staff are granted a kilometrage allowance (KA). While TA for other staff was enhanced on January 1, 2024, the KA had remained unchanged until now, a loco pilot said. According to the All

India Loco Running Staff Association (AILRSA), the rates for kilometrage allowance are derived from two components: 30 per cent of basic pay and 20 days of Travelling Allowance.

The association official bearers explained that the previous rates of Rs 525 per 100 kms was based on a TA rate of Rs 800 per day. With TA rising to Rs 1000 due to dearness allowance reaching 50 per cent of basic pay, a proportional revision of the KA becomes necessary. This enhancement

Key Points

» The announcement comes after over two years of persistent representations and protests by various railway employee unions and federations

» The decision has brought cheers among over two lakh employees engaged in train operations who had staged protests in

support of the hike

» Unlike other railway employees who receive a Travelling Allowance (TA), loco running staff are granted a kilometrage allowance (KA). While TA for other staff was enhanced on January 1, 2024, the KA had remained unchanged until now, a loco pilot said

is in accordance with the recommendations of the 7th Central Pay Commission. “Having raised the travelling allowance from Rs 800 to Rs 1000, the rate of kilometrage allowance also needed to be enhanced,” a loco pilot said, while complaining about the delay.

Running staff pointed out that similar 25 per cent hikes were implemented in 2011 and 2014 following dearness allowance thresholds, yet the current revision faced a significant delay. K C James, Sec-

retary General of the AILRSA, said that while the board eventually conceded to the genuine demand, the two-year delay caused distress among the staff.

“The undue delay of two years in conceding this demand already caused irreparable deterioration in the harmonious relationship between the running staff and management. The board should fix the accountability on the top management for creating such undesirable industrial relations in the railway,” he said.

Nation Briefs

MANIPUR CM INVITES KUKI ZO COUNCIL FOR TALKS ON RESTORING PEACE

IMPHAL: Manipur Chief Minister Y Khemchand Singh has invited members of the Kuki Zo Council for a meeting to discuss steps to restore peace and normalcy in the ethnic strife-hit state, officials said on Friday. In a letter addressed to the chairman of the Kuki Zo Council, the secretary to the chief minister conveyed Singh’s request for a meeting with council members on Saturday in Guwahati to deliberate on issues related to restoring normalcy in the state. “I am directed to refer to the above subject and convey the request of the Chief Minister of Manipur to have a meeting with you and other members of the Kuki Zo Council to discuss matters related to bringing back peace and normalcy in Manipur,” the letter stated. Whether the they would attend the meeting was yet to be confirmed.

‘60 DRUG SAMPLES OF VARIOUS FIRMS NOT OF STANDARD QUALITY’

NEW DELHI: The Central Drugs Laboratories have found 60 drug samples manufactured by various firms to be “not of standard quality (NSQ)” in its monthly drug alert for February, health ministry officials said on Friday. The state drug testing laboratories have identified 134 drug samples as NSQ, they said. According to a routine regulatory surveillance activity, the list of Not of Standard Quality (NSQ) and Spurious drugs is being displayed on the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation portal on a monthly basis.

SEEKS REVIEW TO ENSURE RURAL CONNECTIVITY

Parl panel flags outdated norms in PMGSY

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Rural Development has recommended a comprehensive revision of population and eligibility norms under the Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana (PMGSY), flagging concerns that outdated benchmarks are leading to the exclusion of deserving rural habitations.

The panel, chaired by Congress MP Saptagiri Sankar Ulaka, also suggested that government assistance for the construction of houses under the PMAY-G should be enhanced to Rs four lakh.

The committee stated that the identification and prioritisation of habitations under PMGSY continues to rely on “older population benchmarks and legacy data”, which in many areas no longer reflect the present demographic realities on the ground.

It observed that “dependence on outdated population parameters may result in exclusion of deserving habitations” and recommended a review of norms to better capture “present-day population realities and actual connectivity deprivation”.

Highlights

- » Panel also suggested that govt assistance for construction of houses under the PMAY-G should be enhanced to Rs four lakh
- » The committee also raised concerns over districts classified as ‘saturated’ under PMGSY
- » Regarding PMAY-G, the panel noted that the current per unit assistance ‘has remained static for a considerable period of time’



The committee also raised concerns over districts classified as “saturated” under PMGSY, stating that “mere classification of a district as saturated cannot be a ground for overlooking habitations that remain genuinely unconnected”.

It pointed out that several habitations in forest-fringe, hilly and difficult areas still lack all-weather road connectivity, and called for a “fresh and detailed reassessment” of such districts to ensure “universal road access is actually achieved”.

The panel recommended that the department undertake a fresh and detailed reassessment of such districts, with special focus on habitations left

out on account of forest and difficult-area constraints, and ensure that districts where genuine connectivity gaps continue are not treated as fully saturated till universal road access is actually achieved.

Further, the panel flagged delays in appraisal and approval of road proposals, noting that such lags “adversely affect execution timelines, escalate costs and delay the intended ben-

efits”. It noted that “avoidable procedural delays defeat the core objective of the scheme”, and recommended streamlining approvals through defined timelines, better coordination with states and regular monitoring of pending proposals.

Regarding Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana-Gramin (PMAY-G), the panel noted that the current per unit assistance “has remained static for a considerable period of time” despite rising costs of materials, labour and transportation.

It observed that beneficiaries are often compelled to mobilise additional resources, with “the actual expenditure significantly exceeding the present assistance”, and recommended that the assistance be enhanced to “a minimum of Rs 4 lakh per unit” to ensure construction of a durable house without financial distress.

The panel also called for the inclusion of landless households through a suitable policy framework, including land allotment or community-based models in coordination with states.

NCERT CHAPTER ON JUDICIARY

Centre forms expert committee

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Centre on Friday informed the Supreme Court that it had constituted an expert committee comprising two former apex court judges and an ex-attorney general to review the class 8 NCERT book with a chapter on corruption in the judiciary.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta told a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi that the committee comprises senior advocate and former Attorney General KK Venugopal, former top court judge Justice Indu Malhotra, and former Supreme Court judge and current National Judicial Academy director Justice Aniruddha Bose, along with a vice chancellor.

“We have formed a committee to draft the chapter. KK Venugopal will be a member of the committee. Justice Indu Malhotra will also be a part. We have also requested Justice Aniruddha Bose from the National Judicial Academy to be there,” Mehta said.

The top court was hearing



Closer Look

» SC was hearing a petition by former NCERT member Pankaj Pushkar against a passage in an older class 8 textbook

» The top court refused to entertain the petition, observing that the judiciary should not be oversensitive about a healthy criticism

a petition by former NCERT member Pankaj Pushkar against a passage in an older class 8 textbook that read, “recent judgments tend to view the slum dweller as an encroacher in the city.”

The top court refused to entertain the petition, observing that the judiciary should not be oversensitive about a healthy criticism.

“It’s a viewpoint about a judgment. That’s a healthy criticism. Why the judiciary should

be so oversensitive about that. This part of the book points out what is the structure of the judiciary, how they work, what they have done, some good has also been highlighted.

“Then they say, however, there are also Court judgments that people believe work against the best interests of common persons ... This is a viewpoint about a judgment, people have a right to criticise our judgments,” the CJ observed orally.

Chh’garh all set to host First Khelo India Tribal Games from March 25 to April 3

Events to be held in Raipur, Jagdalpur and Ambikapur

OUR CORRESPONDENT

RAIPUR: As the National Tribal Games is round the corner, Chhattisgarh is all set to welcome around 3,700 participants from across India from March 25th to April 3rd.

Attributing to the legacy of archery sports in the Tribal community and giving credit to success of Bastar Olympics and gaming events, Chhattisgarh earned the opportunity to host the national event for the first time - reflecting Chhattisgarh’s progress toward peace and development.

“Hosting the Khelo India Tribal Games 2026 is a proud moment for Chhattisgarh.

Youth are the future of our nation and state, and the government is fully committed to empowering them through education, employment, skill development, and sports. This event will not only showcase the incredible talent of our tribal athletes but also launch them onto the national stage,” said Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai.

Owing to success of previous events and rise in registration numbers of Bastar Olympics of year 2024 and 2025 along with Tribal dominated Surguja Olympics - which witnessed surging registration of 1.65 lakh, 3.91 lakh and more than 3.49 lakh

respectively - reflects the community’s strong enthusiasm for sports and games. The remarkable strength and endurance of the tribal population have inspired athletes to participate across a wide range of disciplines, including archery, football, wrestling, Mallakhamb, and athletics.

Chhattisgarh boasts robust sports infrastructure including world-class synthetic hockey turfs worth Rs 4.99 crore is developed in Jashpur, synthetic athletic track at Mahasamund worth Rs 6.60 crore an synthetic turf football ground with running track worth Rs 5 crore has been developed in Jagdalpur in past two years.

‘AI to be next big turning point for Punjab’s agri’

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Friday positioned Artificial Intelligence (AI) as the next big turning point for Punjab’s agriculture, arguing that traditional farming has hit its limits and can no longer sustain farmers’ incomes.

Making a strong case for technological intervention, he said the move is aimed at reversing declining profitability, reducing pressure on natural resources, and securing the future of farmers.

At the same time, he sharpened his political attack on the Opposition, calling them out for pushing Punjab into crisis through years of neglect, and asserted that his government is now rebuilding the state with reform-driven policies focused on farmers, infrastructure, and



Bhagwant Mann MPOST

welfare.

Addressing the state-level Kisan Mela at Punjab Agricultural University (PAU), Punjab CM stated, “Punjab has been the food bowl of the country, making India self-reliant in food production. The hardworking and resilient farmers of the state scripted a new chapter during the Green Revolution of the 1960s. However, in serving the nation, farmers have sacrificed precious natural resources like fertile soil and water.”

He noted the growing crisis in agriculture, stating, “With shrinking profit margins, agriculture is no longer a profitable proposition, and farmers are struggling for basic subsistence. The production potential of existing crop technologies has nearly plateaued. To enhance real farm incomes and check over-exploitation of resources, it is imperative to introduce AI in agriculture.”

Listing pro-farmer initiatives, he continued, “For the first time, more than eight hours of uninterrupted power was supplied to farm tube wells during the paddy season. Farmers are now receiving daytime electricity for irrigation, transforming their lives. Punjab farmers are also getting the highest sugarcane price in the country at ₹416 per quintal. Every year, around ₹80,000 crore is paid to farmers for wheat and paddy procurement, with

payments transferred directly to bank accounts within 24 hours. Between 2022 and 2025, ₹6,700 crore has been spent on canal lining, repair, and modernisation, which is 300 per cent more than previous years. Canal irrigation usage has increased from 20.90 lakh acres in 2022 to 58 lakh acres today.”

Meanwhile, continuing his series ‘Shandaar Chaar Saal Bhagwant Mann De Naal’, Punjab Chief Minister on Friday presented the four-year report card of the health sector, after earlier detailing the AAP government’s work in agriculture and irrigation. Drawing a sharp contrast between a “condition-ridden” Ayushman Bharat and the AAP government’s Mukh Mantri Sehat Yojna, he asserted that the difference lies in intent and delivery, positioning the initiative as a model of universal, accessible healthcare.

CBI questions Anil Ambani again in Rs 2,929 cr fraud case

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) questioned Anil Dhirubhai Ambani again on Friday in the Rs 2,929.05 crore bank fraud case involving Reliance Communications Limited.

Ambani returned to the CBI headquarters for the second day in a row. He was questioned for about seven hours. He had been interviewed before on Thursday, but that session was incomplete.

The case began on August 21, 2025, after a complaint from the State Bank of India. The complaint alleged that loan funds were misused between 2013 and 2017. A forensic audit report highlighted complicated transactions among group entities, leading to a loss of Rs 2,929.05 crore to SBI out of a total exposure of Rs 19,694.33 crore involving multiple public sector banks.

After the FIR, more complaints came in from several banks, including Punjab National Bank, Bank of India, Union Bank of India, UCO Bank, Central Bank of India, IDBI Bank, and Bank of Maharashtra. New cases also opened in February and March 2026 based on complaints from Bank of Baroda and Punjab National Bank, naming other accused such as Manjari Ashok Kacker.

The agency had previously searched locations in Mumbai in August 2025 and recovered several incriminating documents.

Haryana CM announces new focus areas, reviews CMGGA field work

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini, chaired a review meeting of the Chief Minister’s Good Governance Associates (CMGGA) at the Swarna Jayanti Haryana Institute for Fiscal Management (SJHIFM), Sector-3 Panchkula on Friday.

The meeting was attended by Chief Principal Secretary to Chief Minister, Rajesh Khulhar, Deputy Principal Secretary to Chief Minister, Yashpal, Director General, SJHIFM Raj Nehru, GVF CEO, Sumit Kumar, Rishihood University CEO, Sahil Aggarwal and Head of Programmes, GVF Ms. Vasundhara.

During the review, the Chief Minister assessed the previous month’s field work carried out by CMGGAs under two modules - Solid Waste Management and Human Resources. He appreciated the work undertaken by the associates so far and encouraged them to continue contributing actively to the state’s governance and development priorities.

The Chief Minister also directed that a meeting with Deputy Commissioners be convened to discuss key issues emerging from the field. He emphasised the importance of stronger coordination with district officials to ensure effective resolution of challenges identified by the associates.

The review also marked the introduction of new focus areas for CMGGAs. In the health sector, associates will work to strengthen the implementation of Ayushman Bharat and Chirayu Yojana in Haryana. In education, the focus will be on school infrastructure and implementation of the National Education Policy. In the water sector, priority areas will include water management, rainwater harvesting, and pond rejuvenation.

SIGNALS BJP’S SOUTHERN OUTREACH
Ram Yantra from Tamil Nadu installed in Ayodhya ahead of polls

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

AYODHYA: The installation of the ‘Shri Ram Yantra’ at the Ram Mandir Ayodhya on the eve of Navratri is being viewed as a development with political undertones, as the Bharatiya Janata Party sharpens its outreach in Tamil Nadu ahead of upcoming elections.

Crafted in Tamil Nadu and installed on the second floor of the temple during the visit of President Droupadi Murmu on March 19, the Ram Yantra represents a symbolic link between the southern state and Ayodhya. While the ceremony was conducted with traditional rituals,

Ram Yantra represents a symbolic link between the southern state and Ayodhya

the timing and the north-south connection have drawn attention in political circles.

The yantra, weighing around 150 kilograms and measuring 3 by 3 feet, is made of a traditional five-metal alloy and coated with 24-carat gold. Its structure features intricate geometric patterns, including interlocking triangles and

concentric circles, designed according to classical temple architecture principles.

In Hindu belief, yantras are considered spiritual diagrams that channel cosmic energy, and the Shri Ram Yantra is associated with the ideals of Lord Ram such as righteousness, victory and protection.

Temple sources said the yantra carries a Sanskrit inscription invoking the eternal presence of Lord Ram in Ayodhya, along with prayers seeking protection through Lord Hanuman. However, beyond its religious significance, the installation is also being interpreted through a political lens.

Economic Survey: Himachal Pradesh’s economy strong, GSDP grows at 8.3%

Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu tabled the economic survey report

ASHWANI SHARMA



Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu

SHIMLA: Despite the acute fiscal crisis, setbacks in the Revenue Deficit Grant, and a series of natural disasters wrecking the state, Himachal Pradesh’s economy has looked stronger, and per capita income has also improved significantly during 2025-26.

Ahead of the state’s Budget, which is being presented in the House on Saturday for the year 2026-27, Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu tabled the economic survey report.

The state, a predominantly rural economy dependent largely on the farm sector, tourism, and hydropower, shows a continuous increase in its per capita income—a sign of stability in the hill economy.

The per capita income has increased to Rs 2,83,626 in the year 2025-26, which is 9.8 per cent more than the previous year and Rs 64,051 more than the national average. In the year 2011-12, this figure was Rs 87,721.

According to the survey, the total economic production capacity of Himachal Pradesh in the year 2025-26 is estimated to be around Rs 2.54 lakh crore, which shows an increase of 10.1 per cent as compared to the previous year.

“The growth rate at constant prices is estimated at 8.3 per cent, reflecting the state’s strong economic activity despite global uncertainties and climate challenges. The service sector remains the largest contributor to the state’s economy,” said Deputy Chief Minister Mukesh

Highlights

- » The per capita income has increased to Rs 2,83,626 in the year 2025-26
- » The GSDP at current prices rose to Rs 2,30,587 crore in 2025-26 from Rs 2,09,385 crore in the preceding fiscal

Agnihotri, commenting on the report.

Also, for the first time, the number of tourists in Himachal has crossed the figure of three crores despite monsoon disruptions, infrastructure damage, and human losses.

The GSDP at current prices rose to Rs 2,30,587 crore in 2025-26 from Rs 2,09,385 crore in the preceding fiscal, and the growth at constant prices (2011-12) was recorded at Rs 1,44,656 crore, exhibiting an 8.3 per cent increase against 6.4 per cent in the previous year.

The contribution of the service sector in the year 2025-26 is estimated to be Rs 62,581 crore, which is expected to grow by 8.6 per cent. The sector has been strengthened by the expansion of tourism, trade, transportation, and financial services.

The share of the service sector in the total economic contribution is 46.3 per cent, the industry sector is 39.4 per cent and the agriculture sector is 14.3 per cent. Growth has also been recorded in agriculture and related sectors. The contribution from this sector is estimated to reach Rs 32,415 crore in the years 2025-26. Improvement in crop production has strengthened the rural economy.

The tourism sector has also improved rapidly. In the year 2020, 32.13 lakh tourists came, which has increased to 31.14 lakh in 2025. This sector is contributing significantly to the income of the state. The state is also getting good revenue in the energy sector.

L-G Saxena launches cleanliness, beautification drive in Leh

OUR CORRESPONDENT

LEH: In pursuance of the directions of Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena, a comprehensive cleanliness and urban improvement drive has been launched in Leh city with renewed vigour and commitment. The initiative aims to transform Leh into one of the cleanest, most organised, and tourist-friendly cities in the country.

Acting in mission mode, the concerned government agencies have commenced large-scale operations to remove accumulated dust, construction and demolition waste lying along roadsides across key areas of the city. The initial phase of the drive is focused on prominent locations including Lok Niwas, the Secretariat, Leh main market, Jivetsal, and adjoining areas.

Nation Briefs

NFR REGISTERS SIGNIFICANT GROWTH IN SOLAR POWER GENERATION

MALIGAON: The Northeast Frontier Railway (NFR) continues to make significant strides in its commitment towards green energy and sustainability, with substantial progress achieved in solar power installation across its divisions and units. As of February 2026, the total installed solar capacity across NFR has reached 31.890 MWp since the inception of the solarisation initiative in 2011. During the current financial year 2025-26 alone, an additional 22.734 MWp capacity has been installed, reflecting accelerated efforts toward renewable energy adoption.



GM INSPECTS MOKAMA-BARAUNI-SAMASTIPUR-DARBHANGA-LAUKHA BAZAR SECTION

HAJIPUR: Chhatrasal Singh, General Manager, East Central Railway on Friday conducted a window trailing inspection of the Mokama-Barauni-Samastipur-Darbhanga-Sakari-Jhanjharpur-Laukha Bazar section. During the inspection, the General Manager reviewed safety aspects, including stations, bridges, and tracks along the section. During the inspection, the General Manager laid special emphasis on safety and instructed to always be vigilant about it.



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EDITORIAL

ANATOMY OF POWER

Israel's targeted strikes on Iran's top leadership mark one of the most dramatic escalations in West Asia in recent decades, raising a fundamental question: can a state be destabilised—or even dismantled—by decapitating its leadership? The killing of Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, followed by the elimination of key figures such as Ali Larijani and several senior military and political leaders, signals a strategic shift from conventional warfare to leadership-centric disruption. At one level, the strikes appear to have achieved their immediate objective—disorienting Iran's command structure. But beneath the headlines lies a more complex reality. States, particularly those built on ideological foundations like the Islamic Republic of Iran, are rarely as fragile as they appear. The assumption that removing top leaders will automatically trigger collapse often underestimates the depth and resilience of institutional structures that sustain such regimes.

The swift elevation of Mojtaba Khamenei as the new Supreme Leader reflects both continuity and uncertainty. Unlike his father, Mojtaba lacks a formal political track record and the clerical legitimacy that Ayatollah Khamenei had accumulated over decades. His close ties with the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) may provide him with a power base, but they also underscore a shift in the balance of authority—from clerical dominance to military influence. His absence from public view following the strikes, coupled with reports of personal loss and possible injury, has only deepened speculation about his ability to consolidate control. Israeli claims that Iran's leadership is in disarray may not be entirely unfounded in the immediate aftermath. Yet, history cautions against equating temporary disruption with systemic breakdown. Power vacuums in such systems are rarely left unfilled for long.

Indeed, if there is one institution that appears poised to benefit from the current flux, it is the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps. Long regarded as the second pillar of power after the Supreme Leader, the IRGC has steadily expanded its influence across military, political, and economic domains. In the present context, it may well have become the central node of authority. Analysts suggest that "the Revolutionary Guard is the state" capture a reality that has been evolving over the years, but is now being accelerated by the crisis. The Guard's control over strategic assets, its command of proxy networks across the region, and its ideological commitment to the regime position it as the ultimate guarantor of continuity. In effect, Iran may be transitioning—gradually but decisively—from a clerically anchored theocracy to a more securitised, military-driven state.

At the same time, the notion that Iran's military and governance systems are collapsing under pressure is far from settled. Statements by Iranian officials indicating that military units are operating with a degree of autonomy suggest decentralisation rather than disintegration. This is not necessarily a sign of weakness; rather, it may reflect pre-existing contingency planning for precisely such scenarios. The Islamic Republic has, over decades, prepared for external aggression by developing layered command structures and redundancies. The idea that eliminating a handful—or even dozens—of senior leaders would paralyse the system overlooks this institutional depth. As some analysts point out, Iran is not a loosely organised militant network but a state with bureaucratic continuity, ideological cohesion, and a capacity to regenerate leadership from within.

The larger lesson from this unfolding crisis lies in the limits of leadership decapitation as a strategy. While it can create shock and disrupt decision-making in the short term, it does not necessarily dismantle the underlying architecture of power. In some cases, it may even harden regimes, pushing them towards greater centralisation and militarisation. For the region, this raises troubling prospects. A weakened but not collapsed Iran could become more unpredictable, its actions driven less by calibrated policy and more by fragmented or radicalised centres of power. For the wider world, the episode underscores the need for a more nuanced understanding of state resilience in the face of external pressure. Wars may be fought with precision strikes and intelligence-led operations, but their outcomes are ultimately shaped by deeper political and institutional realities—realities that cannot be erased as easily as individual leaders.

FUEL FRONTLINE



KDP RAO
THE WRITER IS A FORMER ADDITIONAL CHIEF SECRETARY OF CHHATTISGARH

The crisis is a wake-up call for India to move from reactive energy management to long-term structural resilience and efficiency

AT VANTAGE



SHUTAPA PAUL
THE WRITER IS AN AUTHOR AND MEDIA ENTREPRENEUR

A long-delayed reform exposes gaps in consumer rights, regulatory urgency, and India's response to a growing public health crisis

Towards Energy Independence

As oil prices surge amid Middle East tensions, India faces rising inflation, supply risks and an urgent need to rethink energy security

The Iran-US-Israel war in the Middle East has plunged the world into a global oil crisis. The Brent crude price has risen from pre-conflict levels (around USD 60-70 per barrel in early 2026) to over USD 90-100 per barrel recently, and in a worst-case scenario, the same is projected to reach USD 120-150 if the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz by Iran continues. The scenario is reminiscent of past oil crises of the 1970s and 1980s that exposed the vulnerability of import-dependent nations to geopolitical conflicts. The disastrous impact on the economies of these developing countries needs no exaggeration, as oil, in fact, fuels their economies. While questions as to who initiated the wars or who would end them involve endless debates, the utmost priority for these nations is to address the crisis at home immediately and review their preparedness for the future as well. Energy security is not necessarily energy independence, for the latter refers to a wider ecosystem of self-reliance that most developing nations currently lack.

For example, India, as one of the world's largest oil importers, is in a precarious position. Out of 85-90 per cent of its energy needs, about half is imported from Iraq, Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Kuwait, whose shipments are now unable to pass through the Strait of Hormuz. The situation is one of shortages, higher domestic prices, and strain on manufacturing units, as LPG and LNG supplies depend on 60 per cent of natural gas imports from these countries. A little relief is that recently, a few shipments to India were allowed by Iran. Though in the short term, measures like imports from Russia, shifting 70 per cent of crude to alternative routes, and drawing on strategic reserves may temporarily ease the pressure, the undesirable effects, as days pass, could include a weakening rupee, inflationary pressures, stress on manufacturing sectors, and a fall in domestic demand.



The negative impact on production and employment is imminent. The first casualty could be the gig economy, worth USD 556.7 billion (2024) and employing approximately 12 million workers. Numerous digital platforms like Swiggy, Zomato, Blinkit, Dunzo, Uber, Ola, and Urban Company may have to curtail the scale of operations and downsize manpower. The second could be the agriculture sector, since the energy crisis may jeopardise operations necessary before the onset of the monsoon.

In the immediate run, what matters most is handling the panic in the markets that affects common households and businesses alike. Closure of small hotels, food stalls, long queues at fuel pumps and LPG supplying centres, not to mention the shopping frenzy for induction stoves in the market, all indicate that the crisis may persist for some time. Ensuring an uninterrupted supply, with constant vigilance against hoarding or black marketing, is the foremost priority for governments. It is timely that, early in March, the government invoked the Essential Commodities (EC) Act, 1955, to ensure the stable supply and fair distribution of energy products, specifically LPG and natural gas. District administrations need

to play a pivotal role in ensuring the smooth functioning of the PDS and the distribution of fuels and energy products in local markets through rationing, especially in rural areas.

The crisis may pass in time, but import-dependent countries like India need to learn from this sudden and unforeseen situation and find ways to safeguard their future energy security. "Energy saved is energy produced," they say. Energy wastage in India is substantial but has always remained a matter of little concern. In power, technical losses due to old transformers, long low-voltage lines, poor maintenance, and commercial losses due to non-payment and unmetered agricultural connections were reported at 15.04 per cent in FY 2024-25, with monetary losses estimated between Rs 1.5-1.7 lakh crore per year. This is compounded by "phantom loads" (chargers, standby appliances, etc.) and inefficient old refrigerators and air conditioners that consume 5-10 per cent extra electricity. With regard to fuel—petrol, diesel, and LPG—excess consumption due to inefficiency is a drain on valuable resources. In the transport sector, studies show that old-engine vehicles, traffic congestion, and idling in cities are responsible for 20-30 per cent

fuel waste. Similarly, in the agriculture sector, which is a major diesel consumer, inefficient and old pump sets consume 15-20 per cent more fuel than modern 5-star or IE3/IE4 models—a necessary evil, as the majority of farmers are engaged in subsistence farming.

Reducing wastage is the fastest way to contain demand. Every unit of power or litre of fuel saved will directly lower India's exposure to import disruptions. In the power sector, focus on the Revamped Distribution Sector Scheme (RDSS), High-Voltage Distribution System (HVDS), and infrastructure upgrades in rural and agricultural feeders is essential, in addition to ongoing Bureau of Energy Efficiency (BEE) programmes. In the transport sector, fast-tracking EVs and hybrids (through the FAME scheme with state incentives) is necessary to eliminate fuel wastage. Stricter Corporate Average Fuel Efficiency (CAFE) norms and promotion of CNG, public electric buses, and rail are equally important. In agriculture, the KUSUM scheme needs to be aggressively expanded to replace old diesel and electric pumps with BEE 5-star and solar pumps, alongside drip and micro-irrigation to reduce over-pumping.

Dependence on fossil fuels is an economic imperative for developing countries, including India, which makes their energy narratives vulnerable. Nonetheless, as emphasised in various COP summits, renewable and non-fossil resources need to be created on an epic scale as standby arrangements, though not as permanent alternatives to fossil fuels. India has strongly pushed for renewable energy in G20 forums, highlighting its commitment to achieving 500 GW of non-fossil fuel capacity by 2030. Though coal remains indispensable for baseload power generation, the push for solar, wind, and electrification provides a buffer against future disruptions.

The good news for India is that in FY 2025-26, renewables accounted for 75 per cent of all new capacity additions—a record 49.6 GW, with solar alone contributing 38 GW. As per official data, India's non-fossil energy capacity has crossed 50 per cent of the power mix, while renewables contribute about 25 per cent to generation. India ranks fourth globally in total installed renewable energy capacity (after China, the USA, and Brazil), according to IRENA and MNRE data. Ernst & Young's RECAI index ranks India among the top four globally in solar and wind attractiveness, signalling strong FDI potential. India has also championed global solar alliances and urged G20 nations to triple renewable energy capacity by 2030.

The current crisis is, in fact, an opportunity to accelerate the transition process. However, challenges remain—grid integration and transmission, battery storage and pumped hydro, and land acquisition in some states. Moreover, attitudinal changes are necessary to expand demand for non-fossil fuels and to control energy losses. Renewables and non-fossil fuels play a crucial role in climate action and, in the long run, help create an ecosystem of energy independence—a higher goal than energy security.

Views expressed are personal

No Warning Signs

The Supreme Court has hauled up FSSAI for its extraordinary delay in assessing the front-of-pack labelling of unhealthy packaged food, which also thwarts the government's efforts towards a healthier India



Without clear food labelling, consumers remain vulnerable to misinformation and rising lifestyle-related health risks

In India, even today, citizens don't have enough power as consumers. Information trickles down to us slowly and redressal is painfully sedated or entirely missing. Perpetrators of negligence, misinformation, malpractice, and misinformation get away with a lot. We are not a litigious country. How can we be? Given the existing burden on the judicial system and delayed road to justice, consumer cases are lower down the pecking order. Therefore, Indian consumers are not empowered yet, and that must change. A few days ago, an irate Supreme Court hauled up the food regulator, Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI), for dragging its feet on front-of-pack (FoP) food labelling. The task has been work-in-progress for, hold your breath, eight years! So lackadaisical has been the approach taken by FSSAI that even the apex court had to finally intervene. The apex court said that it was "not satisfied" with FSSAI's compliance affidavit and that their endeavour "has not yielded any positive or good result". We do hear from several quarters about the lack of efficacy of the food regulator, but that's a matter for another column.

To put things into perspective, know

that every day, thousands of Indians consume packaged food without adequate information on levels of sugar, salt, fat, and so on. We are willingly slow-poisoning ourselves and while a few discerning folk would check the back of the pack for the ingredients and nutrition list, the majority lives in delusions of what is and isn't "healthy" food. The packaging of food products is very different overseas. The 'nutri-score' adorns the top of the packets in countries such as France and Belgium with 'A' being the healthiest, leading right through to 'E' being the least. Similar practices are followed in Spain, Germany, Portugal, Israel, Chile, and Brazil. Sadly in India, we are still waiting for almost a decade for the food regulator to complete "consultations" on its implementation.

The regulator seems tone deaf to even exhortations coming from the topmost leader of the nation. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has repeatedly pointed out the "silent crisis" of obesity in India highlighting a possibility of 44 crore obese Indians by 2050 if lifestyles are not amended post-haste. He has urged households to reduce cooking oil usage by 10 per cent, he has lauded the "Sugar Board Movement" in CBSE schools of displaying sugar content

in various snacks and drinks, and cautioned against childhood obesity. The government's Fit India Movement is a clarion call for citizens to pay attention to health and guard against lifestyle disorders such as diabetes, hypertension, and so on.

Therefore, this glacial pace of non-progress shown by FSSAI is antithetical to a fast-moving nation like ours and instead reeks of wilful negligence. This in itself is also bizarre, given that the entire premise of the Eat Right India movement is to nudge people to reduce salt, sugar, and oil intake. The double speak can be rectified with decisive action finally being taken by the food regulator. And while packaged food companies and their lobbies are expected to push back, if the regulator and the government finally shows teeth, all will have to fall in line.

Meanwhile, the top Indian court wants warning labels to be prominently displayed. Following this diktat would ensure that the schizophrenic approach of speaking about public health and following up with real action, is finally resolved. Will front-of-pack labelling stop consumption of junk food? Probably not. But at least these will be informed decisions taken by enlightened consumers.

Views expressed are personal

X

WHO SAID WHAT

Mamata Banerjee
@MamataOfficial

Today, I place before the people my 10 'Protigya' for Bengal. My commitments span every pillar of governance, strengthening support for women, youth, farmers, landless agricultural labourers, and the elderly; advancing education and healthcare; ensuring housing and piped drinking water for every household; strengthening administration; and transforming Bengal into the Gateway of trade for Eastern India. Through these pledges, I reiterate my resolve to sustain the momentum of progress with renewed vigour in the fourth term of my Maa-Mati-Manush Sarkar, and to further strengthen Bengal's position as one of the leading states of the nation.

— WHILE RUSSIA PREPARES NEW OFFENSIVES —

War in Iran raises pressure on Ukraine



Firefighters put out the fire in a residential neighborhood following a Russian missile, in Kyiv AP/PTI

KYIV: With US-brokered Ukraine peace talks on hold due to the war in the Middle East, Russian President Vladimir Putin is expected to try to expand his military gains via new offensives against his southern neighbour that could put even more pressure on Kyiv.

Windfall revenues from surging global oil prices are filling Moscow's war coffers and US air defence assets are being drained quickly by Iranian attacks across the Gulf, raising concerns that little will be left available for Ukraine in the fifth year of Russia's full-scale invasion.

Ukraine's European allies have promised to maintain their steadfast support, but bickering over a major 90 billion euro (\$106 billion) European Union loan to cover Kyiv's military and economic needs for two years has reflected the mounting challenges.

The refusal by NATO allies to commit naval assets to help

Highlights

» Zelenskyy has sought to hold Washington's attention by offering its expertise in defending against Iranian Shahed drones

» Putin and his generals are pondering plans for spring and summer campaign across over 1,200-km front line

UKRAINE'S EUROPEAN ALLIES HAVE PROMISED TO MAINTAIN THEIR STEADFAST SUPPORT

Volodymyr Zelenskyy has sought to hold Washington's attention by offering its expertise in defending against Iranian Shahed drones, sending over 200 military experts to the Gulf. Trump, however, has shrugged off Zelenskyy's offer of help, saying the US doesn't need Kyiv's assistance.

As new signs of a rift emerge in Western alliances, Putin and his generals are pondering plans for the spring and summer campaign across more than the 1,200-kilometre (about 750-mile) front line.

The Russian military appears to be readying for a renewed push to claim the part of the eastern Donetsk region that remains under Ukraine's control, as well as possible offensives in several other sectors. Analysts have observed that Moscow has been building up reserves and its operations are expected to gain tempo as the spring warmth dries the terrain.

Enemies' security must be taken away, says Iran's supreme leader

DUBAI: Iran's new Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei called Friday for the enemies of his nations to have their "security" taken away, in his latest message to the public.

Khamenei made the remarks in a statement issued on his behalf and sent to President Masoud Pezeshkian, after Israel killed Intelligence Minister Esmail Khatib.

Khamenei hasn't been seen since he was named as supreme leader, succeeding his father, the 86-year-old Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who was killed in an Israeli airstrike on the first day of the war on February 28.

The United States was meanwhile deploying three more warships and roughly 2,500 additional Marines to the Middle East, a US official told The Associated Press.

Iran fired on Israel and energy sites in neighbouring Gulf Arab states as many in the region marked one of the holiest days on the Muslim calendar.

Iranians were also cele-



Iran's new Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei

But Iran has showed it is still capable of attacks that are choking off oil supplies and denting the global economy, raising food and fuel prices far beyond the Middle East

brating the Persian New Year, known as Nowruz, a normally

festive holiday that is more subdued this year.

With little information coming out of Iran, it was not clear how much damage its arms, nuclear or energy facilities have sustained since the war began Feb 28 or even who was truly in charge of the country.

But Iran has showed it is still capable of attacks that are choking off oil supplies and denting the global economy, raising food and fuel prices far beyond the Middle East.

The US and Israel have offered shifting rationales for the war, from hoping to foment an uprising that topples Iran's leadership to eliminating its nuclear and missile programs. There have been no public signs of any such uprising and no end in sight to the war.

Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei praised Iranians' steadfastness in the face of war in a written statement read on Iranian television to mark the Persian New Year, Nowruz.

NASA hauls repaired moon rocket back to pad

Ahead of planned launch in April

CAPE CANAVERAL: For the second time this year, NASA moved its moon rocket from the hangar out toward the pad Friday in hopes of launching four astronauts on a lunar fly-around next month.

If the latest repairs work and everything else goes NASA's way, the Space Launch System could blast off as early as April 1 from Florida's Kennedy Space Centre. The Artemis II crew went into quarantine this week in Houston.

The 322-foot (98-metre) rocket began the slow 4-mile (6.4-kilometre) trek in the middle of the night, transported atop a massive crawler used since the 1960s Apollo era. It was expected to take 12 hours. The trip was held up for several hours by high wind.

The three Americans and one Canadian will zip around the moon in their capsule and then come straight home with-

The three Americans and one Canadian will zip around the moon in their capsule and then come straight home without stopping

out stopping.

Their mission should have been completed by now, but hydrogen fuel leaks and clogged helium lines forced two months of delay.

While technicians plugged the leaks at the pad, the helium issue could only be fixed in the Vehicle Assembly Building, forcing NASA to roll the rocket back at the end of February.

The last time NASA sent astronauts to the moon was during Apollo 17 in 1972. The new Artemis programme aims for a two-person landing in 2028.

— AS IRAN THREATENS WORLD TOURISM SITES —

US deploys thousands more troops to war

Georgia has become the the first US state to suspend fuel taxes as pump prices soar due to war in Middle East

Israeli air strikes that have decimated Iran's military and leadership. The Pentagon's request for another \$200 billion to fund the war would need congressional approval as the US national debt hits a record \$39 trillion.

Prime Minister Benjamin

Netanyahu said Israel will stop attacking the gas field that Iranians depend on for most of their electricity at the request of US President Donald Trump. Iran responded to Israel's attack on the field by intensifying targeting of energy infrastructure in other Middle East countries, sending oil and gas prices soaring.

The death toll has risen to more than 1,300 people in Iran, more than 1,000 people in Lebanon, 15 in Israel and 13 US military members in the region. Millions of people in Lebanon and Iran have been displaced.

Georgia has become the first US state to suspend fuel taxes as pump prices soar due to war in the Middle East. The average gas price nationwide has risen from \$2.93 a gallon on Feb. 20 to \$3.91 today, motorist group AAA says.

Republican Gov Brian Kemp signed into law Friday a 60-day suspension of the state's 33-cents-per-gallon tax on gas and 37-cents-per-gallon tax on diesel.

That's \$5 or \$6 per tank for a typical passenger vehicle, and could mean forgoing \$360 million to \$400 million fuel taxes.

Trump admin sues Harvard

Says it violated civil rights law, seeks to recover funds

WASHINGTON: The Justice Department filed a new lawsuit Friday against Harvard University, saying its leadership failed to address antisemitism on campus, creating grounds for the government to freeze existing grants and seek repayment for grants already paid.

The lawsuit, filed in federal court in Massachusetts, is another missive in a protracted battle between the administration of President Donald Trump and the elite university.

"The United States cannot and will not tolerate these failures and brings this action to compel Harvard to comply" with federal civil rights law, the Justice Department wrote in the lawsuit, "and to recover billions of dollars of taxpayer subsidies awarded to a discriminatory institution."

Harvard did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

The lawsuit comes after negotiations appear to have bogged down in the months-



US PRESIDENT DONALD TRUMP



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

The lawsuit is another missive in a protracted battle between the administration of Trump and elite university

long battle with the Trump administration that has tested the boundaries of the government's authority over America's universities.

What began as an investigation into campus antisemitism escalated into an all-out feud as the Trump administration slashed more than \$2.6 billion in research funding, ended federal contracts and attempted to block Harvard from hosting international students.

In a pair of lawsuits filed by

the university, Harvard has said it's being unfairly penalised for refusing to adopt the administration's views.

A federal judge agreed in December, reversing the funding cuts and calling the antisemitism argument a "smokescreen."

Even so, Harvard and the Trump administration have held some negotiations, and the two sides have reportedly been close to reaching an agreement on multiple occasions.

'Drifting Russian tanker entered Libya search and rescue zone'

ROME: The uncrewed Russian tanker drifting in the Mediterranean for the past two weeks has entered Libya's search and rescue zone and is now about 40 nautical miles (74 kilometres) from Libya's territorial waters, Italy's civil protection agency said on Friday.

The Arctic Metagaz is part of Russia's so-called "shadow fleet" transporting fossil fuels in violation of international sanctions over Moscow's war on Ukraine.

The tanker, carrying liquefied natural gas, was badly damaged in a suspected sea drone attack near Maltese waters earlier this month.

According to Russian authorities, it was hit and badly damaged by Ukrainian naval drones. Ukraine has not commented.

Italy's Civil Protection, which has been monitoring the vessel, said on Friday the most significant risk is currently posed by the potential

“THE TANKER, CARRYING LIQUEFIED NATURAL GAS, WAS BADLY DAMAGED IN A SUSPECTED SEA DRONE ATTACK NEAR MALTESE WATERS EARLIER THIS MONTH”

release of gas, adding that no leaks have been detected so far.

Based on prevailing southbound winds and sea currents, and assuming they do not change, it could take "from four to six days for the vessel to reach Libyan land," said Civil Protection spokesman Pierfrancesco Demilito at a news conference with the international media in Rome.

Demilito said the vessel

is estimated to be carrying 450 tons of heavy oil and 250 tons of diesel as fuel supplies, plus an "uncertain" quantity of LNG, which may have been partially dispersed.

Another main concern is that the tanker may crash into an offshore oil platform. However, there are no such platforms currently located nearby, Demilito added.

He said that any intervention on the tanker would fall under the Libyan authorities, since the vessel is in the country's search and rescue waters, but added Italy has offered its help if requested.

In a joint letter sent on Wednesday to the European Commission, the leaders of Italy, Spain, Malta, Greece and Cyprus have warned that the vessel poses an "imminent and serious risk" of a major ecological disaster, and requested to activate the bloc's civil protection mechanism.

CBS News shuts down its radio news service as part of layoffs

NEW YORK: CBS News said Friday it will shut down its storied radio news service after nearly 100 years of operation, ending an era and blaming challenging economic times as the world moves on to digital sources and podcasts.

When it went on the air in September 1927, the service was the precursor to the entire network, giving a youthful William S Paley a start in the business. Famed broadcaster Edward R Murrow's rooftop reports during the Nazi bombing of London during World War II kept Americans listening anxiously.

Today, CBS News Radio provides material to an estimated 700 stations across the country and is known best for its top-of-the-hour news roundups. The service will end on May 22, the network said Friday. "Radio is woven into the fabric of CBS News and that's always going to be part of our history," CBS News editor-in-

Edward R Murrow's rooftop reports during the Nazi bombing of London during World War II kept Americans listening anxiously

chief Bari Weiss said in delivering the news to the staff. "I want you to know that we did everything we could, including before I joined the company, to try and find a viable solution to sustain the radio operation."

But with the radical changes in the media industry, "we just could not find a way to make that possible," she said.

CBS News cut some of its radio programming late last year, including its "Weekend Roundup" and "World News Roundup Late Edition," in an attempt to keep the service going.

COPENHAGEN: Voters in Denmark will decide who runs the Scandinavian country for the next four years in a general election next week, a vote that follows a standoff with US President Donald Trump over the future of the kingdom's semiautonomous territory of Greenland.

Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen called the election last month, apparently hoping that her straight-talking image in the Greenland crisis would win her points with the electorate.

If the leader of the centre-left Social Democratic party can put together a new government after Tuesday's vote, she will embark on her third term.

The 48-year-old prime minister has led the European Union and NATO member country since mid-2019. She is known for strong support of Ukraine in its defense against Russia's invasion and for a restrictive approach to



Denmark's King Frederik X places a poppy at the Roll of Honour during a visit to the Australian War Memorial in Canberra AP/PTI

Key Points

» Prime Minister Mette Frederiksen called the election last month

» Denmark's system of proportional representation typically produces coalition governments

migration.

In her second term, her support waned as the cost of living rose. But she enjoyed a bump

in popularity as the government navigated the crisis over Trump's designs on Greenland, which culminated in January in

World Briefs

FIRE AT SOUTH KOREAN AUTO PARTS FACTORY INJURES AT LEAST 55

SEOUL: A fire at an auto parts factory in South Korea's central city of Daejeon injured at least 55 people on Friday, with officials warning the toll could rise. The National Fire Agency said 24 were seriously hurt in a blaze likely caused by an explosion. Officials could not immediately confirm whether any of the injured were in life-threatening condition. Nam Deuk-woo, fire chief of the city's Daedeok district, said authorities were searching for at least 14 other people believed to have been inside the facility when fire broke out. Videos and photos from scene showed thick gray smoke billowing from complex.

AROUND 6,000 NATIONALS 'UNSAFE' IN GULF: NEPALESE FOREIGN MINISTRY

KATHMANDU: Over 82,000 Nepalis have registered from the Gulf region, out of which around 6,000 nationals have enlisted as being 'unsafe', a foreign ministry official said on Friday. Nepali nationals living in the Gulf enlisted themselves through an online registration system maintained by the Department of Consular Services under the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, ministry spokesperson Lok Bahadur Chhetri said at a press meet. "Of the total 82,100 registrations, around 6,000 Nepalis have enlisted as being unsafe," Chhetri said.

US-ISRAEL-IRAN CONFLICT

Satellite images begin to show damage wrought by Iran war

DUBAI: Satellite images are beginning to be released giving a glimpse into the toll of the Iran war, with ships ablaze in an Iranian port and destroyed buildings at an American base. Information has so far been scarce about the damage being done across the Middle East, particularly when it's inside closed military facilities, since the war started on February 28. The images come from Planet Labs PBC, a San Francisco-based firm used by media outlets, including The Associated Press. Planet Labs has put a two-week delay on its imagery becoming public, citing concerns its imagery could be used by "adversarial actors". High-resolution images also have been published by competing firms. Other providers, like the US Geological Survey, have been publishing lower-resolution imagery as well that's been useful. The US and Israel have been striking a wide variety of targets, including leadership figures in Iran, military bases, missile and air defence sites and positions of the paramilitary Revolutionary Guard and its volunteer force, the Basij. Iran has responded with drone and missile fire targeting Israel and nearby Gulf Arab nations. Here's a look at what's visible in a selection of Planet



The satellite image from Planet Labs PBC shows damage after airstrikes targeting Iran's Parchin military base outside of Tehran

tary Revolutionary Guard and its volunteer force, the Basij. Iran has responded with drone and missile fire targeting Israel and nearby Gulf Arab nations. Here's a look at what's visible in a selection of Planet

Lab's pictures, as well as others. Some of the most dramatic images from Planet Labs so far have been in Bandar Abbas, home to a major Iranian military port next to the crucial Strait of Hormuz connecting

the Persian Gulf to the Gulf of Oman and the Arabian Sea. Images taken on March 2 show ships ablaze at the port. The US military's Central Command has been targeting Iran's naval assets and says

IRAN LONG HAS INSISTED ITS NUCLEAR PROGRAMME IS PEACEFUL, THOUGH THE IAEA SAY TEHRAN HAD AN ACTIVE WEAPONS PROGRAMME UP UNTIL 2003

it has sank or damaged more than 100 Iranian vessels so far in the war. Planet Labs' images from March 6 show damage to several buildings at the Parchin military base outside Tehran, Iran's capital.

The International Atomic Energy Agency suspects Iran in the past conducted tests of high explosives that could trigger a nuclear weapon. Iran long has insisted its nuclear programme is peaceful, though the IAEA, Western intelligence agencies and others say Tehran had an active weapons programme up until 2003. AGENCIES

Zelenskyy: Ukraine using its drone expertise against Iran

KYIV: Ukrainian officials are helping five countries in the Middle East and Gulf region counter attacks on their territory by Iranian drones, while the United States and European countries are among others who have requested support, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Friday.

Ukraine is also looking into whether it can have a role in restoring security in the Strait of Hormuz amid the Iran war, he said.

Ukraine has become one of the world's leading producers of cutting-edge, battle-tested drone interceptors that are cheap and effective. They play a key part in its defense against Russia's more than 4-year-old full-scale invasion.

"Our teams are already working with five countries on countering (Iran's) Shahed' drones — we have provided expert assessments and are helping build a defence system," Zelenskyy said on X.

Zelenskyy has previously



Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy

Ukraine has become one of the world's leading producers of cutting-edge, battle-tested drone interceptors that are cheap and effective

said he hoped to provide expertise to Arab Gulf countries targeted by Iranian Shahed drones,

versions of which are heavily used by Moscow's invading forces, in exchange for advanced air defence missiles that Ukraine needs to counter devastating Russian aerial attacks.

Kyiv fears it will get fewer of the sophisticated missiles it needs to fend off the Russian strikes as the Iran war burns through stockpiles.

Rustem Umerov, the head of Ukraine's National Security and Defence Council who led a delegation to the Middle East and Gulf this week, said that Ukraine has deployed interceptor units there to help protect civilian and critical infrastructure and is working to expand that protection.

He said on the Telegram messaging app that Ukrainian military specialists are operating in the United Arab Emirates, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Kuwait and Jordan.

Ukraine is assessing further steps for long-term security cooperation with each of those countries, Umerov said. AGENCIES

AS EARTH WARMS

Early Southwest heat latest in parade of weather extremes

WASHINGTON: The dangerous heat wave shattering March records all over the US Southwest is more than just another extreme weather blip. It's the latest next-level weather wildness that is occurring ever more frequently as Earth's warming builds.

Experts said unprecedented and deadly weather extremes that sometimes strike at abnormal times and in unusual places are putting more people in danger.

For example, the Southwest is used to coping with deadly heat, but not months ahead of schedule, including a 110-degree Fahrenheit (43.3 Celsius) reading in the Arizona desert on Thursday that smashed the highest March temperature recorded in the US.

On Thursday, sites in Arizona and southern California had preliminary readings of 109 F (about 43 C), which would be the hottest March day on record for the United States.

"This is what climate change looks like in real time: extremes pushing beyond the bounds we once thought possible," said University of Victoria climate scientist Andrew Weaver. "What used to be unprecedented events are now recurring features of a warming world."

March's heat would have been virtually impossible without human-caused climate change, according to a report Friday by World Weather Attribution, an international group of scientists who study the causes of extreme weather events.

More than a dozen scientists, meteorologists and disaster experts queried by The Associated Press put the March heat wave in a kind of ultra-extreme classification with such events as the 2021 Pacific Northwest heat wave, the 2022

Key Points

- Experts said unprecedented and deadly weather extremes that sometimes strike at abnormal times and in unusual places are putting more people in danger
- The area of the US being hit by extreme weather in the past five years has doubled from 20 years ago

Pakistan floods and killer hurricanes Helene, Harvey and Sandy.

The area of the US being hit by extreme weather in the past five years has doubled from 20 years ago, according to the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration's Climate Extremes Index, which includes various types of wild weather, such as heat and cold waves, downpours and drought.

The United States is breaking 77 per cent more hot weather records now than in the 1970s and 19 per cent more than the 2010s, according to an AP analysis of NOAA records. In the United States, the number and average cost of inflation-adjusted billion-dollar weather disasters in the last couple years is twice as high as just 10 years ago and nearly four times higher than 30 years ago, according to records kept by NOAA and Climate Central, a nonprofit group of scientists and communicators who research and report on climate change.

"It's really hard to even keep up with how extreme our extremes are becoming," said Climate Central Chief Meteorologist Bernadette Woods Plackly.

BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, New Delhi

TENDER NOTICE Date: 21.03.2026

Sealed tenders under two Bid System (Unpriced & Priced) is invited for following job from all bidders.

NIT No.	Brief Item Description	Estimated Cost (₹)	Cost of EMD (₹)	Due Date & Time of Submission	Date & Time of Opening
CMC/BR/26-27/FK/CR/AL/1346	"Scheme No: KR25NC2236 -HTC IN F/O IB FLIMISTAN BUILDING AUROBINDO MARG VIDE APP NO 8007897395 S/D B1 DIV VKJ"	1.34 Crore	2.68 Lakhs	10.04.2026 15:30 HRS	10.04.2026 15:45 HRS

Cost of each Tender Document: ₹ 1180/-

For details in respect of Equipment/BOM/Services, Qualifying requirements, Terms & conditions, purchase/submiton of tender documents etc, please visit our website www.bsedsdelhi.com Head (Contracts & Materials)

Regd. Off. : BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, BSES Bhawan, Nehru Place, New Delhi-110019 | Corporate Identification No.: U40109DL2001PLC111527 Telephone No. : +91 11 4910 7235 | Website : www.bsedsdelhi.com

ग्रेटर नौएडा औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण

पत्रांक: प्रो/वर्क सॉलिट-ईएण्डएम-3/2026/04 ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना दिनांक: 20 मार्च, 2026

ग्रेटर नौएडा औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण द्वारा मुख्य कार्यपालक अधिकारी, ग्रेटर नौएडा की ओर से ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या-प्रो/वर्क सॉलिट ईएण्डएम-3/2026/03 दिनांक 20.03.2026 के माध्यम से निम्नलिखित कार्य की ई-निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है। ई-निविदा की समस्त नियम व शर्तें ग्रेटर नौएडा प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट www.greaternoidaauthority.in पर ई-निविदा लिंक एवं ई-पोर्टल <https://etenderup.nic.in> पर उपलब्ध है। किसी परिवर्तन, संशोधन व अतिरिक्त सूचनाओं के लिए उक्त वेबसाइट देखते रहें।

क्र. सं.	कार्य का नाम / वर्क सॉलिट	अनुमानित लागत
1.	Supply, installation, testing, implementation, commissioning, operation and maintenance (SITCOM) of Integrated Security and Traffic Management System (ISTMS) in Greater Noida	₹ 227.60 करोड़

उक्त कार्य की निविदा दिनांक 25.03.2026 से 22.04.2026 को 17.00 बजे तक अपलोड की जा सकती है जिसकी प्री-बिड बैठक दिनांक 08.04.2026 को दोपहर 03.00 बजे ग्रेटर नौएडा प्राधिकरण कार्यालय, भूखण्ड सं-01, सेक्टर नॉल्लिज पार्क-4, ग्रेटर नौएडा के प्रशासनिक भवन के चतुर्थ तल स्थित बोर्ड रूम में उपरोक्त निविदा प्राप्त करने से पूर्व निविदा में प्रतिभाग करने वाली फर्म/एजेंसियों की एक निविदा पूर्व बैठक (Pre-Bid Meeting) की जायेगी एवं प्राप्त ई-निविदाओं की प्री-कालीफिकेशन बिड दिनांक 23.04.2026 को प्रातः 11.00 बजे खोली जायेगी। वरिष्ठ प्रबन्धक (ईएण्डएम-3)

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कार्यालय अधिशासी अभियन्ता, अनुखण्ड खण्ड, उत्तराखण्ड जल संस्थान, 60/1, एक्का हाऊस, इन्दिरा नगर (अन्तर्गत चौक के पास), देहरादून - 248006. Phone No./Fax: 0135 2532509 Email Id: eamdujs@rediffmail.com

पत्रांक 5872 / निविदा सूचना / 2025-26, दिनांक : 20/03/2026 "जल संचय" जीवन संचय "

ई-निविदा सूचना

मुख्य महाप्रबन्धक, उत्तराखण्ड जल संस्थान की ओर से चारधाम यात्रा 2026 के अन्तर्गत जलकल ऋषिकेश नगरीय / ग्रामीण पेयजल योजना के अन्तर्गत जलकल कार्यालय पन्ना नं०-6 एवं नगर निगम वार्ड नं०-28 वीरपुर खुर्द स्थित नलकूप हेतु जनरेटर सैट की आपूर्ति एवं अधिष्ठापन कार्यों हेतु ई-निविदा, टू-बिड सिस्टम (तकनीकी बिड एवं कॉमिशियल बिड) आधार पर निम्नानुसार आमंत्रित की जाती हैं :-

निविदा सं.	कार्य विवरण	धरोहर धराराशि (रु. में)	निविदा प्रपत्र डाउनलोड करने की तिथि एवं समय	ई-निविदा प्रपत्र अपलोड / जमा करने की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय	तकनीकी बिड खोले जाने की तिथि एवं समय	निविदा की वैधता
1	Supply, Installation, testing and commissioning (SITC) of 58.50 3 KVA Phase Silent DG Set comprising of suitable make engine developing suitable BHP Coupled to suitable make alternator mounted on C.C. Foundation.	₹ 34500.00	23.03.2026 from 04.00 p.m.	13.04.2026 upto 05.00 p.m.	15.04.2026 Upto 05.00 p.m.	90 days

ई-निविदा से सम्बन्धित समस्त जानकारीयों व शर्तें उत्तराखण्ड की वेबसाइट www.uktenders.gov.in पर ऑन लाइन देखी / प्राप्त की जा सकती हैं। अधिशासी अभियन्ता

Nepal: 23 Indians rescued from brick kiln

KATHMANDU: Twenty three Indian nationals have been rescued from a brick kiln in Nepal's Madhesh province, police said on Friday. Human Rights Commission Madhesh Province Office rescued the Indian nationals from Assam from Baba Dharmaraj Brick Kiln in Dakneshwori Municipality-9, the police said. The commission investigated at the kiln following a complaint. AGENCIES

कार्यपालक अभियन्ता का कार्यालय, वैशाली भवन प्रमंडल, हाजीपुर शुद्धि-पत्र

इस कार्यालय का पत्रांक-354 अनु० दिनांक-05.02.2026 द्वारा निर्गत ई०-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या (SBD)-39/हाजीपुर/2025-26 (कार्य का नाम-महिला औद्योगिक प्रशिक्षण संस्थान, हाजीपुर, वैशाली के परिसर में 100 आसन वाले बाह्यिका छात्रावास (G+3) निर्माण कार्य (विद्युत कार्य सहित)। जिसका पी०आर० सं०-023514 (BCD) 2025-26 है जो दिनांक-10.02.2026 को दैनिक समाचार पत्रों में प्रकाशित हुआ है को अपरिहार्य कारणवश अवधि विस्तार किया जाता है।

क्र०	विवरण	पूर्व में निर्धारित तिथि	संशोधित तिथि
1.	परिमाण विपत्र (डाउनलोड करने) एवं निविदा जमा करने (अपलोड करने) की अंतिम तिथि एवं समय	दिनांक-27.02.2026 से 23.03.2026 को अप० 3:00 बजे तक।	दिनांक-10.04.2026 से 04.05.2026 को अप० 3:00 बजे तक।
2.	निविदा (तकनीकी बीड) खोलने की तिथि एवं समय	दिनांक-24.03.2026 को अप० 3:30 बजे तक।	दिनांक-05.05.2026 को अप० 3:30 बजे तक।
3.	प्रोबोड मिटिंग की तिथि, समय एवं स्थान	(1) दिनांक-06.03.2026 को 3:00 बजे अप० को अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, भवन अंचल, मुजफ्फरपुर का कार्यालय। (2) दिनांक-13.03.2026 को 3:00 बजे अप० को मुख्य अभियन्ता (उत्तर) भवन निर्माण विभाग, बिहार, पटना का कार्यालय।	(1) दिनांक-17.04.2026 को 3:00 बजे अप० को अधीक्षण अभियन्ता, भवन अंचल, मुजफ्फरपुर का कार्यालय। (2) दिनांक-24.04.2026 को 3:00 बजे अप० को मुख्य अभियन्ता (उत्तर) भवन निर्माण विभाग, बिहार, पटना का कार्यालय।

इसे इस हद तक संशोधित समझे तथा शेष सभी शर्तें यथावत रहेगा। निविदा से संबंधित नियमों, शर्तों के विशेष जानकारी के लिए कार्यपालक अभियन्ता, वैशाली भवन प्रमंडल से सम्पर्क किया जा सकता है।

उक्त सूचना www.state.bihar.gov.in/prdbihar पर भी देखी जा सकती है।

कार्यपालक अभियन्ता, वैशाली भवन प्रमंडल, हाजीपुर

PR. No. 26874 (BCD) 25-26 नशे की मार, बर्बाद करे सुखी परिवार।

NORTHERN RAILWAY CORRIGENDUM

Ref.: EOI Notice No. Better_OBHS/2026/01 dated 18.03.2026 (published on 19.03.2026)

Sub: Corrigendum pertaining EOI Notice No. Better_OBHS/2026/01 dated 18.03.2026 (published on 19.03.2026) Expression of Interest (EOI) for Engagement of Professional Housekeeping Agencies for Enhanced and High-Quality On Board Housekeeping Services (OBHS) in Coaching Trains over Northern Railway.

S.No./Clause of EOI Document	Existing	Should be read as
Clause 7, S.No. 2 (3rd Column para 5) at Page no. 6 of EOI Documents)	• Proof of the annual value of the contract (duly authorized by a Chartered Accountant). • Completion certificate/continuation certificate from client firm authorizing annual value of contract and satisfactory completion/ continuation of work done.	• Proof of the annual value of the contract (duly certified by a Chartered Accountant). • Completion certificate/continuation certificate from client firm Certifying annual value of contract and satisfactory completion/ continuation of work done.
Clause 7, S.No. 3 (2nd Column para 5) at Page no. 6 & 7 of EOI Documents)	Important govt. buildings housing Constitutional Authorities, Ministries/ Departments, Secretariat offices, Apex Judicial Institutions, or statutory/ regulatory bodies, and operating under controlled security access with regular public interface with minimum occupation of 2000 staffs.	Important govt. buildings housing Constitutional Authorities, Ministries/ Departments, Secretariat offices, Apex Judicial Institutions, Education Institutions, statutory/ regulatory bodies, and operating under controlled security access with regular public interface with minimum occupation of 2000 staffs.
Clause 7, S.No. 8 (2nd Column Page no. 7 of EOI Documents)	Employee Strength: The bidder must have a employee strength of at least 5000 people (on its own Pay Roll)	Employee Strength: The bidder must have a employee strength of at least 1000 people (on its own Pay Roll)
Clause 8, S.No. 1 (2nd Column para 5) at Page no. 8 of EOI Documents)	Important govt. buildings housing Constitutional Authorities, Ministries/ Departments, Secretariat offices, Apex Judicial Institutions, or statutory/ regulatory bodies, and operating under controlled security access with regular public interface with minimum occupation of 2000 staffs.	Important govt. buildings housing Constitutional Authorities, Ministries/ Departments, Secretariat offices, Apex Judicial Institutions, Education Institutions, statutory/ regulatory bodies, and operating under controlled security access with regular public interface with minimum occupation of 2000 staffs.

Note: This is the First Corrigendum in above referred EOI

949/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

कार्यालय जिला परिषद्, कोडरमा

निविदा से संबंधित शुद्धि पत्र

इस कार्यालय के पत्रांक 115/जि०प० दिनांक 28.02.2026 एवं PR No. 374015 तिथि 02.03.2026 के द्वारा प्रकाशित अति अल्पकालीन निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या-04/2025-26 (Third Call) में अपरिहार्य कारणवश निम्नवत् आंशिक संशोधन किया जाता है।

क्र०	युप संख्या	योजना का नाम	बेबसाईट में निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि	ई-निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय	निविदा की तिथि एवं समय	बेबसाईट में निविदा प्रकाशन की तिथि	ई-निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय	निविदा प्राप्त की तिथि एवं समय	निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय
1	01	Construction of Zila Parishad Koderma Office Building	07.03.2026	12.03.2026 से 21.03.2026 अपराह्न 05:00 बजे तक	23.03.2026 पूर्वाह्न 11:00 बजे	20.03.2026	28.03.2026 अपराह्न 05:00 बजे तक	30.03.2026 पूर्वाह्न 11:00 बजे	30.03.2026 पूर्वाह्न 11:00 बजे

निविदा की अन्य शर्तें यथावत रहेंगी।

PR 37505 (Panchayati Raj)25-26"D

जिला अभियन्ता, जिला परिषद्, कोडरमा

SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rahtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice. Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Symbolic Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand Notice (₹)	Name of Branch
1.	M/s. Star Roofing Solutions/ Sudhir Kumar/ Sandeep Kumar/ Rinku Goyal Alias Rinku Garg/ Payal Goyal/ M/s. P. K. Fibers Pvt Ltd/ Pawan Kumar/ 662305500776	Residential Freehold Property Bearing Plot/ Property No.35, Measuring Area-330.00 Sq. Mtrs On Each Floor, Entire Upper Ground Floor and First Floor Without Roof/ Terrace Rights Along With 2/4th Silt Parking Space, Property Category-"E" Situated at Rohini Residential Scheme, Pocket- 4 & 5, Sector-23, Rohini, Delhi-110085, Owned By Payal Goyal, Rinku Goyal Alias Rinku Garg , (Admeasuring An Area of 330.00 Sq. Mtrs (Upper Ground Floor) + 330.00 Sq. Mtrs (first Floor) North: Road South: Plot No.42 East: Plot No. 36 West: Plot No.34/ Date of Symbolic Possession March 16, 2026	November 12,2025 Rs. 1,38,43,003.30/-	Sonapat, Delhi

The above-mentioned borrowers(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: March 21, 2026 Place: Delhi

Sincerely Authorised Officer For ICICI Bank Ltd.

CBDT notifies rules for simplified I-T law, to be effective from April 1

I-T Rules, 2026 will operationalise simplified direct tax legislation that was passed by Parliament last year & will come into effect from April 1

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Central Board of Direct Taxes on Friday notified the rules for Income-tax Act, 2025 which provided enhanced tax benefit for HRA to salary earner but makes disclosure of landlord-tenant relationship mandatory.

The Income-tax Rules, 2026 will operationalise the simplified direct tax legislation that was approved by Parliament last year and will come into effect from April 1.

“These rules may be called the Income-tax Rules, 2026. They shall come into force on the April 1, 2026,” a gazette notification said.

Income Tax Rules have significantly raised transaction limits for quoting of PAN for cash deposits/withdrawal in banks, purchase of motor vehicles and property, and payment of hotel bills.

It has also led to enhancing the value of perquisites provided by employers, and making it mandatory for crypto exchanges to share information with the tax department. It also includes Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC) as an accepted mode of electronic payment.

Parliament on August 12,



I-T Rules have significantly raised transaction limits for quoting of PAN for cash deposits/withdrawal in banks, purchase of motor vehicles & property, and payment of hotel bills

2025 passed a new Income Tax Bill to replace the six-decade-old Income Tax Act, 1961. It does not impose any new tax rate and only simplified the language, which was required for understanding the complex Income Tax laws.

The Act has removed redundant provisions and archaic language and reduces the number of Sections from 819 in the Income Tax Act of 1961 to 536

Highlights

» It has also led to enhancing the value of perquisites provided by employers & making it mandatory for crypto exchanges to share information with I-T dept

» It also includes Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC) as an accepted mode of electronic payment

» New I-T law does not impose any new tax rate and only simplified the language, which was required for understanding complex Income Tax laws

and non-resident taxation while simplifying other disclosure mechanisms.

The notification, introduces more than 150 official forms -- numbered from Form 33 onwards -- covering a wide range of tax-related activities.

Income tax rules retain the proposed framework for house rent allowance (HRA) exemptions applicable to salaried taxpayers. However, it has doubled the number of cities eligible for 50 per cent exemption.

Under the new rules, eight cities — Mumbai, Kolkata, Delhi, Chennai, Hyderabad, Pune, Ahmedabad, and Bengaluru — will qualify for a higher exemption limit of 50 per cent of salary, while all other locations will continue at 40 per cent.

At present, salaried employees in Mumbai, Delhi, Kolkata, and Chennai are allowed to claim HRA exemption of up to 50 per cent of their salary, while those living in other locations are eligible for a lower limit of 40 per cent.

The new rules notified seek disclosure of tenant-landlord relationship for claiming I-T deductions and increased responsibility of auditors and companies for tax credit claims on foreign income.

It also entrusts auditors with greater responsibility for checking PAN duplication and tax liability arising out of adverse audit observation.

According to new rules, quoting of Permanent Account Number (PAN) will be mandatory for making cash deposits or withdrawals aggregating to Rs 10 lakh or more in a financial year, in one or more accounts of a person.

Presently, PAN is required for cash deposits exceeding Rs 50,000 during any one day with a banking company or a cooperative bank.

In case of purchase of motor vehicles (including motor cycles), a buyer has to quote his/her PAN if the price exceeds Rs 5 lakh.

The current Income Tax Rules, 1962, do not provide for quoting of PAN for purchase of two-wheelers, while for motor vehicles it was mandatory irrespective of price.

In case of hotel/restaurant bills, payments made to convention centres or banquet halls or a person engaged in event management, PAN will be mandatory if the payment exceeds Rs 1 lakh. The current I-T Rules specify a Rs 50,000 threshold for quoting PAN in case of hotel/restaurant bills.

Bourses jump nearly 1/2% on buying in IT, PSU bank stocks

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Benchmark stock indices Sensex and Nifty gave up most of their intra-day gains to end nearly half a per cent higher on Friday, following intense buying in PSU bank, IT and metal stocks amid concerns over a further spike in fuel-driven inflation.

In another volatile session, the 30-share BSE Sensex climbed 325.72 points or 0.44 per cent to settle at 74,532.96. During the day, it jumped 1,079.15 points, or 1.45 per cent, to 75,286.39.

The 50-share NSE Nifty edged higher by 112.35 points, or 0.49 per cent, to end at 23,114.50. Intra-day, it jumped 343 points, or 1.49 per cent, to 23,345.15.

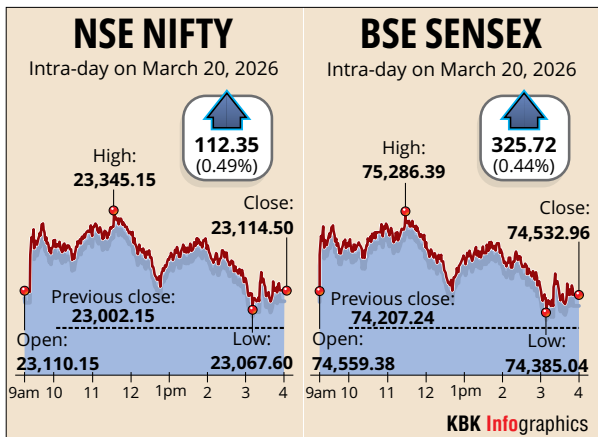
From the 30-Sensex firms, Tata Steel, Tech Mahindra, Infosys, Trent, Reliance Industries, Titan, NTPC and Sun Pharma were among the major gainers. HDFC Bank, Bharat Electronics, Kotak Mahindra Bank and ICICI Bank were among the laggards.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped 1.88 per cent to \$110.7 per barrel.

The BSE MidCap Select index climbed 0.97 per cent, while SmallCap Select index declined 0.32 per cent.

Among sectoral indices, BSE PSU Bank jumped 2.19 per cent, Focused IT (2.18 per cent), IT (2.08 per cent), healthcare (1.45 per cent), metal (1.41 per cent) and energy (1.03 per cent).

However, financial services,



A total of 2,458 stocks advanced, while 1,804 declined and 170 remained unchanged on the BSE

Private Banks index, BSE Top 10 Banks, realty and BSE MidSmall Private Banks Quality Tilt were the laggards.

A total of 2,458 stocks advanced, while 1,804 declined and 170 remained unchanged on the BSE.

On the weekly front, the BSE benchmark dipped 39.96 points or 0.04 per cent, the Nifty slipped 36.6 points or 0.15 per cent.

“Markets witnessed a volatile session on Friday and ended marginally higher, taking a breather after the previ-

ous session's steep decline. The Nifty opened on a firm note following positive global signals and maintained gains in the early hours. However, selling pressure resumed as the session progressed, leading the index to surrender most of its gains by the close,” Ajit Mishra — SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

In Asian markets, South Korea's benchmark Kospi ended higher, while Shanghai's SSE Composite index and Hong Kong's Hang Seng index settled lower. Markets in Japan were closed due to a holiday. Equity markets in Europe were trading higher. The US market ended in negative territory on Thursday.

Foreign Institutional Investors offloaded equities worth Rs 7,558.19 crore on Thursday, according to exchange data. Domestic Institutional Investors (DIIs), however, bought stocks worth Rs 3,863.96 crore.

India's forex reserves drop \$7 bn to \$709.76 bn



MUMBAI: India's forex reserves dropped \$7.052 billion to \$709.759 billion during the week ended March 13, the RBI said on Friday.

In the previous reporting week, the overall reserves had dropped \$11.683 billion to \$716.81 billion. The kitty jumped \$4.885 billion to an all-time high of \$728.494 billion during the week ended February 27.

For the week ended March 13, foreign currency assets, a major component of the reserves, fell \$7.678 billion to \$555.568 billion, the data released by the central bank showed.

Expressed in dollar terms, the foreign currency assets include effects of appreciation or depreciation of non-US units, such as the euro, pound, and yen, held in the foreign exchange reserves.

Value of gold reserves increased \$664 million to \$130.681 billion during the week, the RBI said.

The Special Drawing Rights (SDRs) were down \$23 million to \$18.697 billion, the apex bank said.

India's reserve position with the IMF was also down by \$15 million to \$4.814 billion in the reporting week, according to the apex bank's data.

Make taxpayers' life easier, use tech to check evasion: FM to IT officers

NEW DELHI: Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Friday asked income tax officers to make life easier for assesses and use technology to catch those evading tax willfully.

Addressing the 'PRARAMBH 2026: Nationwide Awareness Campaign on the Income Tax Act, 2025', the minister also exuded confidence that the Income Tax Act, 2025, effective from April 1, will certainly set the trend for making India a very tax-friendly country.

“Make paying tax so easy that honesty becomes the natural choice. But those who are wilfully evading, those who are deliberately trying to get away, technology must catch them. If you are honest, the system will make your life easy, but if you evade, the system will find you. This message should go to



Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman

the taxpayer,” Sitharaman said. Parliament, on August 12, 2025, passed a new Income Tax Bill to replace the six-decade-old Income Tax Act, 1961. It does not impose any new tax rate and only simplifies the language, which was required for understanding the complex Income Tax laws.

The Act has removed redundant provisions and archaic language and reduced the number of Sections from 819 in the Income Tax Act of 1961 to 536

and the number of chapters from 47 to 23. The number of words had been reduced from 5.12 lakh to 2.6 lakh in the new Income Tax Bill, and for the first time, it introduces 39 new tables and 40 new formulas, replacing the dense text of the 1961 law to enhance clarity.

Sitharaman also asked the tax officials to hold awareness sessions across India to educate people about the new tax laws in local languages. Besides, efforts should be made to reduce litigation aggressively.

“Every case that goes to a tribunal or a court is a failure of our system... a black mark on all of us,” the Minister said. She further said the new Income Tax Act should continue to remain simple and clear, adding it should not become as bulky and complex as the 1961 Act.

Production growth of eight core infra sectors slows down to three-month low of 2.3% in Feb

These eight sectors expanded by 3.4 per cent in the same month last year

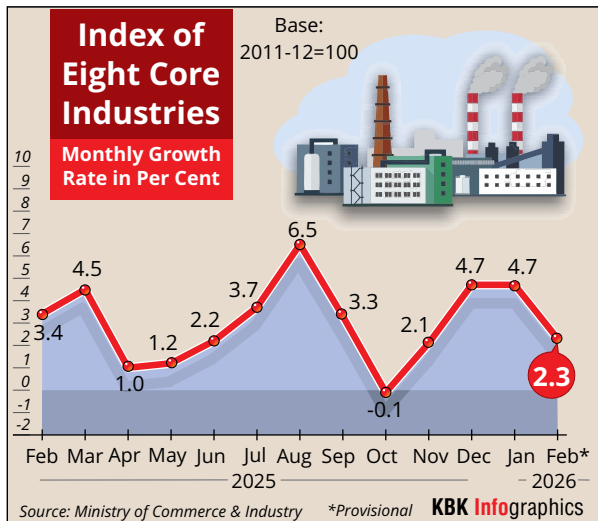
NEW DELHI: Production growth in eight core infrastructure sectors slowed to a three-month low of 2.3 per cent in February due to a contraction in the output of crude oil, natural gas, and refinery products.

According to the government data, these eight sectors expanded by 3.4 per cent in the same month last year.

The growth rate in production of fertiliser, cement and electricity declined to 3.4 per cent, 9.3 per cent and 0.5 per cent, respectively, in February this year.

However, coal and steel production recorded healthy growth.

During April-February, the cumulative production growth



in the infrastructure sector was 2.9 per cent compared to 4.4

per cent in the same period of the last financial year.

Bank of Baroda launches UPI-linked overdraft facility for women Self-Help Group members

NEW DELHI: Bank of Baroda (BoB) has launched an overdraft (OD) facility on Credit Line through UPI for verified women Self-Help Group (SHG) members holding Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY) accounts, becoming the first bank to operationalise the innovation.

The initiative enables eligible beneficiaries to digitally access an overdraft of up to Rs 5,000, aimed at boosting financial inclusion and women-led economic empowerment.

The project was launched by Shivraj Singh Chouhan at the 25th Central Level Coordination Committee meeting on rural development in Hyderabad.



The initiative enables eligible beneficiaries to digitally access an overdraft of up to Rs 5,000

UPI app to access, use and repay funds digitally, make QR-based merchant payments, and track balances and transactions without visiting branches.

Bank of Baroda Executive Director Sanjay Mudaliar said the initiative marks a milestone in digital financial inclusion by enabling seamless, trans-

parent access to formal credit for grassroots women entrepreneurs and creating a scalable model for small-ticket lending.

NPCI Executive Director Sohini Rajola said the move strengthens access to formal credit via UPI, enhancing financial resilience and supporting India's inclusive digital economy.

Key benefits include easy digital access to credit, improved financial independence for rural women, creation of formal credit histories for future borrowing, transparent fund tracking, and alignment with national missions such as PMJDY, DAY-NRLM and Digital India.

NTPC CMD meets Malawi minister to explore power and mining ties

NEW DELHI: The Chairman and Managing Director (CMD) of NTPC Ltd. met Dr. Jean Mathanga, Minister of Energy and Mining, Republic of Malawi, to discuss potential collaboration towards development of power projects, as well as opportunities in the mining sector, with a view to strengthening bilateral cooperation in the power sector.

The interaction took place on the sidelines of the Bharat Electricity Summit (BES) 2026, being held from March 19–22, 2026 at Yashobhoomi, New Delhi.

The meeting was also attended by Shaswattam, Executive



Director, NETRA-NTPC, Renu Narang, CEO, NVVN-NTPC, Dr. Jatinder Singh Chandok, GM (BD-International NTPC), and other senior officials from NTPC.

Discussions focused on exploring avenues for joint development of power infrastructure in Malawi. Mathanga extended an invitation to the NTPC team to visit Malawi for

exploring investment opportunities towards co-development of thermal and renewable energy projects, along with potential collaboration in the mining sector.

The meeting highlights NTPC's ongoing commitment to expanding its global presence and fostering stronger regional partnerships in the energy sector.

Krishna Kumar Thakur takes charge as Director (Personnel), NMDC Ltd

HYDERABAD: Krishna Kumar Thakur, a 1998 batch officer of the Indian Railway Personnel Service (IRPS) took charge as Director (Personnel) at NMDC Ltd on Thursday. In his two-and-a-half decades of service, Thakur brings extensive experience in HR management & administration. He has served in key railway divisions such as Solapur, Bhopal & Mumbai, and led large-scale recruitment as Chairman of Railway Recruitment Cell, Western Railway, overseeing induction of around 12,000 employees. He has also worked with RITES Ltd on an international train operations project in Saudi & headed HR at Konkan Railway Corporation Ltd. Prior to this, as Director (HR) at BHEL, he led HR reforms, policy restructuring & workforce initiatives.



MPOST

RBI board reviews global & domestic economic scenario



MUMBAI: The RBI central board on Friday assessed the emerging global and domestic economic scenario, including evolving geopolitical developments and their impact on financial markets, along with associated challenges.

The 622nd meeting of the Central Board of Directors of RBI was held today in Patna under the Chairmanship of Governor Sanjay Malhotra, a release said.

“The Board approved the Bank's budget for the accounting year 2026-27 and also the Bank's Medium Term Strategy Framework (Utkarsh 3.0) for the period 2026-29,” it said.

Deputy Governors T Rabi Sankar, Swaminathan J, Poonam Gupta, and Shirish Chandra Murmu participated in the meeting.

Other Directors of the Central Board — Anuradha Thakur, Secretary, Department of Economic Affairs; Revathy Iyer, Sachin Chaturvedi and Ravindra H Dholakia — also attended the meeting.

PTI

REC PAVILION INAUGURATED



In a powerful showcase of India's energy transition, the REC Limited Pavilion was officially inaugurated at the Bharat Electricity Summit, 2026 by Manohar Lal, Union Minister of Power and Housing & Urban Affairs; Prahlad Joshi, Union Minister of New & Renewable Energy, Consumer Affairs, Food & Public Distribution; and Shripad Naik, Union Minister of State for Power and New & Renewable Energy. The inauguration took place in the presence of Pankaj Agarwal, Secretary (Power), Government of India; Jitendra Srivastava, CMD of REC Limited; and other senior officials from the Ministry of Power and REC.

MPOST

IndiGo, AI, SpiceJet oppose govt’s 60% free seat selection decision

Federation of Indian Airlines, which represents the three airlines, has also urged Civil Aviation Ministry to take steps to withdraw decision

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: IndiGo, Air India and SpiceJet have raised strong objections to the government’s decision asking airlines not to levy any charges for the selection of at least 60 per cent seats on flights, saying the move will force them to hike airfares to recover lost revenues.

The Federation of Indian Airlines (FIA), which represents the three airlines, has also urged the Civil Aviation Ministry to take steps to withdraw the decision.

On Wednesday, the ministry announced that directions have been issued to the DGCA to direct airlines to allocate a minimum of 60 per cent of seats for selection on any flight free of charge to ensure fair access for passengers.

In a letter written to Civil Aviation Secretary Samir Kumar Sinha on Thursday, FIA said the direction would have unintended and adverse consequences for the aviation sector.

“The financial impact of the directive on airlines will be significant, compelling airlines to recover the lost revenues through increases in fares. As a result, all passengers, including those who may not wish to preselect seats, will end up pay-



On Wednesday, the ministry announced that directions have been issued to the DGCA to direct airlines to allocate a minimum of 60 per cent of seats for selection on any flight free of charge to ensure fair access for passengers

ing higher fares,” it said.

FIA noted that seat selection fees form a legitimate component of airline revenue, particularly in the high-cost environment where costs rise year-on-year under the regulator AERA-governed regime that accords full cost recovery plus an assured margin to airports.

“Airlines operate on thin margins and rely on ancillary

revenues to offset rising operational costs, including fuel, maintenance, airport charges, etc. Imposing a uniform restriction on ancillary revenue undermines commercial flexibility and interferes with market-driven pricing mechanisms,” the grouping said.

The ministry’s announcement on Wednesday came against the backdrop of rising concerns that airlines are levy-

Highlights

» In a letter to Civil Aviation Secretary Samir Kumar Sinha on Thursday, FIA said the direction would have unintended and adverse consequences for the aviation sector

» Generally, airlines charge Rs 200 to Rs 2,100 for seat selection, depending on various factors, including front rows, extra leg room

» The grouping mentioned that the ministry did not carry out stakeholder consultations before announcing the decision

would be counter-productive and higher fares would reduce consumer choice and affordability.

According to FIA, the decision will defeat the stated objective of passenger welfare, as it shifts targeted user-based charges into a blanket fare increase borne by the entire passenger base, and disproportionately impacts price-sensitive travellers and erodes affordability.

Among other concerns, the grouping mentioned that the ministry did not carry out stakeholder consultations before announcing the decision.

“If applied, this measure will set a precedent for excessive intervention in ancillary pricing with heavy loss of revenues for the airlines, apart from creating uncertainty for airlines regarding future regulatory constraints,” FIA said and urged that the mandate to the DGCA be withdrawn.

Meanwhile, sources said the airlines have also told the ministry about various operational challenges, including rising jet fuel prices, in the wake of the West Asia conflict. The conflict has significantly impacted flight operations to and from the region.

Share of non-fossil-fuel-based power to reach 70% mark by FY36

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India has set a target to achieve about 70 per cent non-fossil fuel-based power generation capacity at 786GW, out of the total 1121 GW planned capacity by 2035-36, as per the latest National Generation Adequacy Plan beginning from 2026-27.

The document released at the ongoing first Bharat Electricity Summit 2026, the non-fossil-fuel-based electricity generation installed capacity would be about 786 GW i.e 70 per cent of the total installed capacity by 2035-36.

The installed generating capacity from non-fossil sources as on 28th February, 2026, was 275 GW, which was about 52.5 per cent of the total installed capacity of 524 GW.

As per the generation planning studies, the projected installed capacity by the end of 2035-36 is 1121 GW, comprising 315 GW Coal, 20 GW Gas, 22 GW Nuclear, 78 GW large Hydro, 509 GW Solar, 155 GW Wind, 16 GW Biomass and 6 GW Small Hydro, it stated.

Additionally, it stated that the energy storage installed capacity of 174 GW/888 GWh (BESS of 80 GW/321 GWh and PSP of 94 GW/ 567 GWh) is envisaged by 2035-36.

The fossil fuel-based installed generation capacity will significantly come down to 30 per cent by 2035-36.

However, coal-based thermal capacity will remain and serve as base load.

Similarly, it said that the fos-



The energy storage installed capacity of 174 GW/888 GWh (BESS of 80 GW/321 GWh and PSP of 94 GW/ 567 GWh) is envisaged by FY36

sil fuel-based installed capacity would be about 30 per cent in 2035-36, as compared to 48 per cent in January 2026.

This transition encompasses a shift from fossil fuel-based energy sources to non-fossil fuel-based energy alternatives such as solar, wind, hydro, nuclear and geothermal, coupled with Energy Storage Systems.

Many nations are setting ambitious renewable energy targets, with several aiming for net-zero emissions by mid-century or later (the USA by 2050, China by 2060, and India by 2070).

A long-term National Generation Adequacy Study has been carried out to determine the least-cost option for generation capacity expansion from

2026-27 to 2035-36 in order to reliably meet the projected electricity demand.

The objective is to minimize the total system cost of generation, which includes the cost of future investments, the cost of operating the entire generation fleet, etc., while ensuring that all technical parameters associated with different power generation technologies are satisfied.

The projected peak electricity demand and electrical energy requirement in 2035-36 are 459 GW and 3365 BU, respectively.

As a significant step towards successfully achieving the planned RE capacity, a transmission system has been planned in this report for the evacuation of power from over 900 GW of non-fossil capacity by the year 2035-36, more than the required non-fossil capacity in view of challenges faced in the implementation of the transmission system.

The length of the transmission lines and sub-station capacity planned under ISTS and Intrastate for integration of additional wind and solar capacity during 2026-27 to 2035-36 has been estimated as 1,37,500 circuit kilometer (ckm) and 8,27,600 MVA, respectively, at an estimated cost of Rs 7.93,300 crore.

Additionally, in line with the increasing requirement for clean firm power to meet the growing electricity demand, the study also underlines the likely growth of nuclear-based generation capacity to reach 100 GW by 2047.

AFTER FEBRUARY DECLINE

Russian oil set to regain pole position in India

NEW DELHI: Iraq overtook Russia as India’s biggest oil supplier in February, shipping data showed on Friday, though some analysts expected Moscow to claw back the pole position this month after the United States waived sanctions on Russian supply amid the Middle East conflict.

Indian refiners began reducing Russian oil intake from December, with imports in February falling 32 per cent year-on-year to about 1 million barrels per day, nearly half last June’s peak level, *Reuters* reported.

The sustained reduction in Russian oil imports helped New Delhi secure an interim trade deal with Washington, while increasing dependence on Middle Eastern crude.

In February, India’s oil imports from Iraq rose to



two-year highs of 1.18 million bpd, while purchases from Saudi Arabia climbed to about 998,000 bpd, the highest since December 2021, the data obtained from sources showed.

The share of the Middle East in India’s overall oil imports rose to nearly 59 per cent, the highest since August

2022. However, the world’s third-biggest oil importer and consumer is again bingeing on Russian oil after the US-Israeli war on Iran broke out on February 28, halting shipments via the Strait of Hormuz.

India’s Russian oil imports in February were 32 per cent lower than a year ago and 1.7

per cent below January levels, the data showed.

But they have since rebounded to around 1.8 million bpd and could reach 2 million to 2.2 million bpd in March, according to Sumit Ritolia, lead research analyst at ship tracking firm Kpler.

“Russian barrels remain central to India’s crude import strategy,” he said.

Government officials said India’s reliance on Middle Eastern oil has declined significantly amid the supply disruption, with around 70 per cent of its supplies now coming from other sources.

According to February data, India also sharply increased imports of Brazilian oil, with the South American nation emerging as the fourth-biggest supplier to India after the United Arab Emirates. AGENCIES

Silver prices rise by ₹1,800, gold eases to ₹1.52 lakh per 10 grams

NEW DELHI: Silver prices rebounded by Rs 1,800 to Rs 2.40 lakh per kg while gold prices dropped by Rs 650 to Rs 1.52 lakh per 10 grams in the national capital on Friday, according to the All India Sarafa Association.

The white metal prices increased by Rs 1,800, or nearly 1 per cent, to Rs 2,40,500 per kg (inclusive of all taxes) from Thursday’s closing level of Rs 2,38,700 per kg.

However, gold of 99.9 per cent purity extended its losses for the third consecutive day, declining by Rs 650, or 0.42 per cent, to Rs 1,52,650 per 10 grams (inclusive of all taxes). The yellow metal had settled at Rs 1,53,300 per 10 grams in the previous session.

Analysts said gold prices remain under pressure due to macroeconomic uncertainties and global cues favouring the US dollar.

“The precious metal complex continues to face stiff headwinds from the ongoing US-Israel-Iran conflict, which has moved capital into the haven dollar and crude oil,” Dilip Parmar, Senior Research Analyst, HDFC Securities, said.

In the international market, spot silver slipped nearly 1 per cent to trade at \$72.18 per ounce, while gold was trading 0.27 per cent higher at \$4,663.54 per ounce. PTI

Govt invites bids for 6,000 MTPA rare earth magnet manufacturing

NEW DELHI: The government on Friday invited bids for setting up manufacturing facilities for 6,000 metric tonnes per annum (MTPA) of magnets under the Rs 7,280-crore Scheme to Promote Manufacturing of Sintered Rare Earth Permanent Magnet.

The heavy industries ministry has issued a request for proposal (RFP) for selection of beneficiaries to establish integrated Sintered NdFeB Rare Earth Permanent Magnet manufacturing units.

The pre-bid conference will be held on April 7 while the bid due date is May 28. Technical bids will be opened on May 29, 2026.

The bidding process will be conducted online through the Central Public Procurement (CPP) Portal using a transparent Least Cost System (LCS),



comprising a two-stage process — technical and financial bids.

The scheme, approved by the Cabinet chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi last November, seeks to establish a total manufacturing capacity of 6,000 MTPA of integrated REPM facilities in the country.

Under the scheme, selected beneficiaries will be eligible for capital subsidies and sales-linked incentives. Each beneficiary will be allocated capacity ranging between 600 MTPA and 1,200 MTPA in multiples

of 100 MTPA.

The government has allocated Rs 750 crore towards capital subsidy and Rs 6,450 crore toward sales-linked incentives. Additionally, the three lowest bidders will be provided limited assured supply of NdPr oxide from IREL (India) Ltd., ensuring access to key raw materials.

Rare earth permanent magnets (REPM), particularly NdFeB magnets, are critical components used in electric vehicles, wind turbines, advanced electronics, aerospace and defence applications.

The initiative is expected to help develop a complete domestic value chain — from NdPr oxide processing to finished magnet production — reducing import dependence on China and positioning India as a significant player in the global rare earth magnet market. PTI

Govt clears ₹20K crore credit guarantee scheme for fund flow to microfinance institutions

MUMBAI: The government on Friday approved a limited-period Rs 20,000-crore credit guarantee scheme to aid microfinance institutions (MFIs), which have been complaining about challenges in accessing funds.

The Credit Guarantee Scheme for Microfinance Institutions- 2.0 (CGSMFI-2.0) will cover loans disbursed by member lending institutions (MLIs), including banks and other lenders to non-banking finance company-MFIs and MFIs till end-June, the government-run National Credit Guarantee Trustee Company (NCGTC) said in a circular.

It can be noted that the MFIs, which serve people at



the bottom of the pyramid, have been facing challenging times due to a surge in non-performing assets (NPAs), which has, in turn, made their lenders wary of extending further exposure.

The NCGTC said MLIs shall provide funding to the MFIs or NBFC-MFIs, as per their assessment, for on-lending to eligible small borrowers and also put certain conditions on interest rates.

To qualify for the bene-

fits under the credit guarantee scheme, the interest rate on the loans sanctioned by MLIs to NBFC-MFIs/MFIs is capped at External Benchmark Lending Rate (EBLR) or 1-Year marginal cost of funding based lending rate plus two per cent, it said.

Additionally, the MFIs’ lending to small borrowers has to be done at a cost of 1 per cent below the average rate of their lending in the last six months.

Other conditions include having a maximum loan tenure of three years, which includes a one year moratorium and two years for loan repayment. Also, the MLIs need to ensure that at least 5 per cent of their total loan amount under the scheme is sanctioned to MFIs classified

as small-sized with less than Rs 500 crore of assets under management, 10 per cent to mid-sized ones (Rs 500-2,000 crore of AUM).

“The maximum amount of loan which can be sanctioned by MLIs to NBFC- MFIs/MFIs shall be capped at 20 per cent of AUM of respective NBFC-MFI/ MFI subject to a maximum of Rs 100 crore to small size, Rs 200 crore to medium size and Rs 300 crore to large size NBFC-MFIs/MFIs,” the circular said.

Microfinance Institutions Network (MFIN), a self-regulatory body for the industry, welcomed the move as a timely intervention to address the challenges faced by the sector, which will help unlock liquidity. PTI

Urea, DAP imports rise 63% in April to Jan, govt ensures adequate supply

NEW DELHI: The government on Friday said adequate supply of urea and DAP fertiliser has been ensured for farmers across the country, with imports of the two key nutrients surging 63 per cent during April-January of the current fiscal.

The development assumes significance as the West Asia war, which broke out on February 28, has raised concerns over global fertiliser supply chains.

However, the bulk of the import surge predates the conflict. According to Fertiliser Ministry data, the total imports of urea and Di-Ammonium Phosphate (DAP) rose to 14.94 million tonne in April-January

of 2025-26 from 9.17 million tonne in the year-ago period.

Urea imports rose 83.3 per cent to 8.93 million tonne during the period against 4.87 million tonne a year earlier. DAP imports surged to 9.03 million tonne from 4.30 million tonne in the corresponding period.

Urea and DAP are the two fertilisers consumed the most in India.

The domestic production of urea and DAP, however, remained marginally lower at 28.49 million tonne during April-January of 2025-26 against 29.27 million tonne in the year-ago period.

The total sale of urea and

DAP rose marginally to 44.39 million tonne from 43.61 million tonne in the said period.

The sale of Nano Urea and Nano DAP during April-January 2025-26 stood at 18.25 million bottles and 14.93 million bottles (500 ml equivalent), respectively.

Urea is a highly subsidised fertiliser with its maximum retail price kept unchanged at Rs 242 per 45 kg bag (exclusive of neem coating charges and applicable taxes) since 2018. “There is no proposal to increase the price of urea,” Minister of State for Fertilisers Anupriya Patel said in her written reply to Parliament this week. PTI

Amid disruption, govt emphasis on improving logistics

India’s logistics costs currently estimated at 7.97 per cent of GDP, or about Rs 24.01 lakh crore

NEW DELHI: Amid disruptions to global supply chains due to the West Asia conflict, the government has stepped up efforts to strengthen India’s logistics ecosystem and reduce costs, currently estimated at 7.97 per cent of GDP, or about Rs 24.01 lakh crore.

Officials said the sector is undergoing structural transformation driven by coordinated policy reforms, institutional realignment, digital platforms and large-scale infrastructure planning. These initiatives aim to tackle long-standing issues such as fragmented planning, inefficiencies across transport



modes, limited supply chain visibility and high logistics costs.

India’s logistics reforms are anchored in integrated policies and infrastructure initiatives designed to improve efficiency, cut costs and enhance supply chain connectivity. Addressing

CLOSER LOOK

» ‘The sector is undergoing structural transformation driven by coordinated policy reforms, institutional realignment, digital platforms and large-scale infrastructure planning’

» The government’s Strengthening Multimodal and Integrated Logistics Ecosystem (SMILE) programme is also advancing integrated planning at state and city levels

an event on March 12, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said the ongoing regional conflict had triggered a global energy crisis and disrupted supply chains, underscoring the need for resilience and coordinated action.

Officials noted that programmes like the National Logistics Policy and PM GatiShakti have accelerated the shift towards a more integrated and data-driven logistics framework.

The government’s Strength-

ening Multimodal and Integrated Logistics Ecosystem (SMILE) programme is also advancing integrated planning at state and city levels. Pilot projects in eight cities are mapping freight-intensive activities such as e-commerce deliveries, warehousing clusters and transport corridors to improve efficiency and reduce costs.

The focus remains on data-driven planning, better coordination, congestion reduction, adoption of cleaner transport solutions and improved alignment between freight and passenger movement, officials added. AGENCIES

IPL: Audition ground

Selectors to track ODI WC probables in IPL; strong squad for Afghan Test

NEW DELHI: The ODI World Cup is still a year away but India's 20-odd probables have already been earmarked and the five national selectors will keep an eye on these players during the IPL starting March 28, a top BCCI source said on Friday.

The Ajit Agarakar-led panel comprises SS Das, RP Singh, Ajay Ratna and Pragyan Ojha. The World Cup is to be co-hosted by South Africa, Zimbabwe, and Namibia in October and November of 2027.

The panel members are expected to be present for matches at their respective bases while tracking the other games on TV. IPL begins with defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru taking on Sunrisers Hyderabad in Bengaluru.

No extension for Agarkar?
The senior official also rejected speculation that Agarkar has sought an extension till the 50-over World Cup after a triumphant T20 World Cup campaign earlier this year. "The selection panel is a sub-committee of the BCCI and the selectors' contract runs till September this year," a senior BCCI said.

"Ajit's contract ends in September and after that BCCI secretary and Ajit will have



Kolkata Knight Riders' players during a training session on Thursday

PTI

to decide whether he would continue till next year's ODI World Cup. A senior selector can continue upto four years as per constitution and he doesn't need to seek an extension," he said. Agarkar took over as chairman of selectors in July, 2023 and has been a central figure during the transitions endured by the Test and T20 squads.

Focus on ODI hopefuls
While Agarkar is Mumbai-based, Das is a Kolkata resident. RP Singh and Ratna reside in the National Capital Region, and Ojha is expected to watch

The BCCI is looking at each selector watching at least one game per week which covers five games per week from the venue

BCCI source

the his share of the IPL games in Bengaluru and Hyderabad.

"The BCCI is looking at each selector watching at least one game per week which covers five games per week from the venue. Else obviously they can track on TV," the official said.

It is understood that with the 2028 T20 World Cup and, prior to that, the Olympics in the same year, this IPL will be more about tracking the performance of those 20-odd players who are going to be in the mix for the 50-over World Cup.

The selectors are not expected to look at any break-

out IPL star for the ODI World Cup. The core 50-over specialists are all known and their performance and fitness will be tracked during this year's IPL.

It is reliably learnt that pacer Harshit Rana will take considerable time to recover and the four other fast bowlers for ODIs will be Jasprit Bumrah, Mohammed Siraj, Prasidh Krishna, Arshdeep Singh along with all-rounder Hardik Pandya.

Ready for Afghans
The selection committee is also unlikely to compromise on team strength for the one-off Test against Afghanistan at Mullanpur from June 6 to 10, even though it does not have World Test Championship points to offer. It is understood that with nine Tests to be played between August and March, all top red-ball players, including the front-line bowlers, will be available for the game.

Even Bumrah and Siraj, unless there is a niggle during the IPL, will also be a part of the Afghanistan squad. "The India Test cap isn't for experimentation. For that, you have India A shadow tours. As of now, in Tests, Bumrah, Siraj and Prasidh are top three bowlers on the selectors' radar," the BCCI source said.

AGENCIES

'HE HAS BEEN ADDING A LOT OF VALUE'

Impact coach? Pant pins hopes on Bharat to fix bowling woes



Rishabh Pant was all praise for Bharat Arun

FILE

Pant is eyeing an improved performance in IPL 2026

season, we felt we needed to add more to our bowling. He is definitely someone who can contribute a lot in that area, and I am really happy to have him."

On being the most fun-loving person in the dressing room, Pant said it helps lighten the team environment, especially in stressful situations.

"I think everyone is fun-loving these days because the environment is already so stressful. Everyone wants to enjoy each other's company,

you can feel that emotion, the love, the enjoyment. If you carry too much stress and don't enjoy yourself, sometimes you won't be able to give your best.

"You don't want to treat it as work. I say this a lot, as kids, why did we play cricket? Yes, there is a lot at stake, a lot to lose, and the stakes will keep getting higher, but you shouldn't stop enjoying the game and having fun. I think that is something that seems to be missing these days, and if players bring that back, they will be a lot happier."

The franchise enters the new season with renewed ambitions under Pant and head coach Justin Langer, having had an inconsistent run since its debut in 2022.

AGENCIES

IT'S OFFICIAL

Blow for KKR as Rana ruled out of entire IPL

KOLKATA: In a big blow to Kolkata Knight Riders, pacer Harshit Rana was on Friday ruled out of the entire IPL 2026 owing to the ligament injury that he sustained during a warm-up match ahead of the recent T20 World Cup.

The fast bowler suffered a ligament strain in his right knee during India's T20 World Cup warm-up game against South Africa, following which he underwent surgery in February, needing an extensive rehabilitation process.

"It is a big blow because Harshit Rana has been an integral part of this team for the last couple of seasons, also the championship season. Over the last year, he's really grown as a cricketer," KKR head coach Abhishek Nayar said, without giving a confirmed timeline for Rana's return to action.

"We will always miss Harshit Rana, it's not easy to replace him. But over the last few days, we've looked at a few bowlers as to who fits in and who can do that role to the best of their prowess. Hopefully, we'll take a call in a couple of days," Nayar added.

Sri Lankan pacer Matheesha Pathirana's injury has also disturbed KKR's plans ahead of the new season.

"Matheesha Pathirana, who has requested NOC to participate in IPL 2026, is yet to undergo the Physical Performance Test, as he is still undergoing rehabilitation to recover from injury sustained. He will undergo the tests upon completion of the recovery and rehabilitation programs," the Sri Lanka Cricket (SLC) later said in a release.

Navdeep Saini, Akash Madhwal, Simarjeet Singh, Sandeep Warrier and KM Asif are some of the fast bowlers who were seen at the Eden Gardens this



It is a big blow because Harshit Rana has been an integral part of this team for the last couple of seasons

Abhishek Nayar

week, training ahead of the IPL.

The IPL start on March 28, and KKR's campaign starts against Mumbai Indians on March 29, followed by their first home match against Sunrisers Hyderabad on April 2.

As far as Varun Chakravarthy's form is concerned, KKR skipper Ajinkya Rahane believed the break after the T20 World Cup will be good for the spinner, who went for plenty of runs in the mega event at home in February-March.

"I don't see any problem with Varun's bowling ability... In the T20 World Cup, opposition batters played him (Varun Chakravarthy) really well. Let's give credit to them rather than talking about Varun.

"I think this 10-day break really helped him after especially coming after a high-intensity tournament to another high-intensity tournament," Rahane said.

AGENCIES

India women to play one-off Test, three ODIs in SA

JOHANNESBURG: The Indian women's team will play a one-off Test during its tour of South Africa later this year, which will also feature a three-match ODI series, Cricket South Africa (CSA) said on Friday.

CSA said the Test will be held in Gqeberha from December 20 to 23, while the ODIs are scheduled from December 9 to 15 across Potchefstroom, Bloemfontein and Cape Town.

"The Proteas will face India in a three-match ICC Women's Championship (IWC) ODI series from 09-15 December, with the JB Marks Oval in Potchefstroom hosting the series opener before Mangaung Oval in Bloemfontein and the Newlands Cricket Ground stage the second and third matches," CSA said in a statement. "The tour will also include a one-off Test match at St George's Park in Gqeberha from 20-23 December.

"It will be the fourth red-ball contest between the two nations and only the second women's Test match in the Friendly City since South Africa hosted England there in December 1960."

AGENCIES

Iyer targets IPL glory, PBKS focus on bonding ahead of new season

MOHALI: Declaring that his "eye is on the trophy," Shreyas Iyer on Friday said Punjab Kings are focused on building strong camaraderie off the field ahead of the Indian Premier League 2026 season.

Speaking at the franchise's jersey unveiling event in Mohali, Iyer stressed on the importance of team bonding during the early phase of the tournament.

"This is the period where we live as a family for two months. The more time we spend together, the more we get to know each other. Now is the time where we build that camaraderie," Iyer said.

"We spend most of our time in the game room, playing FIFA and other games. The planning and plotting for matches usually happens a day or two before the game, but building this bond off the field helps us get better results eventually," he added.

Punjab Kings will open their campaign in the upcoming season against Gujarat Titans on March 31 at home.

Embracing expectations from fans, who have nicknamed him 'Sarpanch Sahab', Iyer made his ambitions clear.

"Expectations are high, which is fun. I love the chal-



Shreyas Iyer and Co will look to go one better this time

FILE

Punjab will open their campaign in the upcoming season against Gujarat Titans on March 31

lenge. But the important thing is that whenever we step in, we have to win. My eye is on the trophy," he asserted.

The skipper, who has battled injuries in recent times, also reflected on his comeback journey.

"It is always challenging to come back after an injury. I had lost around seven kilos and it

took a lot of effort to gain that weight back. But I love challenges. I am glad I overcame that part of my life, and I am back here proudly representing the team," he said.

Pressure is privilege
Left-arm pacer Arshdeep Singh echoed his captain's confidence, highlighting the role of home support in Mullanpur.

"When you feel the pressure, it is a privilege. It is a lot of fun when you get so much support from the crowd. When people cheer for you, you feel that 30,000 people are running in with you at that time. We will try our best to win all our home matches this year," Arshdeep said.

AGENCIES

Anahat, Tanvi storm into Indian Open squash semi-finals

MUMBAI: Top seed Anahat Singh and unseeded compatriot Tanvi Khanna ensured a strong Indian presence in the women's singles semifinals of the JSW Indian Open after winning their respective quarterfinal matches here on Friday.

However, veteran Joshna Chinappa bowed out of the competition following a 1-3 defeat to Egypt's Nadien El Hammamy.

In another quarterfinal clash, second seed Hana Moataz fought hard to edge past eighth seed Yashmitha Jadishkumar of Malaysia in a five-game thriller, 3-2 (11-8, 8-11, 7-11, 11-7, 11-8).

In the semifinals on Saturday, Anahat will face Tanvi, while Moataz will square off against El Hammamy.

Anahat underlined her status as one of the top contenders for the title with a dominant 3-0 (11-2, 11-6, 11-4) victory over Malaysia's Shevettraa Kumar.

The top seed raced through the opening game with ease, taking it 11-2 without much effort. Kumar offered a stronger challenge in the second game, but Anahat's blend of power and clever deception helped her maintain control and clinch it 11-6.

AGENCIES

MELBOURNE: Four leading Australian pacers, including Pat Cummins, Mitchell Starc and Josh Hazlewood, are set to miss the start of the upcoming Indian Premier League season later this month, dealing an early setback to their respective franchises.

According to a report in cricket.com.au, Starc, Cummins and Hazlewood will miss at least the start of IPL while Nathan Ellis is set to be ruled out of the tournament completely.

The report said Cricket Australia (CA) is taking a cautious approach with their pacers ahead a busy schedule from August that includes 21 Test matches in a 12-month period. Australia will tour South Africa, India and England before defending the ODI World Cup title in 2027.

"The trio's availability will depend on progress in their return to play protocols over the next few weeks," the report said.

Test captain Cummins has featured in only one Test last summer due to a back stress injury, while Hazlewood missed the entire series due to hamstring and Achilles issues.

The duo also missed the T20 World Cup.



Pat Cummins is among them

FILE

Starc played all five Ashes Tests and the back-end of the Big Bash League, but not the T20 World Cup as he has retired from the format.

Australia selector Tony Dodemaide had said that Cummins and Hazlewood's availability for the IPL purely was a "timing issue".

"If it was in reverse, the IPL was first and the World Cup was second, then they'd be missing the IPL to play in the World Cup," said Dodemaide.

"It's not going to be frustrating for us at all. We know their commitment to want to play and succeed for Australia."

Cummins is the captain of Sunrisers Hyderabad, while Starc plays for Delhi Capitals and Hazlewood for Royal Challengers Bengaluru.

AGENCIES

ISL: Mumbai City edge Mohun Bagan

KOLKATA: Noufal PN's first-half strike, backed by a stand-out defensive performance, guided Mumbai City FC to a 1-0 victory over Mohun Bagan Super Giant in their Indian Super League match here on Friday.

Mumbai City FC moved to the top of the standings with this victory, staying unbeaten and going one point clear of Mohun Bagan Super Giant, who slipped to second with 13 points. Phurba Lachenpa was adjudged the Player of the Match for a series of crucial saves.

The contest began at a lively tempo, with Mohun Bagan dominating possession in the early exchanges, while Mumbai City looked to threaten on the counter. Noufal had the first attempt in the sixth minute but fired over from distance after being set up by captain Lallianzuala Chhangte.

The Mariners continued to control the ball, with right winger Liston Colaco seeing his effort blocked by Mumbai City centre-back Nuno Reis in the 19th minute. The Islanders responded with a swift counter-attack three minutes later as Chhangte found himself one-on-one with Vishal Kaith, but the goalkeeper stood firm to deny him before Mehtab Singh cleared the danger.

AGENCIES

Arsenal face City in English League Cup final, which is about so much more

MANCHESTER: When Arsenal and Manchester City lock horns in the English League Cup final on Sunday there will be more at stake than the first domestic silverware of the season.

The trophy is the tangible reward. The intangibles could ripple further, especially on the Premier League title race.

With all due respect, the League Cup would have ranked at the bottom of the priority list for Arsenal and City when the season began. The Premier League and the Champions League would rank at the top and the FA Cup somewhere in between.

The League Cup, however, has taken on greater significance given both finalists' rivalry in the context of the season. The winner at Wembley Stadium could deal the loser a

Gunning for glory



Arsenal will look to pile more misery on Manchester City

AP

huge psychological blow. For Arsenal — top of the table and nine points ahead of City — there would be further confirmation of its superiority over their main title rivals. That

is important for a team that has appeared to have an inferiority complex when it comes to City, after losing the title twice in recent years from commanding positions. For manager Mikel

Arsenal are unbeaten in their last six meetings with Manchester City in all competitions

Arteta, who was once Pep Guardiola's assistant at City, it will be evidence that he can get the better of him when it comes to lifting major trophies.

That is still very much in question, even in a year when Arsenal is vying for an unprecedented quadruple.

Should City triumph on

Sunday there is the danger that the damage to Arsenal's confidence would send its season into a tailspin. That is the sort of psychological impact Guardiola would likely want to inflict: To sow seeds of doubt into an Arsenal team that still has to play City at Etihad Stadium. And with City having a game in hand on Arteta's team, there is the potential that the lead could be down to three points after the match in Manchester. Another intangible is momentum, which at this stage of the campaign is so crucial. City's ambitions have hit some road bumps in recent weeks. Like Arsenal, City were also targeting a quadruple. But back-to-back draws in the league and elimination from in the Champions League have left City with two trophies to play for.

AGENCIES

**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE
APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON**

**See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha
Sanhita, 2023**

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Neelam Tomar D/o Narendren Singh R/o: A-44, Gali No.-1, 1st Pusta, Sonia Vihar, Sabapur, Delhi-94**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 243/2020, U/S 379/403/411/34 IPC, PS Kashmere Gate, North Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Neelam Tomar** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Neelam Tomar** has absconded (or is concealing herself to avoid the service of the said warrant);

Proclamation is hereby made that **Neelam Tomar** the said accused of **FIR No. 243/2020, U/S 379/403/411/34 IPC, PS Kashmere Gate, North Distt., Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **09.06.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Vaibhav Garg
Judicial Magistrate First Class-11,
Central Distt, Court No.-138, 1st Floor,
Tis Hazuri Courts, Delhi

DP/3577/R/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Kasim Ali, S/o Ahmed Ali, R/o 1) F-220, Bawana, JJ Colony, Delhi, 2) H.No. B-69, Phase-1, Holambi Kalan, Delhi, 3) B-3, Phase-1, Metro Vihar, Holambi Kalan, Narela, Delhi, 4) B-90, Phase-1, Metro Vihar, Holambi Kalan, Narela Industrial Area, Delhi, 5) A-533, Metro Vihar, Phase-1, Holambi Kalan, Delhi, 6) F-437, Bawana, JJ Colony, Delhi, 7) Village Sarai Pipariya Dataganj, Badaun, UP-243635** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 17/2018, dated 22.07.2018, U/s 356/379/174A/34 IPC, P.S. Subzi Mandi Railway Station, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Kasim Ali** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Kasim Ali** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Kasim Ali** accused of **FIR No. 17/2018, dated 22.07.2018, U/s 356/379/174A/34 IPC, P.S. Subzi Mandi Railway Station, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **15.05.2026**.

By Order - Sh. Apoorv Gupta
Special Railway Magistrate

DP/3515/Rly/2026 Old Delhi Railway Station Court, Delhi

COURT NOTICE (U/o 5 Rule 20 CPC) (UNDER GUARDIAN AND WARD ACT) IN THE COURT OF Sh. Mohommad Saegee Additional Civil Judge (Senior Division), Rohtak Santosh w/o kalam Singh Vs. General Public CNR No. HRRH02-000327-2020 Next Date 03-04-2026 NOTICE TO: General Public :- India In above titled case, the defendant (s)/ respondent(s) could not be served. It is ordered that defendant(s)/ respondent(s) should appear in person or through counsel on 03-04-2026 at 10:00 am. For details login to https://highcourtrcdg.gov.in/?trs=distrikt notice & distrikt = Rohtak Sd/- Sh. Mohommad Saegee Additional Civil Judge (Senior Division), dated 19.03.2026 Rohtak	COURT NOTICE (U/o 5 Rule 20 CPC) IN THE COURT OF Dr. Mohd. Imtiyaz Khan Civil Judge (Junior Division), Gurugram SYNDICATE BANK Vs. BARUN KUMAR CNR No. HRRG02-000830-2020 Next Date 14-04-2026 PUBLICATION ISSUED TO: BARUN KUMAR FATHER:- BIRDESHWAR HN. 499/28, G N 8, JYOTI PARK, GGM In above titled case, the defendant (s)/ respondent(s) could not be served. It is ordered that defendant(s)/ respondent(s) should appear in person or through counsel on 14.04.2026 at 10:00 am. For details login to https://highcourtrcdg.gov.in/?trs=distrikt notice & distrikt = Gurugram Sd/- Dr. Mohd. Imtiyaz Khan Civil Judge (Junior Division) dated 19-03-2026 Gurugram
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PROCLAMATION REGARDING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person, namely, **Saif Ali, S/o: Iqbal Ahmed, R/o: House No. E-16/B-181, Seelampur, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 115/2016, U/s: 392/411/34 IPC**, registered at **P.S.: Welcome, Delhi**, and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused person, **Saif Ali**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person, **Saif Ali**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said, accused person, **Saif Ali, FIR No. 115/2016, U/s: 392/411/84 IPC**, registered at **P.S.: Welcome, Delhi**, is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **23.04.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Deepakshi Rana, LD
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
Room No. 19, First Floor, Distt. Shahdara
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/3598/NE/2026
(Court Matter)

NORTHERN RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE

Invitation for Tenders through E-procurement system

Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tender through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-

S. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
1.	02252517	SMF VRLA BATTERY 110V/120Ah	104 SET	08.04.26
2.	15250080	COMPLETE RADIATOR ASSEMBLY	7 NOS	13.04.26
3.	02261425	ELECTRONIC RECTIFIER CUM REGULATING UNIT	64 NOS	20.04.26

Note:-1.Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details. 2.No manual offer will be entertained.

Tender Notice No. 95/2025-2026 Dt. 20.03.2026



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Regional Office (Gurugram)
1398, First Floor, Chandni Chowk,
Delhi-110006. Tel: 011-41028985

E-AUCTION
SALE NOTICE
(Under SARFAESI Act 2002)

APPENDIX- IV-A [SEE PROVISO TO RULE 8(6) & 9(1) SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF MOVABLE/IMMOVABLE ASSET]

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Movable/Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) & 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the borrower(s) and guarantor(s) that the below described movable property mortgaged / charged to the secured creditor, the **Physical / Symbolic Possession** of which have been taken by the Authorized Officer of **Central Bank of India**, secured creditors, will be sold on **10.04.2026 "As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is"** basis for recovery of dues to the Central Bank of India from below mention Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s). The Reserve Price and earnest money deposit (EMD) is displayed against the details of respective properties. For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided in: www.centralbankofindia.co.in or (<https://BAANKNET.com>)

DESCRIPTION OF PROPERTIES TO BE AUCTIONED ON 10.04.2026 (15 DAYS NOTICE)
Amount In Rupees

S. No.	Name of Branch	Authorised Officer/R.A.	Name of the Account	Description of Assets & Name of the Owner	Demand Notice Date & Amount Dues (Rs. in Lakhs)	Date & Type of Possession	Reserve Price EMD Bid Increase
1.	Vasant Kunj New Delhi	Mr. Rahul Mehta MOBILE: 9811040603 (Resolution Agent)	MRS. SONIA WALIA W/O RONNIE WALIA Vehicle Loan A/c. No. 5281732185	FOUR WHEELER MAHINDRATHAR Model No.- THAR LX D AT4WD 45 CT Registration No. DL110CU3200 Chassis No.: MA1JU4YF7N2F18084 Engine No.: YFN4F53775, Colour: Red Rage, Month-Year of Manufacturing: 06/2022 Fuel Type : Diesel Owner:- Mrs. Sonia Walia W/o Mr. Ronnie Walia	13(2) Notice Date: 09.01.2025 Rs.13,44,570.08 as on 09.01.2025 + Interest & Other Charges thereon	06.09.2025 (Physical Possession)	₹ 8,00,000.00 ₹ 80,000.00
1.	Naraina New Delhi	Mr. Peeyush Pushpam Mobile: 8800013528	Satish Kumar Singh and Poonam Singh	Residential Property bearing No. B-1/5 & First Floor Back Side Portion, Without Roof / Terrace Rights, Area measuring 50 Sq Yards, Situated in the area of Village- Palam, Colony known as Rajapuri, Gali No.- 5, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi- 110059, Owner- Mrs. Poonam Singh W/o Mr. Satish Kumar Singh and Mr. Satish Kumar Singh S/o Mr. Tej Bahadur Singh	13(2) Notice Date: 18.12.2025 Rs.11,26,590.45 as on 18.12.2025 + Interest & Other Charges thereon	28.06.2025 (Physical Possession)	₹ 16,00,000.00 ₹ 1,60,000.00 ₹ 15,000.00

E-AUCTION DATE: 10.04.2026, TIME: 12:00 NOON TO 4:00 PM WITH AUTO EXTENSION OF 10 MINUTES

Last Date & Time of Submission of EMD and Documents (Online) On or Before: 10.04.2026 Upto 3:30 PM. Bidder will register on website: (<https://BAANKNET.com>) and upload KYC documents and after verification of KYC documents by the service provider, EMD to be deposited in Global EMD Wallet through NEFT/RTGS/Transfer (after generation of challan from (<https://BAANKNET.com>)).

The auction will be conducted through the Bank's approved service provider ["https://BAANKNET.com"](https://BAANKNET.com) E-auction will be held on **"As is where is", "As is what is" and "whatever there is"** basis. (All other charges/dues to the property will be borne by the purchaser).

For detailed terms and conditions please refer to the link provided in www.centralbankofindia.co.in Secured Creditor or Auction Platform (<https://BAANKNET.com>) **BAANKNET** Helpdesk: (+91) 8291202020, E-mail: support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com

NOTICE FOR SUB STATUTORY 15 DAY'S SALE NOTICE UNDER RULE 8(6) & 9(1) OF SARFAESI ACT 2002

The borrowers/guarantors/ mortgagors are hereby notified to pay the sum as mentioned above along with upto date interest and ancillary expenses before the date of e-auction, failing which the property will be auctioned/sold and balance dues, if any, will be recovered with interest and cost.

DATE: 20.03.2026

PLACE: DELHI

Authorised Officer, CENTRAL BANK OF INDIA,
Regional Office (Gurugram) Chandni Chowk, Delhi

Sr. No.	Tender No. and Due Date	Description	Quantity (Nos./Sets/ Cum)	EMD (Rs.)
1.	17261078 10/04/2026	SUPPLY & APPLICATION OF SET OF ROOF AND ENDWALL PANELS IN LHB HIGH CAPACITY PARCEL VAN COACHES	31 Set	1,09,050/-
2.	14261001A 10/04/2026	SOUND INSULATING WOOD PANELS.	1801 Nos.	2,17,030/-
3.	17261058 15/04/2026	AIR INLET DUCT FOR LHB PANTRY CAR	53 Nos.	2,18,890/-
4.	05261182A 24/04/2026	UNDERFRAME COMPLETE FOR LHB HIGH CAPACITY PARCEL VAN.	16 Nos.	NIL
5.	05261047 17/04/2026	SUPPLY AND APPLY (INSTALLATION, COMMISSIONING & TESTING) OF 3-TYPES OF AXLE MOUNTED DISC BRAKE SYSTEMS WITH EP ASSIST BRAKE SYSTEMS FOR AMRIT BHARAT COACHES	426 Set	50,00,000/-
6.	05261179 17/04/2026	Set of Partition Frame	64 Set	3,39,220/-
7.	05251688A 22/04/2026	SET OF LONGITUDINAL BEAM	47 Set	1,17,530/-
8.	04261018 07/04/2026	Ferritic Steel Sheet	203121 Kgs	7,33,430/-
9.	02621023 14/04/2026	C.D.S.I.C. MAINTENANCE MANUALS, SPARES & MAINTENANCE WORK OF ONBOARD CONDITION MONITORING SYSTEM (OBCCMS)	64 Set	12,80,940/-

1. For details and making On-line bids, visit [Website http://ireps.gov.in](http://ireps.gov.in) Drawings/specifications, wherever required can be downloaded from RCF Website <http://www.rcf.indianrailways.gov.in>. Class II-B digital signature certificate required for on-line bidding, can be obtained from licensed certifying agencies listed at <http://www.cce.gov.in>, 2. Tenders will close at 14.25 HRS. on due date and Tender will be opened at 14.30 HRS for Sr. No. 1 to 4 at RCF Kapurthala and for Sr. No. 5 to 9 at Tilak Bridge, New Delhi-110012, 3. For queries, contact IREPS Helpdesk at 011-24102855, 011-24105180 or RCF helpdesk at 011-23378658.

PCMM

CORRIGENDUM

1) Tender No.: 05251947, Description: SET OF PIPE SEALING ARRGT., Due Date to be read as "30/03/2026" instead of "12/03/2026", 2) Tender No.: 17261006, Due Date to be read as "30/03/2026" instead of "19/03/2026", 3) Tender No.: 17261004, Due Date to be read as "30/03/2026" instead of "19/03/2026", 4) Tender No.: 13255417, Description: CNC AXLE TURNING LATHE, Due Date to be read as "27/03/2026" instead of "16/03/2026", 5) Tender No.: 14251110A, Due Date to be read as "27/03/2026" instead of "16/03/2026", 6) Tender No.: 12251370, Description: SUPPLY OF ONE COACH SET OF LOOK OUT AND OTHER GLASSES FOR TRAIN 18 DTC COACHES, Due Date to be read as "20/03/2026" instead of "17/03/2026", 7) Tender No.: 05261093, Description: SET OF PIPE SEALING KIT FOR LAVATORY OF, Tender Closing Date & Time to be read as "30/03/2026 11:30" instead of "16/03/2026 11:30", 8) Tender No.: 05251643, Description: SET OF UNDER FRAME ITEMS FOR LHB SCN COACHES., Due Date to be read as "02/04/2026" instead of "18/03/2026"

PCMM

No. 143-S/2025-26	Date: 20.03.2026
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DELHI TRANS CO. LTD.

NOTICE INVITING e-TENDERS

Delhi Transco Ltd (A Government of NCT of Delhi Undertaking) invites online tender, for the following work:

Tender No.T25P090671: Design, Supply, Erection, Testing, Commissioning of 04 Nos. 25 MVA, 33/11 kV Transformer including dismantling of existing 02 Nos. 20 MVA and 02 Nos. 16 MVA, Transformers with associated civil work at 220 kV Sub-Station, Lodhi Road on turnkey basis (Risk & Cost Purchase basis).

For complete details of the tender please visit following websites :-
<https://govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in>

(Tender ID No. 2026_DTL_288852_1) and www.dtl.gov.in with Unique No. DTL-9940-190326.

Last date for bid submission: **08.05.2026 at 01.30 P.M.**

All Corrigendum/Addendum/ Amendments/Date of Extension/Clarifications etc. to this e-tender will be hosted on the above website only. Bidders should regularly visit website to keep themselves updated.



NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Tendering Tender Notice

Date: 17.03.2026

Sr. Divisional Signal & Telecommunication Engineer/Jhansi, DRM's office, Jhansi, for and on behalf of President of India invite open Tender through on Line (**E-Tendering**) for the following works.

E-Tender No.: JHS-N-W-20-26	Approx Cost : Rs. 18887704.71
Description of work : Provision of Data entry terminal for Signaling Maintenance Management system (SMMS) over Jhansi Division.	
Earnest Money : Rs. 244400/-	Cost of Tender form : Nil

Opening of tender : 09.04.2026 Time 15:00

Completion period from issue of letter of acceptance : 09 Months

- Tender on line can be submitted upto 15:00 hrs on 09.04.2026.
- For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in. (NORTH CENTRAL RLY/JHANSI DIVISION S AND T) 609/26 (D)

 North central railways
 @ CPRONCR
 www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

**PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE
APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON**

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Sandeep @Babu** S/o Late Sh. Sukhdev Nath R/o B-85 DDA Slam Flat Jahangirpuri, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 21/2021 U/s 325 IPC, PS Paschim Vihar West, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Sandeep @Babu** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sandeep @Babu** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Sandeep @Babu** in **FIR No. 21/2021 U/s 325 IPC, PS Paschim Vihar West, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **23.04.2026**.

By order
Shri Ankit Karan Singh
Metropolitan Magistrate-08
West, Room No. 30
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/3426/OD/2026

 NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY	
Tender Notice No: 118202502026-262	Dated: 17.03.2026
E-TENDERING TENDER NOTICE	
Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering) / North Central Railway / Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-TENDERS on prescribed form for the following work up to 13.30 hrs on 10.04.2026 The details of the Tender are as under-	
S.No.: 1	Tender No: 262
Name of Works: Carrying out ultrasonic testing of Flash Butt Welded joints by using Phased Array Ultrasonic testing (PAUT) on all types of Rails in Prayagraj Division under DEN/TRACK/PRYJ.	
Approx Cost (Rs.): ₹ 39549375/-	Completion Period: 12 Months (Twelve Months)
Earnest Money (Rs.): ₹ 791000/-	Date of Opening of Tender: 10.04.2026
Eligibility Criteria for similar work: (1) Firm shall have RDSO verified PAUT weld tester. (2) Firm shall have RDSO certified USFD operators for weld testing by conventional UT method as described in IRS-T-53. In addition to above, the operator should have competency certificate issued by OEM after completing requisite training for operation and data analysis of Phased Array ultrasonic weld tester. (3) Firm shall have RDSO verified Quality Assurance Plan (QAP) for ultrasonic testing of FB welds by Phased Array ultrasonic weld tester. (4) The PAUT weld tester proposed to be used by firm on IR network should be in service on some other Railway network for USFD testing of Flash Butt (FB) welds and should have carried out USFD testing of at least 5000 FB welds with satisfactory performance. Firm shall submit a certificate of satisfactory performance of USFD testing of 5000 FB welds in this regard. (5) Original Equipment Manufacturer (OEM) firms shall be eligible to participate in the tender. However, in case the OEM firm is not located in India, any Authorized Indian service provider or representative can participate in the tender.	
Note: (1) Tender on line can be submitted up to 13.30 hrs. of tender opening date. (2) For full details and submission of tenders, please see the Indian Railway Website www.irreps.gov.in	
614/26(A)	



‘Taking things step by step’

Aditya Rawal talks about his acting career

Aditya Rawal, who has garnered acclaim for his nuanced performance in Hansal Mehta’s ‘Faraaz’ and most recently in Suresh Triveni’s ‘Subedaar’ opposite Anil Kapoor, said he is seeking versatility in his career.

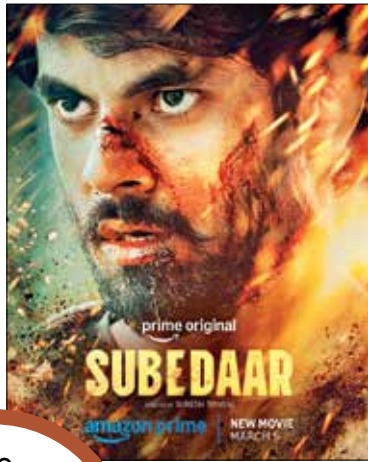
The 32-year-old actor, son of actors Paresh Rawal and Swaroop Sampat, debuted in 2020 with the ‘ZEE5’ original film ‘Bumfaad’ and was most recently seen in ‘Daldal’, an OTT series and ‘Subedaar’.

“It feels great that people have liked my work. But I don’t necessarily see it as carving out a niche for myself. The idea is simply to take things step by step, choose the right projects, collaborate with the right people and audition for the right roles. Each project builds on itself. My goal is always to choose work that interests me and try to remain as versatile as possible,” Aditya told PTL.

The actor said all his upcoming projects are different from his past work. “I’m doing Hansal Mehta sir’s ‘Gandhi’ and that’s miles away from what I did in ‘Faraaz’ with him,” the actor said.

While audiences have mostly seen him in intense roles so far, Aditya said he is keen to do comedy next.

In ‘Subedaar’, the actor plays the role of Prince, who he describes as a flamboyant, unpredictable



The 32-year-old actor was most recently seen in ‘Daldal’ and ‘Subedaar’

and unapologetically attention-seeking man. The audience’s response has amused him. “I’ve never enjoyed people telling me they hate me,” he said, adding that he is also happy that his actor parents, Paresh Rawal and Swaroop Sampat, have liked his recent work.

The conversations at home are more analytical, Aditya said. “We often analyse our work for hours after watching it. Like, my father particularly enjoyed my work in ‘Daldal’, while my mother loved ‘Subedaar’.”

‘Subedaar’ marks his second collaboration with director Suresh Triveni after the OTT series ‘Daldal’, which was released on January 30. Aditya, who began his journey in the industry as a writer in 2017 with a short film, ‘The Mailbox’, said his collaboration with Triveni began as a writing partnership and later the director pitched him the idea of ‘Subedaar’ and ‘Daldal’, created by Triveni and directed by Amrit Raj Gupta.

“He saw my first film ‘Bumfaad’ and said, ‘I want to work with you’. We started writing something together. ‘Faraaz’ came out and he enjoyed my work, then he told me about ‘Subedaar,’” said the actor. PTL

Babil remembers late Irrfan Khan in emotional post

The late actor was battling a rare neuroendocrine tumour since 2018

Babil Khan shared throwback pictures on social media as he remembered his late father and notable cinema star, Irrfan Khan.

Irrfan, known for his acclaimed performances in films such as ‘Slumdog Millionaire’, ‘The Lunchbox’ and ‘Hindi Medium’, died on April 29 in Mumbai, aged 53. The late actor was battling a rare neuroendocrine tumour since 2018.

Babil uploaded his childhood pictures on his ‘Instagram’ handle on Thursday, which featured him alongside the late actor. “To begin again, remembering you. With my feet planted firm in my roots,” he wrote in the caption.

Babil, who fol-

lowed in his father’s footsteps to become an actor, made his acting debut in 2022 with Netflix’s psychological drama ‘Qala’, which also starred Triptii Dimri.

He often shares unseen posts with Irrfan on social media.

Besides his notable work in Hindi cinema, Irrfan also featured in Hollywood projects, including ‘The Warrior’, ‘Life of Pi’ and ‘Jurassic World’, among others. PTL

Babil uploaded his childhood pictures on his ‘Instagram’ handle, which featured him alongside the late actor



Samanvaya: Dialogues in Contemporary Indian Art

The India International Centre (IIC) presents a new exhibition, titled ‘Samanvaya: Line, Colour, Form - Dialogues in Contemporary Indian Art’. Curated by Jyoti A Kathpalia, the group exhibition is presented by Delhi Art Society, with participants Aashima Mehrotra, Alka Jhamb, Anand Moy Banerji, Aniruddh Sagar and many others exhibiting their artworks.

‘Samanvaya’ is a Sanskrit word meaning coordination, harmony, synthesis or reconciliation. In philosophical discourse, it refers to the process of reaching an agreement between different, even seemingly contradictory positions, into a coherent unity, while allowing each element to retain its uniqueness and distinct identity. It signifies both material coordination and order, as well as a spiritual integration.

With this philosophical concept in mind, ‘Samanvaya: Line, Colour, Form’ brings together diverse contemporary art practices: painting, printmaking, sculpture and others. The participating artists are among the most senior and eminent practitioners, with careers and contributions to Indian art spanning over decades.



participating artists are among the most senior and eminent practitioners, with careers and contributions to Indian art spanning over decades.

As the title implies, the exhibition becomes a material, spatial, emotional and ontological anchoring of artistic expression, while remaining in continuous dialogue with the self, society and the evolving public sphere. MPOST

BOX OFFICE COLLECTION

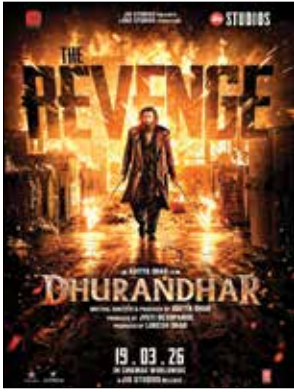
‘Dhurandhar 2’ delivers record-breaking opening

Aditya Dhar’s ‘Dhurandhar 2’, starring Ranveer Singh as an undercover spy in Pakistan, has broken many records to deliver one of the biggest openings in Indian cinema with an estimated earning of over Rs 100 crore on the first day of its release.

The film earned over Rs 43 crore from paid previews on Wednesday, the highest ever for an Indian film and Rs 102.55 crore on its opening day on Thursday, bringing its total India earnings to around Rs 145 crore, according to early estimates by trade tracking website ‘Sacnilk’.

The makers are expected to update the official figures later in the day. Still, the film has already surpassed the opening day numbers of recent Hindi blockbusters - Shah Rukh Khan’s ‘Jawan’ (Rs 75 crore) and ‘Pathaan’ (Rs 57 crore), as well as horror-comedy ‘Stree 2’ (Rs 54 crore).

The worldwide collection of the movie is expected to cross the figure of Rs 200 crore, given the buzz surrounding the release of the sec-



The film earned Rs 102.55 crore on its opening day on Thursday

ond part after the massive success of ‘Dhurandhar’.

‘Dhurandhar 2’ opened in cinemas on the back of record advance bookings with over 15 lakh tickets sold. PTL

THAAI KIZHAVI

She Gave Them the Gold. Not the Game

In ‘Thaai Kizhavi’, a dying moneylender becomes the center of a village’s greed. But beneath the scramble for gold lies a quieter story about how women inherit wealth without ever being taught how it works

DARSHIM SAXENA

The entire village waits for an old woman to die. Her sons are already dividing the gold. Their wives have sold their own ornaments to fund the search. A man in white shows up claiming to know exactly how much she has hidden. A doctor is flown in from the city, not to treat her, but to decode her unconscious hand gestures like they’re a treasure map.

And Pavunithaayi, the aged moneylender at the heart of ‘Thaai Kizhavi’, just lies there. Saying nothing. Then she wakes up. And she gives them an answer so small, so ordinary, that you almost miss what just happened. Watch her face when she says it. Because the film then quietly shows you what she actually knew and for how long. She was never the object of this story. She was running it.

The detail that got me most wasn’t gold. It was the ‘pallanguzhi’. She mentions, almost in passing, that she learned the game after marriage, handed to her like a household chore. But she looked at this little game of distributing seeds across pits, of knowing when to hold and when to collect and she taught herself how money works. Nobody showed her. She figured it out from what little she was given.

That’s who she is. Someone who builds a philosophy inside the constraints of her own life and tells no one. There’s a glass cold drink bottle on a hill near the village. Hers. She’d been going there alone, probably for years, to a place that looked oddly like a deity, maybe because it was. The bottle is a city thing, out of place in a rural landscape, which means she was carrying both worlds



Pavunithaayi smiles, fully aware of the game everyone else is still trying to learn

OF WEALTH & GREED

Film: Thaai Kizhavi

Language: Tamil

Year: 2026

Director: Sivakumar Murugesan

Cast: Radikaa Sarathkumar (Pavunithaayi / Pavunithaayi), Singampuli, Aruldoss, Munishkanth, Bala Saravanan, Ilavarasu, George Maryan, Muthukumar, Raichal Rabecca

Genre: Comedy Drama/Rural Drama

Runtime: 142 minutes

Release: Theatrical (February 27, 2026)

In ‘Thaai Kizhavi’, wealth moves from one woman to another, but knowledge doesn’t

up that hill quietly, by herself. Nobody knew she had gone or even thought about asking. The bottle is the only evidence.

When she finally distributes her gold to the women of the village, it feels like a victory. She says she was free at 60, she hopes her daughter will be

free sooner and she dreams of women born free. It’s a beautiful speech. But then the women wear the gold to a wedding and something in you sinks a little. She gave them the capital. Not the game.

The film knows this. It ends with Pavunithaayi smiling at the top of the frame, a monkey eating the god’s food above her, the same gentle chaos carrying on as always. Nothing is resolved or ruined. She gave what she could, knowing it wasn’t enough and smiled anyway.

Darshim Saxena writes on cinema and culture

‘PANCHAYAT’ S5, HRITHIK ROSHAN’S ‘MESS’ & ‘DAHAAD’ S2 ANNOUNCED

OUR CORRESPONDENT

From the return of popular franchises like ‘Farzi’ Season 2, ‘Panchayat’ Season 5, ‘Dahaad’ Season 2, to new titles like Nikkhil Advani’s magnum opus ‘The Revolutionaries’ or India’s first Hindi homegrown superhero series, ‘Vansh: The Kalyug Warriors’, ‘Prime Video’ on Thursday unveiled its biggest new ‘Originals’. Close to 55 series and movies were announced. Anchored by an expansive ‘Indian Originals’ lineup, alongside the announcement of theatrical films from ‘Amazon MGM Studios India’ and some of the biggest licensed titles, the upcoming multi-language slate promises to entertain customers at every viewing touchpoint, from streaming to cinema.

The slate features compelling ‘Original’ series and movies in Hindi, Tamil and Telugu, spanning a wide range of genres across both scripted and unscripted storytelling. The lineup introduces several highly anticipated new titles, including Nikkhil Advani’s ‘The Revolutionaries’ starring Bhuvan Bam, Rohit Saraf,



Pratibha Ranta and Gurfateh Pirzada; ‘Matka King’ starring Vijay Varma; ‘Raakhi’ starring Ali Fazal, Sonali Bendre and Aamir Bashir; ‘Lukkhe’, which marks the acting debut of rapper KING and ‘Vansh: The Kalyug Warriors’, India’s first Hindi homegrown superhero series created for streaming.

Alongside these new launches, the slate also brings back new seasons of some of India’s most loved

franchises, including ‘Farzi’ Season 2, ‘Panchayat’ Season 5, ‘Call Me Bae’ Season 2, ‘Dupahiya’ Season 2, ‘Dahaad’ Season 2 and ‘The Traitors’ Season 2, among others.

Expanding its regional storytelling with the biggest slate yet, the lineup includes major launches such as the Telugu adaptation of the hit Hindi unscripted series ‘The Traitors’ with Teja Sajja as host; ‘Guvvala Chervu Ghat’, a Telugu drama starring Kiran Abbavaram and Thiruveer, as well as the Tamil drama ‘Exam’, Season 2 of ‘Vadhan-dhi’ produced by Pushkar and Gayatri and Season 2 of ‘Inspector Rishi’, to name a few.

The slate also introduces an array of new strategic collaborations for ‘Prime Video’ - Hrithik Roshan’s ‘HRX Films’, making its foray into streaming with ‘Original’ series ‘Storm’ and ‘Original’ movie ‘Mess’ and Alia Bhatt’s ‘Eternal Sunshine

The slate features compelling ‘Original’ series and movies in Hindi, Tamil and Telugu

